The only ability I got in a another world "Return by Death"
I die again and again to save her.

The Author
Tappei Nagatsuki

The Illustrator
Shinichirou Otsuka

Re:IF

Starting Life in Another World
Accumulating Life in Another World

The only ability I got in a another world "Return by Death"
I die again and again to save her.
The Author
Tappei Nagatsuki
The Illustrator
Shinichirou Otsuka
Re:IF
Starting Life in Another World
Accumulating Life in Another World

Foreword

Re:IF: Repeating Life in Another World from Zero (Ｒｅ：IFから始める異世界生活　ゼロカラカサネルイセカイセイカツ), otherwise known as Re:IF: Greed or Greed IF, is a special volume written by Tappei Nagatsuki that was released on October 19, 2021.

As for the chapters themselves, I've tried to change as little as possible in each translation, only fixing obvious grammar mistakes and standardizing the formatting.

If you find any mistakes, please let me know in my discord.

That's it for now,
Eminent

Document Compiled and Edited by: Eminent (Eminent Translations)
Translation by: Ringo & Ice (HTL); Kazatashi & GioGioCat (MTL) with proofreading by Cirdan Lunae and Hydra
Typesetting by: Shido Itsuka
eBook Version: 1.01
Released on June 15, 2025
Last Updated on November 3, 2025

Table of Contents

Cover
Foreword
Table of Contents
Prologue I: The Shield of the Sanctuary
Chapter I: Accumulating Life in Another World from Zero with a Witch
Prologue II: The Witchbeast Master
Chapter II: Accumulating Life in Another World from Zero with a Witch
Prologue III: The Versatile Steward
Chapter III: Accumulating Life in Another World from Zero with a Witch
Prologue IV: The Progeny of the Lion King
Chapter IV: Accumulating Life in Another World from Zero with a Witch
Afterword
Closing Dialogue

PROLOGUE I:

THE SHIELD OF THE SANCTUARY

—Roaring, he swung his claws toward the enemy surging from the environs.

???: “Gaahhhh—!!”

Their soft bodies burst open upon getting ensnared in his claws, his field of vision dyed with blood of a brilliant crimson hue.

The sensation of robbing the life of a living creature, despite being accustomed to it, could have never been enjoyable. Though he felt the hunting instincts seated within him galvanize, it was far from indulgence.

However, he immersed himself during these moments, forgetting said value of life and virtues.

If not, he shall be swallowed by the enemy—no, by the fiendish, multitudinous “Appetite” advancing from every direction, and fail to hold fast to even his own life.

???: “Shiiihk!”

A wrathful bellow, swinging his claws with no set aim, unleashing kicks. He still hit. It hit them. Ahead of his arms, by his shins, rebounded the dull sensation of shattering the bones of a tiny being.

Nauseating. However, forsaking all sentimentality, he bared his fangs in enmity, losing himself.

???: “…”

He was in a wrought state. For as long as time permitted, he had tormented his own body with pain.

Weakness was a sin. His self, had once lost what he held close to his heart due to this sin. Neither was he able to grasp an opportunity to never release what he cherished. That was why, for when an identical opportunity returned, or in order to not lose anything more, he sought the utmost of limits.

He could not, render those days futile. His self, was no longer his weak self. In order to prove that, sojourning an emotion akin to vomiting blood, he smashed, incised, tore apart the tiny lives.

The dusky forest of the night was tainted with blood. He felt the volume of this flowing blood, to be the fruits of the days he had accreted—

???: “—Urgh.”

A sharp ache running through, his right calf burst open by scorching heat.

Look there and the fangs of a white ball of fur had been wolfing his leg, severing the flesh with not an instant's worth of vacillation. He gnashed his molars and swung his right arm down like a sword, slaughtering the ball of fur into two slices.

However, he could not end this spar out of agony. In spite of robbing the life of the enemy, he had lost the firm support of his leg. Curtailment of mobility, in this battlefield, meant immediately shortening the distance to Death.

—Death, the instant he focused on that word, shivers ran through his entire frame.

???: "—This ain't, no goddamn joke!!"

He did not want to think of these shivers as fear or dismay.

Raising his voice as though repudiating his weak self and shoving aside the thoughts coming to his mind, he elevated his wounded right leg overhead and energetically pounded it into the ground.

That moment, an immense power was invoked below his feet, and the soil and bare earth were vigorously overturned.

Entire hordes of fluffballs within five meters of his tiptoes were all toppled by the rising ground, many dozens of them giving rise to death wails as their bodies were crushed and perished.

???: "Now—"

???: "—Kyuuuhn."

However, he was bestowed not even the time to be elated with triumph. Paying no heed to the entombing of dozens of their fellow comrades in the horde, the enemy's fervor was not withered by even an atom. —No, rather than wither, saying it had augmented would also be appreciable. But, he was unable to identify any change in the horde charging towards his side.

The advancing white fluffballs, felt no rage, turmoil, or anything for that matter toward their comrades' deaths. With simply a blazing glimmer conceived in their eyes, befitting of fulfilling the desires of the individual, they clattered their fangs.

Clanging, clanking, clunking, clinking, an infinite harmony of the sound of devouring life, abrading his spirit.

???: "—~hk."

Faintly clearing his throat, he pounded his legs whilst seeking to fall back. What would happen should he fall back now. By falling back, and bracing his stance, just want would that amount to—

???: "—I suppose by now, you must've gotten how crazy the enemy is, right, Garfiel."

Garfiel: "—~hk! Shut yer mouth! Shut the hell up ~hk!"

He reflexively yelled back at the voice abruptly thrown at him from behind.

Lit with the flame of rebelliousness was the fighting spirit momentarily yielding to reason, subsequently repelling the surging vanguard of furballs with a barrage of fists, as by the spray of blood the forest was yet again tinted. Tinted. Tinted—.

???: “That amounts to nothing but buying time. They need to be dealt with from the source.”

Garfiel: “For the last goddamn time, I’m tellin’ ya ta shut the hell up! I ain’t listenin’ to yer directions, ya bastard!”

Upon getting preached by a visage indicating knowledge and experience, he howled back that nobody shall lend their ears to his say. Even should that advice hold accurate, he could never harbor the faith of entrusting his life to the one who offered the advice.

Never could he ever do so, at the very least, for the black haired youth spectating the battle from behind.

Garfiel: “—Piece of shit.”

With the gaze verging onto a sigh at his back, the battle with the white furballs resumed.

What he bore for the onlooker youth standing in the rear was distrust, and a sense of defeat excoriating his chest which he did not wish to admit. The resentment he directed towards his own self for having his state become per the youth’s anticipation, per his words, a maelstrom of rage.

—The crisis imminent upon the Sanctuary, one of the Three Great Witchbeasts, was something beyond what his hands could possibly manage.

Repudiating such seeming folly, he had entered the subjugation paying no heed.

However, the slaves of ceaselessly gushing “Appetite”, their overwhelming numbers and ruthlessness had waged a war of attrition as though sneering at his recklessness.

His wounds were deep. The Divine Protection of Earth Spirits that dwelled within his body accorded strength but could not heal wounds. He possessed no time, to use healing magic. Nor did he possess any comrades who would buy said time, nor did he possess any means to keep the enemy away.

He was alone. He was lonely. And that was something wished for by nobody but him.

That should he alone be strong, he would be able to protect everything till the very end. In order to make that childish illusion into reality, he had continued to train these fangs, these claws, this body.

And yet, and yet, and yet—

???: “It’s beyond you to be able to do everything alone, Garfiel.”

Delegating even the rage to retort with a “Shut up” into his fangs, he smote the enemies before him.

Their soft bodies shattered, flowers of blood blossomed before his eyes. Eating the fluffball now a slice of meat, another fluffball approached. The fluffballs he had assuredly crushed quavered, and multiplied into two like magic.

In an identical vein, the more he crushed the fluffballs, the more they multiplied. No matter how much he abated them, diminished them, they shan’t decrease.

Despair, distended within his chest. It felt as though it was being pronounced for him, that the entirety of the days he had spent until now had been futile, that illusions remained nothing but illusions.

—Warm tears of bitterness cascaded down his eyes, as he pierced them with his quivering fangs, and tore their flesh apart.

CHAPTER I:

ACCUMULATING LIFE IN ANOTHER WORLD FROM ZERO WITH A WITCH

1

???: "—Stay put right here. Do that, 'n I won't be makin' ya suffer."

Dealt by the intemperate voice, Natsuki Subaru realized his error.

Limbs tied, mouth gagged, he was thrown upon the solid, chilly floor.

Having been blindfolded so courteously, he could gather zero information from his vision. However, vision was not necessary for him to know which location in the Sanctuary this was.

For this was not the first time he had been restrained and confined in the ruins in this manner.

Subaru: "~~hk! ~~hk."

Twisting his body, he became desperate to unfasten the constraints on his limbs, but they seemed not to come loose even in the slightest.

On the other hand, he was feeling surprised by the unexpected meticulousness of the offender since it was serving to strangle his own neck. Right now he wished to implore said person to behave more wildly, the way he ordinarily conducted himself.

Anyhow—since things had come down to this, there was not much left Subaru could do.

There was no scenario of him breaking out with his own strength and the pattern of support arriving depends on preparation. And this time, Subaru had not laid the groundwork for said support to arrive.

Thus, Subaru did not possess the means to escape from here.

Subaru: "~~hk! ~~hk."

However, Subaru had not become so resigned as to give up and think nothing can be done.

Hands tied behind his back, he twisted his body, attempting to sever the rope by rubbing it against the ground. With half hearted resolve, worrying for his own body, making a bunch of scratches was the best he could do.

Had he wielded the guts to whittle down his own flesh, or even his bones, perhaps he would have been able to escape from these constraints.

However—

???: "…"

Atop the floor, as Subaru danced like a caterpillar, the sensation of a tiny hand pin him down.

It was obvious that this was the person who had confined Subaru—Garfiel's cooperator, and clearly a being exactly identical to Ryuzu.

An existence who could be called, without hesitation, a "duplicate".

Puppets who took the form of Ryuzu, who simply abided by Garfiel, devoid of any will. It saw to the confined Subaru's everyday necessities, simultaneously fulfilling the duty of surveilling him.

Even if his constraints were to come loose, then would come the issue of her—no, them? Should he be discovered by them, it would be short lived joy. He would immediately be restrained again, with no hope to escape. Likely, this would happen even if he were to escape the constraints with the resolve to whittle down his own limbs.

—In other words, this conclusion was an inevitable one.

Subaru: "—?"

The time of being given food by a mute duplicate and having his excrements disposed of continued for a number of days.

During meal time, when the gag would be removed, he believed there might be a chance for a counter attack. But that too, was easily restrained by small hands of the duplicate.

In order to escape, he desperately thought up his next plan, when…

—In that moment he began to hear grinding and a dissonance that called out to his instinct.

Subaru: "—~hk."

Guessing the identity of those sounds, anxiety and nervousness sprinted through his entire frame.

That which initially had been few in numbers, gradually built up their numbers and formed hordes, and was drawing near. No point in shrinking himself up and hiding somewhere. Their olfaction—the ability to sniff out the mana stockpiled by living beings was remarkable, and had converged as their singular purpose.

Namely, the purpose of utterly eating away their prey, and satisfying their own "Starvation".

Subaru: "~~hk!"

Limbs bound, blindfolded, and mouth gagged, he crawled on the floor akin to a caterpillar.

Bending his body back and forth, pulling the muscles within his body, unafraid of tearing them, he attempted to run away. Running away, running away, running away,

dwelling not on what lies ahead. Simply running away, however—

Subaru: "~~hk, ~~hk?!"

He could not get away at literal crawling speeds.

Caught up by the prancing predators, Subaru's legs were eaten by a scorching like pain. In a matter of mere seconds, he felt the restraints of his legs he had so attempted to escape from come undone, but that gave him no delight.

It was meaningless, since along with the constraints of his legs, all up to Subaru's knees had also disappeared.

He attempted to screech, but his mouth gag did not permit it. A groan as though vomiting blood in agony, the reason he managed to vocalize that was because the devouring fangs had crunched apart a section of his throat and opened a hole.

It was a shriek lasting but a moment, as soon a tiny creature penetrated into his body from the wound in his throat. One, two, at any rate, an infinite number of them, Natsuki Subaru was devoured from the inside and out.

Couldn't make it in time, never did any such regrets graze past his mind.

Solely pain. The sense of loss from losing himself dyed his thoughts in murky black.

Die, he will die. If he was going to die, then he wished to die faster. His hands freed, he attempted to kill himself.

His hands were eaten from the fingers. He's dead. Already, dead dead, dead dead dead dead dead de—

2

—His vision cleared, and Natsuki Subaru was standing beneath an open sky.

Subaru: "…"

A grassland of verdant emerald stretched as far as the eye could see.

A refreshing breeze jolted the blooms, a calm spectacle contrary to any boisterousness or savagery. The grassland resumed till beyond the horizon, making him almost hallucinate that this tranquility shall persist forever.

Narrowing his eyes from the radiance of this scene, Subaru turned back with a long sigh.

Ahead of his gaze was a slightly elevated hillock. Atop the hillock positioned were a white parasol and a table, seeming to meld into the beautiful ambience of the grassland.

Setting foot on the hillock, he leisurely climbed the slope. Atop the table, whose silhouette gradually defined itself, was a cup of black tea, steam rising from it. The sweet fragrance, mingled in the gentle breeze, was that of the tea and tea cakes that went along with it.

Different tea cakes were arranged for each of his visits. *Surprisingly faithful*, he thought in admiration.

Though above all, he was aware that both of those things were all make-believe that appeared with a snap of the tea party host's fingers.

Anyhow—

Subaru: "Tch."

Two chairs were placed around the table, both vacant.

Regardless of the invited guest, the absence of the host who invited him had Subaru furrowing his brows as he clicked his tongue whilst guessing what it was that she sought.

Afterwards, he took the cup atop the table in his hand, and bravely carried it to his lips. And, entwining the steaming amber fluid with his tongue, he quickly swallowed it.

Gulping in succession, he drank the cup's content—

Subaru: "—Oe~e~e~egh!!"

???: "Wait wait wait?!"

He vehemently spat out the black tea he just drank on that very spot.

Hot tea dripping from his mouth and nose, Subaru's violent coughs made someone shout with a flustered, overturned voice.

???: "Surely this is quite rude?! To vomit tea someone had prepared for you right there immediately after drinking it, that is too much!"

Subaru: "Cough, cough… s-sorry. It wasn't on purp… oe~e~egh."

???: "Even if not on purpose, it does not make one feel particularly good! To begin with, you need not drink my tea in such a deteriorated condition…"

Subaru: "But, you wouldn't have shown up if I hadn't done that…"

Calming his regurgitation, breaths hoarse, Subaru's words plunged the person into silence. Wiping his mouth and eyes with his sleeve, Subaru viewed the person immediately ahead.

Subaru: "…"

Ahead was a gorgeous young lady, her frame consisting solely of a dichromatic white and black.

White hair as though achromatized of saturation, black eyes as though ensnarling all shadows in the world, and a jet-black dress garbing her slender, supple figure. Proprietor of an appearance that befitted her the description of a belle from the heavens, and also a succubus or a devil—

Subaru: "—Echidna."

Her name called by the feebly breathing Subaru, the young lady—Echidna straitened her eyes.

She knitted her well-defined eyebrows, and slowly shook her head,

Echidna: "It does make me happy that you are so sincerely bearing to fulfill your promise to me, but… Assuming from your state, it appears you died in quite a horrific fashion this time as well."

Subaru: "…I've told you before. There's no such thing as an easy way to die."

Echidna: “I suppose so. That was a verbal gaffe on my part. I do wish to accord with your thinking as much as possible, but… this alone is something I lack personal experience in, you see.”

Subaru: “…”

Subaru grit his teeth, refraining from having a sour expression, to whose words Echidna shrugged and gently caressed Subaru’s back with a hand.

Quite the unusual concern, he reckoned, but being grateful for it, he spoke nothing. Simply resuming his violent coughs for a minute, he remained knelt on the ground until he composed himself.

Some time later, Subaru’s mind and body calmed down at last.

The shock of slaughter from just before somewhat faded, it felt as though Natsuki Subaru’s torn and mutilated soul was returning to its original form.

Albeit he was aware, that this regeneration was nothing more than a patchy, shoddy one.

Subaru: “…Sorry. I’ve finally calmed down.”

Echidna: “Is that so. I am glad. Now then, let me arrange for a second cup of tea…”

Subaru: “…”

Echidna: “I simply jest, you know. I have received your good faith. Hence, I shall not be insistent. Though this is not really any meaningless entertainment either, you see.”

Halting the hand caressing his spine, Echidna stood up and snapped her fingers.

That very instant, the tea Subaru had violently thrown up, along with the soiled tea cakes and table, all vanished, and entirely new ones reappeared in their stead. As though a dream or illusion—no, in reality, that was the kind of place this was, so these events were truly worthy of being called wondrous.

Echidna: “Now then.”

Echidna then placed her hips on the seat positioned on the other side of the table. Placing both of her elbows atop the table, and propping up her chin, her upturned eyes gave a warm reception to Subaru.

Conjecturing what she sought from her gaze, Subaru sighed.

Subaru: “I know, you don’t need to tell me.”

With that answer, Subaru sat on the chair opposite to the Witch and gazed at the cup of tea which had reappeared just like the tea cakes, and helplessly took it to his lips.

Watching this, Echidna faintly blushed and smiled.

Echidna: “Hm, very well. It makes me happy you have become significantly acquiescent, Natsuki Subaru.”

Subaru: “…Why do you wish to make me drink your bodily fluids this much, wicked Witch.”

Whilst seeing the carefree Echidna’s smile, Subaru distorted his lips, feeling something repugnant instead of the taste of flavorless, odorless tea.

This was a dream world built in the graveyard of her, of the Witch of Greed—the Witch who had already expired took form beyond death, a tea party incapable of

existing in reality.

Originally improbable, the solitary space materializing the tryst of the Witch and her contractor.

3

—Subaru was not particularly knowledgeable regarding the Witch of Greed.

Already expired, a young lady who was supposed to have died four hundred years ago. One of the seven Witches possessing immense might, a personage purporting to be the thirst for knowledge incarnate.

All of this was sufficient to raise eyebrows, but Subaru who stood before the genuine entity could not think of any reason to simply laugh it off.

As a matter of fact, the tea party where Subaru and Echidna met was held in her graveyard located inside the Sanctuary, and that she was enjoying this liberty after her death was proof of her might. He had met the other five Witches, but she even had the power to tether the souls of the deceased.

On top of that, there existed no margin of doubt in her being the thirst for knowledge incarnate, a clod of inquisitiveness.

After all, if not so—

Echidna: "—To propose a Contract to you and risk being scowled at by that thing, is not exactly a stunt that can be pulled off, is it?"

Subaru: "…I'm astounded. You're really gonna say that yourself."

Echidna: "It is not anything embarrassing or as such, after all. Rather, in order to have a deeper understanding of you I shall not keep away from all hazards; will this not make for a gallant maidenly appeal?"

Subaru: "It'll just give more of the impression that I've got some crazy person's eyes on me though, you know?"

Hearing the wry faced Subaru's response, Echidna pouted.

A terribly beguiling attitude, but there was nothing dishonest about her say. In truth, what Subaru and Echidna were walking over, was a bridge of risking their lives altogether.

A tightrope walk risking life and death in order to not collide with the outrage of the being who, in some kind, was deemed as the utmost fearsome existence in this world —

Echidna: "You need not be afraid anymore. To the utmost, the Contract is a secret pass tied between me and you. Even should the opponent be a Witch, our surreptitious meeting shall remain unnoticed."

Subaru: "Can you stop going out of your way and speaking in this suspicious way please? It drains me."

Echidna: "A girl is going so far as to say all this, and yet you have this attitude, I cannot say I approve of it…"

Echidna implored in displeasure, holding her cup to her mouth. But unfortunately, he had no time to lend an ear to any unserious comments of hers.

This tea party was not an occurrence of reality. Subaru's body present in this location, Echidna's existence before his eyes, the tea and tea cakes, from the table to the grassland, it was all make-believe. Outside of the tea party in the graveyard, Natsuki Subaru's body was still lying on the chilly floor.

Still collapsed by Emilia's side, who was tormented with nightmares after challenging the Trial.

And—

Subaru: "As long as I don't find a way to break this deadlock, neither Emilia, nor will anyone else be saved."

Echidna: "I will say this, you need not fret over the time passed here too much, you know? In accordance with your knowledge, this is a dream world of my creation… self-aware make-believe. Even if you were to spend a hundred years here, merely a scant amount of time would have passed outside."

Subaru: "You make me shudder. No way in hell I'm spending a hundred years here."

Echidna: "Oh, how callous. Even when I have already been here for nearly four hundred years."

Accreting a radical precedent atop a radical proposition, Echidna smiled at Subaru.

It might have been quite an attractive proposal from her perspective, but Subaru's answer earlier was truly genuine. Spending a hundred years here would be outrageous.

—Even if, going forward, Subaru was to spend enough time with Echidna to rival that figure.

Echidna: "—Now then, you do not seem to enjoy small talk with me here anyways, so let us delve into the main issue."

Subaru: "…"

Subaru narrowed his eyes as Echidna set the cup down and clapped her hands before her chest.

Just before Subaru's irritation verged onto its peak, the Witch's observational perceptivity saw through it, making him feel the definite influence of her learning and bittering his mood.

However, Echidna seemed to enjoy even this mental state of Subaru's,

Echidna: "Let me get straight to the point, in what manner did you die this time?"

A candid enquiry devoid of even a speck of considerateness was hurled at him.

Subaru: "…I'm telling you every time, but you've gotta put it in a nicer way."

Echidna: "Oh? Every time? How very intriguing. For in accordance with my cognizance, this is the first time I have asked you this question. If so, can it be inferred that I am receiving identical adjuration from you like this every time?"

Subaru: "That's…"

Echidna: “That’s?”

Eyes glistening with inquisitiveness, Echidna reacted with a lean forward. Glaring at her, Subaru fumbled around the bottom of his neck.

And, pulling out a dusky crystal, he forcibly unfastened it from his neck.

Subaru: “Try asking yourself!”

Echidna: “Oop.”

Subaru domineeringly threw the dusky crystal atop the table. Rounding her large eyes, Echidna pleasantly picked it up with a “Let me see let me see” —

Echidna: “*Myon myon myon myon myon*…”

Touching it by her brows, her lips began to leak this suspicious note of efficacy.

In all honesty, it seemed nothing more than tomfoolery from Subaru’s standpoint. Above all, she would answer that she was being serious upon being questioned.

Subaru: “It’s supposed to be this formula that cannot be omitted in terms of magic, but… I’m goddamn sure that’s all bullshit.”

Echidna: “How upsetting for you to accuse *myon myon* of being lies, *myon*. This is a crucial rite, *myon*.”

Subaru: “You’re speaking your thoughts out loud. Are you really able to read its contents like this.”

Echidna: “*Myon myon*… do not worry. I can certainly read them. Phrasing it in your style, I suppose it feels like firmly downloading memories.”

Putting forward western words unused in this different world, Echidna ceded the dusky crystal from her forehead. Witnessing the intellectual glister dwelling in her black eyes, Subaru surmised she had attained her objective.

Echidna’s objective—it was to retrieve the memories of Subaru’s previous Return by Death from the crystal dangling down his neck.

That is to say—

Subaru: “In the dusk jewel, the proof of the Contract, accumulated are experiences identical to what all I did.”

Echidna: “And each time you return to the tea party, I succeed the Memories from you. What all you previously conversed with me, and what all experiences you underwent, I mean. Hm…”

Subaru: “What. Is there some defect in the Memories or something?”

Echidna: “No, they are perfect. However, you told me to ask myself, did you not? Once I actually investigate and explore the Memories like this, well well, this is quite astonishing.”

As Subaru sat puzzled, Echidna, smiling faintly, prefaced with a “I mean, is it not true?”,

Echidna: “As much as I could approximately affirm, this is the fifteenth time I have asked you the way you died… in other words, that is the amount of times you have accreted Death since exchanging the Contract with me.”

Articulating so, Echidna returned the dusky crystal atop the table. And, cast her enraptured pupils toward the jewel serving to slake her thirst for knowledge, and her contractor, Subaru.

Echidna: "…Indeed, you are an individual difficult to ever attain. It was correct to have exchanged vows with you."

Subaru: "*Ding dong*, you lost points on my amiableness scale once again."

Echidna: "Hu~h? Even when I am complimenting you, that is strange…"

If that was her way of complimenting, then what Echidna ought to learn foremost was how to communicate with others. Subaru stood in no position to say this about anyone, but he could hold his head high for being far better off than the monochromatic Witch before his eyes.

Subaru: "At the very least, this is no time to be rubbernecking at someone else's life and death."

Echidna: "What a mortifying way to put it. By no means am I gaining amusement from the situation of you accreting Death itself. Most of all…"

Subaru: "Most of all what. It's not too enjoyable of a spectacle anyways or something?"

Echidna: "No, most of all—you and I no longer qualify as being "someone else" pertaining to each other in our relationship, you see."

Gently tapering her eyelashes, Echidna lowered her pitch to whose words Subaru halted his breath.

Before his eyes, the white haired Witch directed a gaze at Subaru captivating enough to make one shiver, her black irises assuaged with a dubious gleam. Magical charm that made one involuntarily forbear to avert their eyes away from her's.

His throat feeling parched, Subaru spontaneously gaped his mouth open, focusing on the numbness of his tongue. That was truly an acute manifestation of the sensation of "Enthrallment".

And much to his vexation, Subaru possessed no means to refute Echidna's words.

Because—

Echidna: "—You, accepted a Contract with me. A Contract that on your forlorn road of innumerable stumbles hereon, I, the Witch of Greed, shall chaperone you."

Subaru: "You don't need to tell me, I…"

Echidna: "Already know, you say? Splendid. Certainly, it seems I have previously had this identical conversation with you before. Mhm, it is present within the Memories as well. However…"

Adjourning her words, Echidna slanted forward.

Subaru was on his chair, petrified like a frog leered by a serpent. Touching Subaru's lips with a finger, Echidna then put her finger on her mouth.

Afterwards, in a beguiling display, Echidna lovingly caressed the finger that had felt his lips with her vermilion tongue.

Echidna: “Once again, this is the first time my present self touches on this topic with you. Therefore, I wish for you to close your eyes to some larks as part of the Contract.”

Subaru: “…Should’ve properly documented the Contract’s details, huh.”

Echidna: “How unvarnished. But, that is precisely why you attract a special gaze from me. Oop, although what you attract are not my eyes alone…”

Subaru: “…”

Echidna: “Even I am hurt by an expression so appalled. As a young souled, singular maiden, you see.”

Watching Subaru distort his lips, Echidna pouted and narrowed her eyes.

Young souled, this expression alone had plenty of substance to demur, but this conduct of Echidna’s vanished her of her earlier bewitching ambience. The Witch showed a multitude of expressions even in this short interval, to opine which amongst those was her true face felt akin to grasping clouds.

—Or perhaps, this enigma too would be unravelled once he had been in fellowship with her for a long, long period.

Subaru: “…The succession of Memories is complete, yeah. Then, let me get to the topic. About this time’s cause of death…”

Echidna: “How impetuous. Certainly, it seems you could not see what killed you because you had been blindfolded… but that fashion of death is patent, yes? The calamity that assails onto the Sanctuary, it is the Great Rabbit.”

Subaru: “…”

Echidna: “Drawn into the Great Rabbit’s foray, your entire body was devoured. To be quite honest, even I felt powerless upon browsing through your Memories, what a miserable Death.”

Receiving Echidna’s merciless delineation, Subaru felt a gastric influx in his gut once again.

The fierce death that he recalled, it could not have been more than ten minutes since he had experienced it. Unlike how it would have been if he were to be with Emilia or Rem, spending time with Echidna would not heal his wounds.

Even now, the sensation of his defenseless self being gorged away from edges of his body had been incised into his soul with clarity.

Echidna: “It somehow feels like I am being subjected to a rather rude comparison?”

Subaru: “—. Stop with the jokes. You’re the type of character who doesn’t understand the human heart, aren’t you. It’s too late for you to be malcontent about however I may think of you in my mind to begin with.”

Echidna: “If that is your liberty as an adolescent young man, then I am not opposed to it either.”

Subaru attempted to varnish the situation over, feeling as though his mind had been peered into, to which Echidna straitened her eyes. With a single one of her slender

fingers, she alluringly traced her body garbed in a black dress.

A devilish gesture suggesting rousing or seducing—

Subaru: “One hundred percent no.”

Echidna: “It is quite upsetting to hear you say it with such certainty too~! Despite appearances, I was even said to be welcomed by the king of a country as his favorite mistress.”

Subaru: “Well, it’s not that king’s fault since Emilia-tan wouldn’t have been there four hundred years ago.”

Echidna: “You are quite churlish when it comes to me alone!”

Setting her hands on the table, the prior seductive ambience dwindled from Echidna. In all honesty, Echidna pleasantly rattling on would bear to be of greater help to him.

In the sense of ignoring the impact immediately followed by Return by Death or the ache of wounds engraved onto his soul, as well.

Subaru: “Anyhow, I don’t object to the Great Rabbit being the cause of death. But the thing is, that’s the indirect cause of death. The direct cause of death is not the hare, but lies somewhere else. It’s—”

Echidna: “—Garfiel, right?”

Subaru: “…Right.”

Subaru jerked his chin upon Echidna’s brisk, complicit response.

Focusing solely on the main issue and allowing no disruptions during the interlude in between, this Witch was dreadfully concise and brisk.

Testament of her peerless acumen, perspicacity, and most of all, wisdom, but perhaps it was for this reason did their conversations stray off to an infinite extent.

Anyhow—

Subaru: “The reason he perceives me as a hazard is because of the Witch’s scent accumulating due to Return by Death. If it’s always going to be proportional to the count of death, then…”

Echidna: “There exist no means to win the confidence of a being who can pick the scent of Miasma.”

Subaru: “…That’s what I’m worried about. What do you say.”

Pronouncing so, Subaru sought the Witch’s stance on the Witch’s Miasma.

Upon each repetition of Return by Death, Garfiel’s attitude quickly altered—now fixed on by utter hostility, the situation was such that he had himself expressed the reason itself.

With the reason for his hostility established, he wished to believe he could change their relationship for the better by removing that facet, but—

Subaru: “Does this scent last permanently upon getting tinged with it? If that’s the case, then I’ll be causing a good deal of distress to Rem once she’s opened her eyes.”

Echidna: “Concern that truly befits you, but how about you fear for the nearer future? To begin with, the Oni Clan is a race created such that they are capable of

detecting Miasma, so even upon being placed in a distressing plight due to that, I suppose there is no choice but to give up on it by regarding it as an inborn quality of the race."

Subaru: "You said something kinda impossible to overlook, but then that'll mean I'll have to live my whole life with Rem thinking of me as stinky, huh."

Echidna: "Indeed, my deepest condolences… I am joking. Please do not glare at me like that."

Once he glared at Echidna who went astray with unserious answers, the Witch shrugged her shoulders.

Echidna: "Your fear is needless. The Miasma is not overflowing from your own Od. It is but a scent in the end… as time goes on, it will fade and ultimately vanish. Provided it will need copious time for someone tinged to not smell anymore."

Subaru: "Copious time… you aren't exactly talking about a couple of days now are you?"

Echidna: "Considering your density, I would say think of weeks or months. Also, this is something I do not wish to say since you will likely get angry at me, but…"

Subaru: "…I'll get angry if you stop there anyways, so accept it and say it."

One eye shut, a remark whilst peeking into Subaru's mood.

Correlative bitterness of not wanting to say because of his foreseeable reaction, but also the inquisitiveness of seeing how Subaru would react.

The idiosyncrasy of the Witch of Greed seemed to be quite the nuisance.

Putting these contemplations of Subaru's aside, Echidna pointed to the dusky crystal atop the table with a "Well then, allow me to",

Echidna: "As I previously mentioned, the optimal way of making the Miasma fade is the passage of time. But, since it is simply scent, it is necessary to ward away from the odor's origin…"

Subaru: "Yeah. So?"

Echidna: "You are my contractor, yes? Even should the Authority not be utilized, you cannot elude my Miasma, so there may never be a day when it fades away."

Subaru: "In other words, the reason why I stink right now is also because of you…!"

Subaru glanced at his palm once again, eyes dilated. Echidna sulked, stating "That is quite an abashed way to put it", but this was an unanticipated demerit.

Of course, with him sharing the truth of Return by Death and consulting for a way to abscond from this impasse in their relationship, one could say Echidna was an ally difficult to ever attain.

However, in terms of exclusively the Sanctuary, this relationship's drawbacks were indisputable.

Subaru: "Echidna's Contract, and Return by Death's count… no matter which, if the scent won't disappear then I'll never be able to connect with Garfiel. This is pretty bad."

Echidna: “Certainly, within a restricted span of time, to be shadowed by Garfiel who is far more adroit than you can be called the worst possible environment.”

Subaru: “Sounds so insincere… you better not have known what happens, yeah?”

Echidna: “What do you mean, what happens?”

Echidna tilted her head as Subaru glared at her, teeth gritted in rage. From her black pupils framed with white eyelashes, he could not infer her true motive veiled beneath conundrums. However, it had now already been fifteen times—fifteen times had Subaru accreted Death ever since he contracted with Echidna.

Subaru: “Couldn’t you have given me advice about the problem posed by the Witch’s scent earlier. Had you done that, then Garfiel could’ve been countered while the scent was still weak…”

Echidna: “Ah, so that is what you mean. Certainly, pertaining to the Miasma shrouding you, I could have delineated it at an earlier stage. Regardless, it was still too late. Prior to entering into a Contract with me, you already reeked enough to buy the opponent’s distrust.”

Subaru: “…”

Echidna: “A being who can pick the scent of Miasma surely would not have pardoned you.”

Arms crossed over her chest, Echidna replied whilst intercepting Subaru’s gaze.

Boldly riposted, Subaru failed to immediately refute. Her words could not be fully trusted, but he possessed no basis to allege lies or mendacity.

Once he was told it was too late to do something about his stench, he could not do anything but put his faith in it.

However, amidst an outwardly fruitless exchange, Subaru saw a faint glimmer of hope.

That was—

Subaru: “Considering your fishy phrasing, it seems my guess wasn’t pointless either.”

Echidna: “Fishy… well, I suppose when anyone is pointed out something about a subject as delicate as their body odor, they would feel somewhat discomfited. Most of all, I hardly have any at all. I did not have much body odor when I was alive, and in this place, a dream after my death, I can freely…”

Subaru: “I don’t care if you smell like flowers or sewage. That’s not what I’m talking about. —You’ve been repeating “A being who can pick the scent of Miasma” since earlier, haven’t you?”

Echidna: “…”

Subaru’s identification had Echidna raise a single one of her brows, wordless.

For the Witch to pause and incline herself to listen was somewhat of proof that Subaru was not off the mark.

That as basis, Subaru grazed his jaw with a finger,

Subaru: “An unusual phrase. Of course, here onwards, Return by Death… though I don’t want to rely on it much, but if I’m going to use it then we can’t do away with the problem of me and the scent. So, it’s also possible you may have been looking at it from the perception of someone looking at the distant future, but…”

Echidna: “Hm. That is fine, resume.”

Subaru: “From what you said, our focus to the utmost is the Sanctuary. Yet, why are you using this discursive phrase instead of just saying Garfiel?”

Going further, Echidna had divulged Garfiel’s name itself.

Yet she was expressly drawing a distinction between Garfiel and “A being who can pick the scent of Miasma”.

Its true connotation was—

Echidna: “—You definitely take notice of specifics. Mhm, admirable.”

Subaru: “…I knew it, caught red-handed.”

Echidna: “Your intuition regarding my fixation was correct, that is all. I certainly was deliberately drawing a distinction between a being who can pick the scent of Miasma and Garfiel. However, is it not a matter of course?”

A faint smile, Echidna resumed with a “After all” whilst setting her elbows on the table, chin propped in her hands,

Echidna: “The Miasma shrouding you, the one who can pick its scent is not Garfiel. It is someone else.”

She pleasantly verbalized, unreservedly and lost of any diffidence.

4

Subaru: “…”

Subaru narrowed his eyes in response to what Echidna had said, an air of danger about it.

Deep inside his mind, he felt a certain sort of conviction, like he had muttered the phrase “I knew it”.

Echidna: “From the start, I was talking about someone else. So, naturally, I call them differently and differentiate between them. I mean, my thinking here should not be that surprising, no?”

Echidna spoke with an air of composure, like she was talking about the most obvious thing in the world. Subaru frowned in response to her matter-of-fact way of putting it, gawking at her in disbelief.

Subaru: “I’d originally been suspecting that possibility. If he could actually smell the Witch’s Lingering Scent, his attitude would’ve gone to shit right after I Returned by Death and exited the graveyard.”

Echidna: “And yet, even when you, drenched in all the more Miasma after returning while accreting so many Deaths, leave the graveyard with your beloved girl, the attitude of Garfiel, who awaits you there, does not change. Meaning…”

Subaru: “Right there and then, he can’t perceive my smell. That’s why his attitude doesn’t change.”

Echidna: “Correct.”

She snapped her fingers and confirmed Subaru’s conclusion.

She was acting like she was his classroom teacher or mentor, but he ignored his irritation towards that currently. Right now, it was more important for Subaru to have his suspicions confirmed.

There was someone out there, separate from Garfiel, who could smell the Witch’s Miasma that Subaru was clad in. In other words, the hostility Garfiel felt towards him was down to this certain someone putting these ideas into his head.

And, he needed not trouble himself over who the candidate for this someone was.

Echidna: “You also must have had an idea all this time, right? Unless you have turned your eyes away from it.”

Subaru: “…Ryuzu-san, for sure.”

Every single time, Echidna’s knack for conversation would come along and block Subaru’s escape. Her skill of forcing Subaru to look ahead was a vector unlike that of Rem’s.

Compared to Rem, she was not as unsparing, but regardless, it was detestable.

Subaru: “Plus, not as kind, the hue’s darker, and it’s bitter in taste…”

Echidna: “I do not suppose I am being badmouthed, am I?”

Ignoring the words of the surprised Echidna, Subaru wrinkled the middle of his forehead.

Thinking about people that were able to smell the Witch’s Lingering Scent who would have given Garfiel that information, by process of elimination, it could only have been Ryuzu.

Rem also had that ability, but by now, it was obvious to Subaru that her older sister did not.

In the first place, the allies of Emilia like Ram and Roswaal had no reason to be hostile towards him.

Lastly, to think of the most unexpected, perhaps Otto was somehow able to smell the Witch’s Lingering Scent, but—

Subaru: “…He was killed right in front of my very eyes.”

Just by recalling it, it became hard to breathe, but Otto had been an absolute idiot that had thrown his own life away for Subaru, someone he had known for such a short period of time. Therefore, he was most definitely not the mastermind behind this.

Subaru: “Now that I think about it, I was held captive by Ryuzu-san and Garfiel in the past.”

That had been a collaborative effort of the both of them, but he had thought the main offender had been Garfiel. He had been mistaken. —The main offender had been Ryuzu, and Garfiel was only a collaborator.

And, the reason Ryuzu took these actions was—

Subaru: “Because she smelled the Witch’s Lingering Scent.”

Echidna: “She tattled that to Garfiel, whom she trusts. Believing his grandma’s words in a heartbeat, Garfiel’s behavior instantaneously changed, and he bared his fangs at you. Quite literally~.”

Subaru: “…”

While wagging her finger, Echidna confirmed Subaru’s deduction.

With that explanation, the storm whirling inside Subaru had dissipated. But, without giving him a pause, black clouds began to appear inside his heart once more. Making their way through to his expression, Echidna tilted her head with an “Oh”

Echidna: “Your expression is quite stressed, perhaps there is something you wish to say to me?”

Subaru: “Of course there is! From how you talked earlier, you knew my real enemy was Ryuzu-san this entire time, didn’t you! And yet…”

Echidna: “Why did I not say anything, huh. It is reasonable that you would get angry, but for what it is worth, I had a reason. I do not think it is too late for me to say it?”

Subaru: “—*Tsk*, what is it?”

Echidna’s finger brushed against Subaru’s forehead as he gritted his teeth. Subaru took a listening posture, though his vigor was not dampened by the touch of the slender finger.

With her finger still pressed to Subaru’s forehead, Echidna prefaced her question with “Listen?”,

Echidna: “I mentioned earlier the problem with the Miasma surrounding you, did I not? As long as you have a Contract with me, the Miasma will never fade from you. Every time you use your Authority, the Miasma grows stronger and stronger, and it becomes impossible to make up for the impression you make on them.”

Subaru: “…Ah, about that huh. What does that have to do with you not telling me anything?”

Echidna: “You are quite impatient. In other words, no matter what I said, their impression of you would not change… I want you to understand that it is a given.”

While roundabout, this was her crude explanation to justify her decision.

Even so, while her finger was still pressed to his forehead, without saying anything, Subaru urged Echidna to continue. If she kept spitting excuses, he might have changed the way he viewed his Contract with her.

Echidna: “—That, is extremely unsatisfactory for me.”

Echidna replied to his innermost thoughts, prompting Subaru to raise his eyebrows.

Smiling at Subaru’s reaction, Echidna shrugged while saying “It’s not a complicated matter”.

Echidna: “As a basic premise, the other party… For convenience, let us call them Ryuzu. That negative impression you left cannot be changed. As such, If she remains your enemy, Garfiel’s aggression cannot be avoided…. are we clear on that?”

Subaru: "…Continue."

Echidna: "On the other hand… if Ryuzu was no longer your enemy, Garfiel's aggression towards you would no longer be an issue, that is what I am saying."

Echidna briefly summarized the problem as if she were stating a simple theory.

Surely, Echidna was correct on a logical level. Since Ryuzu was the one who had sensed the Witch's Lingering Scent, if her meddling was the reason for Garfiel's hostility towards Subaru, then logically the best way to avoid that confrontation within the Sanctuary would be for Ryuzu to not recognize Subaru as an enemy—

Subaru: "However, understanding the reasons behind their actions won't change the outcome. In your own words, the Witch's Miasma has drenched me with no hope of it fading away. If that's the case, the reason for being hated won't go away either…"

Echidna: "That is true. You still will be hated… Even so, that is no reason to be hostile."

Subaru: "Huh?"

After those words that destroyed his previous assumptions, Echidna moved her finger away from the surprised Subaru's forehead and snapped her fingers right before Subaru's nose.

Suddenly, a white cup appeared on the cleared table, and the aroma and steam wafted into his nostrils.

It was the tea set that was served hospitably to Subaru every time he returned to the Castle of Dreams—the "Dona Tea".

Subaru: "…The hell are you doing?"

Echidna: "Have I not told you? I do not just serve tea frivolously, nor am I asking you to sit at the table just a matter of formality."

Subaru: "I thought it was just your fetish to make me drink your bodily fluids…"

Echidna: "Actually, while I do not mind seeing you drink my tea so reluctantly, that is not what I meant. Before entering your Contract with me, you had talked to Ryuzu. —About the Apostles."

—Subaru's breath stopped at the mention of the word "Apostles", causing Echidna's black pupils to flicker.

Echidna's assumption was correct that he had heard that word, before he had entered the Contract with her, before he had experienced Death fifteen times.

When the Witch of Envy had covered the Sanctuary in her shadow, and when Subaru had seized the opportunity to commit suicide through Echidna's scheme, he had seen numerous Ryuzus—her replicants, including Garfiel, who was accompanying them.

After that, Subaru had learned about the origin of these replicants, "Ryuzu Meyer", and that the Ryuzu he knew was a clone of her, a part of the system that protected the Sanctuary.

Apostle, it was a word he had heard in a conversation with Ryuzu at that time.

Echidna: "Do you remember? I believe Ryuzu had told you. The tea that has been served to you…"

Subaru: “Something about it giving me the qualifications to become an Apostle of Greed.”

Echidna: “And, that Garfiel also gained power over the replicants under the same conditions.”

Subaru: “…”

Echidna’s additional words fit together perfectly within Subaru’s mind.

With a click, the gears began to turn, and Subaru felt like he understood the Witch’s aim, along with the words she had added. The tea was something that gave Subaru power as an Apostle of Greed.

There might have been many other tricks up her sleeve, but for now, he would turn a blind eye to them. The important thing here was that fact, that Echidna had overlooked Subaru’s Deaths fifteen times.

What was the reason that Subaru had to stack up more than fifteen Deaths?

It was—

Subaru: “—I’m waiting for my power over Ryuzu-san and the other replicants to surpass that of Garfiel’s.”

Echidna: “That is a great answer.”

Echidna clasped her hands in front of her chest and raised her voice cheerfully.

Echidna: “If two Apostles exist, then it would be natural to conclude that the one with the higher affinity would have priority when giving orders. It has been ten years since Garfiel challenged the tomb and became an apostle… So it is not surprising that he had plenty of experiences of being an Apostle. If you were to try to compete with him in such a short amount of time…”

Subaru: “Then it would be <u>best</u> for me to drink the tea over and over again… but what’s the point?”

Echidna: “Oh, are you concerned about what will happen after Death? Have no fear, since you are contracted with me, my interference will accumulate in your soul. It cannot be left behind when you cross over into Death.”

Subaru: “…You didn’t tell me this before, that way I wouldn’t lose my <u>motivation</u>.”

Before Subaru’s eyes, as he mumbled in frustration, Echidna hugged her elbows in silence. A faint smile appeared on her lips, quietly confirming Subaru’s words.

During the fifteen Deaths that Subaru had experienced, Echidna had hidden the truth about the relationship between Garfiel and the Ryuzus. The reason was that there was no solution for dealing with them until the effects of the tea had taken hold.

—In short, Subaru had no other solution but to accrete Deaths.

Echidna: “Now that you understand, are you convinced?”

Furrowing her brows, Echidna peered into Subaru’s face as he bit his lip.

The act of her slightly lowering her tone and giving an upward glance towards Subaru caused a burst of rage to swell up inside of him, but he refrained himself from raising his voice. In fact, Echidna’s thoughts were accurate.

—He would not have easily agreed to something as ludicrous as sacrificing himself fifteen times for nothing.

Subaru: "You needed me to understand that it was a dead-end, and there was nothing I could do."

Echidna: "Yes yes, that is correct. I knew you would understand."

Subaru: "*Ding ding ding*, your amiableness score has gone down once again."

Echidna: "Heeh?"

Echidna's eyes widened at Subaru's heartless announcement. Subaru finished another cup of tea on the table in one gulp, relishing the Witch's reaction.

Despite the steam rising from the cup, he felt no heat. It was an odorless and tasteless tea of unknown ingredients.

It was surprising that the Witch's scheming included such a bland tea, and even more so that it would help to conquer the Sanctuary.

Indeed, there had been no wasted actions. Not the fifteen Deaths he had accumulated, nor even this Tea Party where she had revealed her true intentions.

Subaru: "So, the secret has been revealed. Which would mean, the time has come… hasn't it?"

Echidna: "Indeed. It seems as though you now rank higher than Garfiel as an Apostle. The replicants that shield the Sanctuary cannot resist your commands. Even Garfiel can no longer give them freedom."

Subaru: "…"

Subaru could not help but notice the irony of him being called "The Shield of the Sanctuary".

Originally, Garfiel had appointed himself to that role. However, Echidna, who had created the Sanctuary, recognized Ryuzu as the Shield rather than him.

As proof of this, Garfiel would be left out in the dark.

Subaru: "The Witch's Lingering Scent… if Ryuzu-san doesn't tell Garfiel about the Witch's Miasma, he won't have any reason to oppose us."

Echidna: "Even so, he would not essentially want the Sanctuary to be released."

Subaru: "…If there's room for discussion, there's a way to handle it."

The biggest problem with Ryuzu's inclusion was that it took away the possibility of discussing things with Garfiel.

If only he did not resort to violence and confinement first, then perhaps they could do something.

Perhaps, they could even give Garfiel a decisive reason to leave the Sanctuary.

For that purpose—

Echidna: "—You have keen eyes. Even I, a Witch, shudder at the thought."

As if reading Subaru's thoughts, Echidna chuckled and picked up a crystal off the table with her slender white fingers—picking up the Magic Crystal, she offered it to Subaru.

She did not want to miss a single fragment of Subaru's experience as her contractor.

Echidna: “Now then, things are in order. And moreover, the chances we have are now endless. With the Authority you possess, let us repeat every single kind of experience, over and over and over again, —let us seize that world which you desire.”

With that, the Witch of Greed mercilessly pushed Natsuki Subaru toward his hesitance.

5

—Frustratingly, the situation went smoothly, all according to Echidna’s plan.

???: “I am Ryuzu Shima… one of the first four replicants of Ryuzu Meyer, and a failure who had her role taken away.”

In the forest, dressed in white and hiding in the woods, Ryuzu—no, Shima said so, raising both of her hands up in resignation at Subaru, who had found her.

Finding her was easy. He had simply gathered the replicants, distributed them throughout the Sanctuary with Pico as their leader, and gave them an order.

—He had instructed them to find the replicants who had been secretly meeting with Garfiel.

And, the Eyes of the Sanctuary, which Garfiel boasted about, found their target easily and told Subaru of her location.

Subaru: “Shima… the Ryuzu-san I know called herself “Ryuzu Bilma”. That difference, does it mean that you distinguish each other by your surnames?”

Shima: “…”

Subaru: “Answer me.”

Shima: “—. Yes. We are all descended from Ryuzu Meyer. Thus, we cannot change the fact that we are Ryuzu. So, we sought individuality in another aspect.”

Shima, who had remained silent for a moment, answered Subaru’s question.

Forcing her to answer, despite her emotional state, seemed to be a privilege given to those who were deemed Apostles of Greed. The privilege of commanding the replicants, that was what had coerced Shima to speak.

Subaru: “Ryuzu-san… no, I’ll call you Shima-san, I’m sure you’re sensing the Miasma that seems to cloak me, right?”

Shima: “Hm…”

Subaru: “Please, don’t try to fool me. I don’t want to force you to answer me truthfully every time I ask you something. It hurts my heart to do so to such a familiar face.”

Subaru pleaded with Shima, who hesitated to answer.

It might not have been entirely accurate to say that Shima was a “familiar face”; however, she was the spitting image of the other Ryuzu that Subaru was acquainted with —Ryuzu Bilma.

Forcing someone to bend to one’s will and twisting their true intentions would not be a good feeling. That method would be no different from brainwashing or

blackmailing with how despicable it was.

Shima: "…That's true."

Perhaps sensing his distress, Shima silently nodded her head in agreement.

So finally, one burden was lifted from Subaru's shoulders. —He felt that there was a glimmer of hope in dealing with Garfiel, a situation which had not progressed for a long time.

Subaru: "Shima-san, were you planning to meet up with Garfiel later to convey this information to him? Could you not do that, please? I don't want to aggravate our relationship."

Shima: "…Even if you say that, if Gar-bo pesters me, I won't be able to go against him."

Subaru: "Is that really the case? —Even if it is my request?"

Shima: "—Hk!"

In response to Subaru's repeated question, Shima's previously shrewd and relaxed expression stiffened for the first time.

Or, perhaps the calmness that had prevailed until just before was due to resignation. As such, Subaru's words directly interfered with Shima's calm, ocean-like state of mind.

Shima: "Could it be, Su-bo, that in just half a day, you've become an Apostle of Greed…?"

Subaru: "If the question is something like "Have you been awakened?", the answer is an unwilling yes. Can you really bring yourself to lie to Garfiel through the persuasive power of my words?"

Shima: "…Probably, I'm sure there wouldn't be a problem."

With her eyes downcast, Shima reluctantly nodded to Subaru's question.

Her reaction simultaneously brought a sense of relief that it had gone well, and a sense of guilt that he had pushed her too hard into this position. It was truly bitter and left a bad aftertaste in Subaru's mouth, like an act of self-harm that he had inflicted on himself.

However, the only real harm that had been done was to Subaru. —He gritted his teeth and looked forward.

Subaru: "Pico, come here."

Closing his eyes tightly, Subaru killed his hesitation and called out behind him.

Then, a silent Ryuzu emerged from the bushes—one of the replicants. Of those scattered throughout the Sanctuary, she was also a hollow-like marionette with no purpose but to listen to instructions.

Information within the Sanctuary could also be obtained from replicants other than Pico. If Shima was not an enemy, this analog surveillance system could be extremely useful.

Subaru: "If Shima-san doesn't provoke him, there's no need to worry about Garfiel's sudden outbursts. However, I'll have a few of you take turns keeping an eye on

him.”

Shima: “Su-bo, about Gar-bo…”

Subaru: “—He’s currently my number one potential enemy right now.”

Subaru gave Pico instructions, interrupted Shima, who was about to say something, and explained to her clearly.

Shima snickered at his decisiveness, but Subaru’s greatest sincerity was his honesty.

Of course, Shima had her own point of view. Subaru, too, had experienced Death nearly twenty times so far, and had interacted with Garfiel in the Sanctuary.

According to that experience, Subaru knew that Garfiel was not an incomprehensible monster. He understood that much.

However, even so—

Subaru: “—I’ve already made my decision on what should be prioritized. Don’t get it wrong.”

Under Subaru’s firm gaze, Shima shut her mouth and turned her head away.

Subaru did not command her to be quiet or to disobey. It was just that she was painfully aware of the firmness of Subaru’s determination.

In Subaru’s mind, the words of someone, not of Shima who stood before him, not of Garfiel who opposed him, not of the Witch with whom he was cooperating, but of another person, resurfaced.

Those, were the words spoken by a terrifying man who sneered in a world painted with blood, adorned with white snow and flames.

A man who had even used his own life as a betting chip and had left a curse on Subaru.

???: “Liiisten~ well, Subaru-kun. —This is important. The one thing that is truly, truly important to you. Cast away everything else except that one thing. Let go of everything else except that single thing, and think only of protecting your single most important thing to the end. If you do that—”

Subaru: “—You too, can become like me.”

Subaru: “I—hk!!”

As soon as the voice echoed clearly in his head, his throat trembled with anger.

His vision turned red, and the beating of his heart sounded incredibly loud. His breathing became ragged, and Subaru could no longer bear it, slamming his fist hard against a tree trunk.

Shima: “S-Su-bo…?”

Suddenly Subaru erupted into a tantrum, and Shima timidly called out to him in a frightened tone of voice.

The frightened tone of Shima’s voice reminded Subaru of his instability, and he replied “My bad…” with a hand to his forehead.

The contents of his skull throbbed painfully, as if the pain was a reminder of a nightmare that he should not forget. —No, he must not forget it.

That was a warning. That curse was a binding chain that Subaru himself must consciously bear.

Subaru: "…Don't get me wrong, Shima-san. It's true that I consider Garfiel as a potential enemy, but I'm not thinking of getting rid of him in any way."

With a frown on his face from the headache, Subaru said this to alleviate Shima's concerns. Shima's eyes widened at his words and she leaned forward, asking, "Ho, is that true?"

In response, Subaru nodded his head and said "Yeah",

Subaru: "However, I need Shima-san's cooperation to get him away from here peacefully. It's going to take a lot of work to convince him. Shima-san understands that too, don't you?"

Shima: "That's… because Gar-bo's stubbornness is hardwired. But how?"

Upon hearing that he wanted a peaceful resolution, Shima also agreed with Subaru's thinking. Subaru accepted it affirmatively and moistened his lips with his tongue.

He was not plotting, nor was he camouflaging about his true feelings. Sincerely, he wanted to convey with all his words, so that they would understand.

And, if possible, to achieve a satisfactory conclusion for everyone involved in this situation.

By doing so, he could prove himself. —Once Natsuki Subaru accreted it all.

Subaru: "—Roswaal, I am not like you."

He would never become the Warlock, who was obsessed with just one thing, and allowed the world to make everything a sacrifice.

Even if he were to take the hand of the Witch, he would not lose the soul and dignity of being "human".

That was why—

Subaru: "—I, won't become like you."

6

It was with the cooperation of Ryuzu Shima and the twenty-one replicas who followed his instructions.

By using the power as an Apostle of Greed and skillfully manipulating them, the situation that should have been intricate was easily untangled, like light shining from beyond the dark clouds.

For Subaru, who felt as if his head was being held down and submerged in water, it was a level of emotion akin to finally taking in a breath of air.

However—

???: "Gaahhhh—!!"

And, with a blood-curdling scream, claws were swung and lives were cruelly torn apart, a scene that was contrary to the divine radiance that shone from beyond the dark

clouds.

Subaru: "…"

Before the eyes of Subaru, with his arms crossed, there was a small shadow that was striking to the left and right.

Fighting against the overwhelming white malevolence that approached like a surging mist, literally, was a figure of a golden-haired boy—the heroic figure of Garfiel Tinsel.

Garfiel: "Shiiihk!"

Roaring ferociously, slashing with claws and fangs, he destroyed the enemies that came at him from all directions, one after another.

—His figure, what else could one call it other than heroic?

Facing the enemy without the support of his allies and standing in isolation, Garfiel proved that he was a bold fighter as he mustered all the courage he had built up in his body.

His posture engraved his nobility and bravery more eloquently than words ever could.

In fact, Subaru had no choice but to honestly re-evaluate the fact that he, too, had underestimated Garfiel.

However—

Garfiel: "—Urgh."

Garfiel's throat groaned in agony as a fang was plunged into his right calf.

The embodiment of gluttony devoured the muscles of his well-trained leg in one gulp, aiming to fill its stomach. Its round body was torn in half by a descending karate chop.

However, taking the opponent's life was not enough to make up for the pain.

There were literally enough opponents to fill Garfiel's field of vision.

Garfiel: "—This ain't, no goddamn joke!!"

For a brief moment, a hint of weakness flickered in his emerald eyes, but it quickly faded away.

Biting back the weakness that had sprouted within himself, as if he was ashamed, the roaring Garfiel swung his blood-spurting leg and smashed it powerfully onto the ground.

Immediately after, the trampled earth burst forth, and the destruction swallowed up the white herd of animals.

Collectively, dozens of them—no wonder they were frightened and realized their disadvantage, even if they were Witchbeasts.

Garfiel: "Now—"

Naturally, Garfiel, seeing this, also snapped his fangs in response to the blow.

It was a result worth being proud of. Or perhaps. he might have felt a tailwind at his back, almost like a plea, that he would be able to repel the enemy. —But all of that, too, was just a trick.

Great Rabbit: "—Kyuuuhn."

Stepping over the corpses of their own kind that were killed by Garfiel, the swamp of white furballs stirred.

All at once, without stagnation, like waves on the shore, the Witchbeasts approached like a surging wave. In an unchanged manner, with the deafening cry of *kichi kichi*.

There was no sense of fear for the death of their kind, or for Garfiel who made it happen.

Kichi, kichi, kichi; a quiet and cruel, life-devouring sound—.

Garfiel: "…"

Before that demeanor, even Garfiel's profile showed a frightened expression.

None could point a finger at him and demeaningly ask where that gorgeous figure from just before had gone. This was not the level of disaster that could be faced with a sound mind.

He thought this was the moment.

He had been waiting for the right timing to interject, to seize the opportunity to extend a helping hand, and he believed this was it.

Subaru: "—I suppose by now, you must've gotten how crazy the enemy is, right, Garfiel."

Garfiel: "—~hk! Shut yer mouth! Shut the hell up ~hk!"

However, Garfiel shouted at Subaru as if shaking him off

It was a voice that rejected Subaru, even more than it refused to admit his own fright.

In front of Subaru, whose eyes were wide open in the face of a backlash beyond his imagination, Garfiel's fists roused his deflated heart, and seized the white ball of fur—the Great Rabbit, and crushed the small Witchbeast.

The barrage of fists that were continuously unleashed blew away the fragile Witchbeasts with each blow, but those that turned over and stopped from moving were mercilessly chewed up by the fangs of their own kind that followed, like a perpetual motion machine.

—No, perhaps it would be more appropriate to say that they were not exactly members of the same herd, but more like they were the same existence.

The Great Rabbit, after all, was a being of mysterious biology that trembled and divided itself in the blink of an eye. Whether this was cell division or replication of itself was not clear.

The only thing that could be said was—

Subaru: "That amounts to nothing but buying time. They need to be dealt with from the source."

Garfiel: "For the last goddamn time, I'm tellin' ya ta shut the hell up! I ain't listenin' to yer directions, ya bastard!"

Being told directly that he would not be heard, Subaru could only curl his lips.

But, it would be arrogant to just assume that Garfiel's stubbornness was simply stubbornness.

In the first place, looking back on how he had to face one of the Three Great Witchbeats, it was clear that anyone would sympathize with Garfiel as he faced the Great Rabbit.

Subaru himself realized that this was a terribly malicious method that he had used to set this up.

Garfiel: "—Piece of shit."

As if encouraging himself, or hating the world, or cursing Subaru behind him, abusive words leaked from Garfiel's mouth.

It was natural for him to want to shout like that. Garfiel's feelings could be easily understood, as one were holding them in their hands.

Subaru, too, was dizzyingly familiar with the feeling of helplessness that burned in his chest.

Caught between feelings of powerlessness and disappointment, that was the terrifying nature of the hell that was oneself.

At first glance, Garfiel appeared to be furious, but in reality, to Subaru, he looked like he was crying. Overwhelmed by his own sense of powerlessness and disappointment with reality, he was like a crying child.

And, it was the scheme of none other than Natsuki Subaru that made him realize this.

Subaru: "It's beyond you to be able to do everything alone, Garfiel."

This was not something that was limited to Garfiel personally.

It was known that in all kinds of hardships, the power of a single person was tiny. That was why, to resist the raging current of fate, even giving it one's all was not enough.

At least, it was not something that could be changed with just one person's life.

Garfiel: "…"

Before Subaru's eyes, Garfiel's valiant struggle continued to be in vain.

Even if he shook off their claws and fangs and spilled their blood and flesh, the large rabbits' numbers were replenished immediately. It was not a game of cat and mouse; it was an overwhelmingly one-sided battle of endurance.

Only his durability was being tested, and the enemy's side was not running out of gas..

That was why they were called the Three Great Witchbeasts, and continued to threaten the world endlessly.

Subaru: "—This is the end."

Tears streamed down Garfiel's face as he grit his teeth, and his body was covered in incurable wounds.

If he took a moment to catch his breath, it seemed he would have been able to heal his wounds with the healing magic he had learned. But, he could not make the time for

that. He should have felt the pain of knowing that he could not do it alone.

To make him realize that, he took him to the Great Rabbit that was assailing the Sanctuary.

With that goal accomplished, Subaru gave instructions for a replica to act as a bait for their retreat.

7

Subaru: "They're coming straight towards the Sanctuary. It seems like the people in the village are a feast for them. So, we have to evacuate them."

Garfiel: "…"

Subaru: "This isn't the time to argue about whether or not to open the barrier of the Sanctuary. You understand how serious this is, right?"

Faced with Subaru's question, Garfiel sat on the ground with his legs outstretched in front of him.

His back was pressed against a large tree and his face was downcast. He was conscious. He was also listening. That was evident from his trembling ears and occasional reactions in his breathing.

However, he probably did not have the capacity to respond to Subaru's words. That was understandable.

He must have felt helpless against the Great Rabbit, and he must have felt like he had been denied the days he had spent accumulating.

Subaru, who had set up this outcome, did not feel great either. He did not even have a sense of accomplishment for being able to manipulate his opponent according to his expectations.

There was only a sense of exhaustion, and a dim expectation that things might work out. This expectation was neck and neck with the anxiety that things might not work out.

Garfiel: "…What 'bout Granny?"

Subaru: "Ryuzu… Shima-san is waiting in the Sanctuary. Originally, I didn't plan to take Shima-san and the others out in front of the Great Rabbit. But I had Pico and the others push themselves to do it."

Garfiel: "Pico?"

Subaru: "One of the ones who look exactly like Ryuzu-san and Shima-san, except for the fact that she's not them."

Garfiel wrinkled his nose in displeasure at Subaru's answer.

Subaru somewhat understood why Garfiel had that reaction. Garfiel probably wanted to distinguish between Ryuzu-san and the others.

The grandmother, whom he loved, from the replicas, who were just identical dolls.

Maybe Garfiel was more rational in his approach to the replicas. Subaru would not have named her Pico if he had known how the replicas worked.

But, he had already given her that name. Subaru could not change it now.

Subaru: “Even so, I had to borrow their strength to bring you out and to attract the Great Rabbit… However, it seems that even if we delay their advance, we cannot change their course.”

Garfiel: “Ain’t gonna know unless ya give it a shot, ya know…”

Subaru: “No, I do know. —I’ve tried it many times already.”

Garfiel: “What…?”

Garfiel cleared his throat, dissatisfied when he could not understand what he meant.

However, Subaru did not intend to answer his question in detail. He only used the fact that his answer was not a bluff or anything of the sort as the basis.

The Great Rabbit’s course could not be changed. They were heading straight for the Sanctuary.

Therefore—

Subaru: “Evacuate the residents of the Sanctuary. Everyone in Arlam Village, too. I don’t want you to get in the way of that. That’s why I warned you about the crisis.”

Garfiel: “—. I get that we can’t do shit ’bout ta Great Rabbit. But, what’cha gonna do ’bout it?”

Subaru: “What do we do?”

Garfiel: “It’s obvious! The barrier! As long as the barrier’s up, no one ‘cept my amazin’ self can leave the Sanctuary! Not ’til that princess smashes through the Trial…”

The residents of the Sanctuary could not escape the forest because their souls would be repelled by the barrier.

Subaru nodded in response to Garfiel’s point with a “yeah”. It was indeed a daunting task to overcome the Trial that Emilia had been challenging in the tomb.

Subaru: “But, there’s an alternative to that. Don’t worry about it.”

Garfiel: “Alternative? What’re ya gonna do?”

Subaru: “It’s simple. —I’ll clear the Trial myself. And for the remaining two, I’ll do them in Emilia’s place.”

Garfiel: “…What?”

Garfiel was surprised by Subaru’s confident assertion as he poked his own chest with his thumb.

Looking at Garfiel’s stunned expression, Subaru noticed that his face, which had lost its ruggedness, appeared rather young. He had not noticed it before due to the numerous tense situations, but perhaps Garfiel was younger than Subaru thought.

Anyway, the resolution of such an unhelpful question would have to wait.

Subaru: “I’ve already completed the first Trial. I know what the second Trial entails. Honestly, it’s difficult content… but probably just a matter of getting used to it.”

Garfiel: “Gettin’ used ta it?”

Subaru: “Yeah. I just hope I don’t get upset every time I’m shown something I don’t want to see.”

Regardless of whether or not such a forceful clearing of the Trial was intended, Subaru's plan to overcome the second Trial was something along those lines.

The so-called unthinkable present showed many afterlifes upon worlds in which Subaru had Returned by Death—the pain and suffering of which he endured with a broken heart.

Even so, Natsuki Subaru believed what stood beyond was a happy future for everyone, which he sought.

Subaru: "That nasty, evil Witch just keeps playing coy, refusing to share anything about the third Trial…"

However, since the first Trial was about the past, and the second Trial occurred in the present, one could vaguely imagine that the third Trial would be about the future.

Although it was unclear what kind of hellish future awaited him after the unpleasant past and the painful alternate present—

Subaru: "—If that's what's supposed to break my spirit, then I won't stop."

He did not have an unbreakable spirit that would not be shattered by any impact.

Rather, the strength of Subaru's heart, no matter how much he strengthened it, would only be as fragile as glass. Even though it might appear hard on the surface, it would crack and shatter with a strong enough impact.

However, the fact that it could be broken was not a problem. If glass were to be heated, it could be melted and reshaped.

The Authority given to Natsuki Subaru was, in short, the power to do so.

Garfiel: "…"

Hearing Subaru's confident words, Garfiel held his breath.

He probably wanted to bite Subaru's head off and say, "Don't be ridiculous". However, Subaru's actions up to this point had silenced Garfiel's budding rebelliousness.

Subaru, as an Apostle of Greed, had demonstrated abilities higher than Garfiel; informing him of the existence of the Great Rabbit and the threat it posed to the Sanctuary, opening the barrier that originating from the tomb, assuring him that he could clear the Trial that Garfiel himself had been so frustrated by.

Subaru: "…It's not your fault, Garfiel."

With those words, Subaru addressed the profile of Garfiel, who faced his own weakness.

No one was at fault. The situation, the environment, and the timing were all different types of bad—

Subaru: "—It's just that your luck was bad."

8

???: "—Congratulations! The threat to the Sanctuary has been eliminated!"

Subaru: "…"

???: “Hmm? You are not responding well. From what I could gather from your Memories, I thought this was a stylistic element of a celebration.”

As she said this, Echidna tilted her head, having greeted Subaru with a loud burst of sound.

In the hands of the confused Witch lie a cone-shaped, cylindrical party item, which had exploded with a dry sound—a party cracker, to put it simply.

Although it was probably an item that did not exist in this other world, in this fantastic space created by the Witch of Greed, it was no surprise that manipulating her imagination into shape was her specialty.

Subaru: “…The idea certainly isn’t bad. Just, your ability to read the room is hopeless.”

Echidna: “Oh my, that is not something to just let slide. Saying that I cannot read the room is, quite simply, an insult, is it not? Why should I receive such an evaluation?”

Subaru’s comment on the colorful tape, which had popped out of the party cracker, as he removed it off his head was met with an objection from Echidna, who put her hands on her hips as if to express her opinion.

Echidna’s lips pouted, and she seemed to be very upset that her elaborate hospitality had not been well received. In the first place, her attitude was already an indication of her hopeless lack of discernment.

Subaru: “You can grasp what’s happening on the outside through this crystal, right?”

Echidna: “Hmm? Yes, that is correct. A proof of our Contract… through that Magic Crystal, I can see everything you can, including outside the Sanctuary. What about it?”

Echidna furrowed her brow as Subaru pointed to the Magic Crystal hanging from his neck.

Subaru sighed heavily at the confused atmosphere. Echidna, dissatisfied with his layered reaction, complained with a “What is it?”, but she was genuinely at a loss for an answer.

Subaru: “I took Garfiel before the Great Rabbit and made him taste powerlessness. Did you think I’d be happy being celebrated for something that didn’t leave a good taste in my mouth?”

Echidna: “…I thought you would. Conversely, if you cannot be happy about this, then what can you be happy about?”

Subaru: “Ugh…”

When the question was asked back, Subaru stumbled over Echidna’s words.

Spreading her arms in front of Subaru, Echidna, with her quivering white eyelashes, said “Listen please?”.

Echidna: “At present, hostility with Garfiel, who was the biggest obstacle in the Sanctuary, has been avoided, and you now have the potential to save those close to you, including your beloved girlfriend. Is this not the result of your struggles and accumulated deaths? And yet, you cannot be happy about it?”

Subaru: "…"

Echidna: "Natsuki Subaru, I am not asking you to become inhuman. Given Garfiel's situation and position, it is understandable to sympathize with him. But, that does not diminish your own achievements."

Facing the silent Subaru, Echidna reiterated her thoughts to make him reconsider.

Indeed, she was right; if he only looked at the results, he had chosen the best route. He had avoided hostility with Garfiel, and managed to steer clear of unnecessary confrontation with Shima. Garfiel, having learned about the threat of the Great Rabbit, would take the initiative to help evacuate the residents of the Sanctuary and the people of Arlam Village.

This would also lead to helping Emilia, Ram, and Otto.

Echidna: "Even if you were to praise yourself for your efforts, no one would blame you."

Subaru: "Echidna…"

Echidna: "If I may add, my assistance has played a part in the results you have achieved. If you are feeling down, it would not give me, your contractor, a pleasant feeling either."

Echidna, hands clasped behind her waist and leaning forward, peered upward at Subaru. Subaru felt suffocated by her gaze and words.

Subaru was so distressed by the sight of Garfiel fighting the Great Rabbit, shedding blood and tears, that it left him with a pessimistic view that he could not fully approve of his own actions.

That was why he had pointed out that Echidna could not read the room when they both saw the same thing but felt differently; however, it was Subaru who was actually unable to read the atmosphere, and had been hopelessly insensitive.

It was only natural that Echidna, his contractor, would be displeased.

Subaru: "…My bad. I wasn't paying enough attention to my surroundings."

Echidna: "Are you reflecting on it?"

Subaru: "Yes, I'm reflecting on it."

Echidna: "Can you promise to not excessively belittle yourself?"

Subaru: "Okay, I promise. Honestly, it's not my strong suit."

Echidna: "Can you say that you have been saved by the feelings of the intellectual and compassionate Echidna?"

Subaru: "Don't get carried away."

Approaching forcefully, he flicked his finger on the forehead of Echidna, who was gradually intensifying her demands.

"Gyah!" said Echidna, who was bending over and holding her forehead with her hand, becoming teary-eyed. With this little drama at his side, Subaru thanked the Witch inwardly and took his place at the tea party.

Atop a green hill, facing the Witch at a white table, that was Subaru's reserved seat.

The backrest creaked as he sprawled and sat roughly with his legs stretched out. Watching Subaru's behavior, Echidna, still holding her forehead, narrowed her eyes,

Echidna: "…Could it be, that you are embarrassed?"

Subaru: "*Ding ding ding*."

Echidna: "Does that sound mean "correct answer"?"

Subaru: "That's the sound of your likability dropping."

Her saying what should have remained unspoken, made him reconsider his relinquishing of her disgrace of being a "Witch who cannot read the room".

In any case, Echidna took her designated seat, and snapped her fingers conspicuously.

Instantly, the Dona tea, which had become tradition, was prepared.

Subaru: "…Hey, if you can bring out crackers, does that mean food and drinks are also free to choose? Then, can you give me a cola? Not bodily fluids."

Echidna: "Even if I were to recreate that cola, the ingredients would be no different from the tea you despise."

Subaru: "It's about setting the mood. Warm and cold are different, right?"

Echidna: "Is that so? Well, I shall consider it."

After receiving a less-than-reliable reply, Subaru had no choice but to reluctantly take a sip of warm tea. Since he would feel like he had lost if he tasted the tea, he swallowed it down in one gulp.

After gulping down his tea, Subaru rudely placed his cup on the table. At that moment, his eyes met with Echidna's, who was gazing at him with a relaxed smile on her lips.

Subaru: "What's up?"

Echidna: "Well, I have started to feel like I can rely upon you a bit more… If we get a bit more comfortable with our Contract, then you will be able to talk to me without having to come all the way to the tomb."

Subaru: "—. Does that mean I can just talk to you normally outside?"

Echidna: "Ah, is that not delightful? Since you probably have a lot of situations where you wish to discuss your thoughts with someone."

Echidna smiled at Subaru while resting her chin on her folded hands.

Subaru was hesitant to agree with her words, but it was true that if he could freely communicate with Echidna outside, his range of actions would be greatly expanded.

It was difficult for him to justify going to the tomb every time he needed to consult with her.

Subaru: "Is this like an expansion of the functionality of this Magic Crystal? Can you tell me in advance what kind of updates are planned in the future?"

Echidna: "Do you require benefits beyond constant communication with me? …Oh, no, I simply am joking. There is no need for you to give me that scary look. Let me see, for example…"

Subaru: "For example?"

Echidna: “You will be able to come and go from the tea party freely. In other words, you can meet me anytime you want.”

Subaru: “I see… so, there aren’t any significant benefits.”

Echidna: “You are really cold and unforgiving, no?”

He sighed at Echidna’s bland attitude, which was a response he should have expected.

However, he did not want to be greedy. Just being able to rely on Echidna as a consultant in his situation, where he was being thrown around, would bring him great mental relief.

If that were the case—

Subaru: “—So, shall we aim to release the Sanctuary right away?”

Echidna: “Oh my, are you already planning to challenge the next Trial? Perhaps you could take it a little slower…”

Subaru: “Will I really not be punished for being lazy? …No, I will be.”

The more idle one was, the more fate would mercilessly take away what was important to them.

Knowing this from personal experience, Subaru did not succumb to Echidna’s tempting suggestion of idleness. Even if he could redo it, it was better to not risk losing anything at all.

Subaru: “It was a good opportunity to see what happens after each Death.”

Echidna: “Originally, the second Trial was not supposed to be that way. In your case, the alternate Present from the current one has become a deadly poison. However, it seems as though you can overcome this with brute force.”

Echidna raised both hands and teased Subaru’s head-on approach.

It was a *banzai* attack based on the premise that one’s heart would be shattered, and was deserving of being mocked as reckless. If Subaru were alone, he would never have chosen it, but—

Subaru: “I have a lot of things to say, but I’m grateful to you.”

Slowly standing up from his chair, Subaru told that to Echidna before leaving the tea party.

It was an embarrassing topic to discuss eye-to-eye, so he turned his face away and spoke a little quickly. Perhaps that was why Echidna stared at him with a surprised expression and said “Eh?” as her eyes widened.

However, he did not feel like repeating it again. So, he turned his back and walked away.

Echidna: “Wait a minute, wait a minute! If you are going to say something, say it properly!”

Subaru: “Get lost. No, don’t get lost. You’re the <u>type</u> of <u>character</u> who can’t take a joke, so I can’t mess around with you. Just be quiet.”

Echidna: “Wah, you spoke so fast! Which means, that was not a misunderstanding on my part just now!”

Subaru: “Shut up, shut up, shut up!”

As if she had just taken a demon’s head off, Echidna was shouting at Subaru’s back as he walked down the hill. Subaru covered his ears with his hands and decided to ignore her voice, saying he could not hear her.

Subaru: “Damn it, I shouldn’t have said that…!”

It was just a whim, he had pressed the wrong button in his heart; that was how he convinced himself firmly.

He was sure that he had seen a glimmer of hope in this dead-end situation, which had relaxed the chains on his heart a little. He might have also been swayed by the Witch’s sweet words from earlier.

After all, he could not be proud of himself for crushing Garfiel’s spirit. It was difficult to pride oneself on the result of hard work. —Even so, it was all thanks to Echidna.

Subaru: “You wicked Witch! I’ll deal with the rest of the Trials you’ve set up in a heartbeat!”

Subaru turned around and declared such to the Witch on the hill, flipping his middle finger towards her.

Since she was an ally rather than an enemy, there was no need to go out of his way to swear at her, but it was all due to the heat of the moment.

By encouraging himself in this way, he would be able to more easily attract favorable results.

It was a sort of jinx for Subaru, who had gone through a trial and error process before he caught this glimmer of light.

Echidna: “Isn’t wicked Witch is a bit too much…”

Echidna pouted at Subaru’s words.

But, she then quickly drove away her expression with a sigh, and smiled at her contractor as he pressed forth.

Echidna: “Give it a try, Natsuki Subaru. Are you really going to be able to pass a Witch’s challenge?”

Subaru: “Bring it on! I’ll show you what I can do. Go ahead and watch from the sidelines.”

The gazes of the Witch and the contractor crossed, and the challenge to overcome a new obstacle began.

However, there was no need to be afraid. With the Witch’s help, victory was assured. Even if it was just by a thin thread, the Witch had proven her insight to make it through.

The high, high walls surrounding the Sanctuary, which had seemed impossible to overcome alone. —They had been overcome by Echidna, with two hundred and thirty-two accreted Deaths of Subaru.

Echidna: “I shall support you as much as possible, Natsuki Subaru. —Please do your best, for my sake.”

Subaru: “I’ll do my best, but it won’t be for you!”

Subaru received the Witch’s cheers, unable to become serious until the end, and pushed open the door connecting the Castle of Dreams and reality, which lie beyond.

He was enveloped in a white light, and his consciousness returned. —Again, this was a reality where he would continue to struggle against Death.

And so, the Witch that was left behind smiled as she watched her contractor depart.

The white chair she was sitting in creaked, and she let her white hair flutter in the gentle breeze—

Echidna: “For someone who is not doing this for me… I wonder if that is really true?”

If that was so, why did the two hundred and thirty-two Deaths feel like a gift, stirring up her heart?

While rolling around this overwhelming feeling in her chest, the Witch of Greed sneered.

—With that smile, she decided to watch over her contractor’s struggles, fierce fights, and brave deaths through the Magic Crystal.

PROLOGUE II:

THE WITCHBEAST MASTER

—From the beginning, they had known that it was going to be a job unlike any other.

???: “Huff, huff…”

Gasping for breath, they trod through the dirt path, repeatedly glancing back over their shoulder.

They had been instructed to give heed to nothing else at all while they were running. They had been sternly warned that looking back would only slow them down and shorten their life.

Yet, they could not stop themselves from disobeying and looking back.

Such was the terror of the unknown that it eclipsed and obliterated the caution they usually observed.

???: “This is strange… so stra~nge…!”

Her face pale, the girl’s cherry blossom-colored lips trembled as she lamented the absurdity of the world.

Girl: “This, this is just like…”

—It was just like a nightmare.

She gasped and shook her head, trying to dispel the thoughts that had popped into her mind.

It was as if the enemy had foreseen everything: every hiding place, every plan, everything. Even the backup strategies she had prepared for unforeseen situations had been anticipated, leaving her with no escape route.

Even with all that said, she was nowhere near a position where she could merely quietly surrender on her own accord.

Should she be caught and fall into the hands of the enemy, she could not even fathom the kind of cruelty she would suffer; not at the hands of her enemy, but her own comrades. There was a certain negative trust that they would certainly carry out that cruelty.

An inner fear born from this negative trust. —And yet, even that was now secondary.

A different kind of hell, distinct from the one she had experienced countless times before, was rapidly closing in on her.

Girl: “Shadow Lion-chan…!”

Gasping for breath, a word of regret slipped from the corner of her lips.

In the distance, beyond the thick foliage of the trees, she could hear the Witchbeast that she had sent in—the death throes of the Shadow Lion, the Guiltilaw.

A Witchbeast unparalleled in its ferocity and cruelty. Yet, the Shadow Lion that had been dispatched to delay the enemy had fought in vain, falling prey to their venomous fangs and losing its life. —No, it was uncertain if it had even managed to put up a fight at all. The Shadow Lion was indeed a strong Witchbeast, but it had a tendency to charge straight ahead without thinking.

That reckless nature might have made it the perfect prey for this enemy.

Girl: "—Hk"

The more she thought about it, the more she felt she had made the wrong choice.

Right from the beginning, when she had returned to her hideout after finishing her patrols, she was trapped. From that moment on, she had been completely at the mercy of the enemy. The Witchbeasts she had gathered were all hunted down with Fire Magic Stones, and the remaining fighting force of her Witchbeasts was steadily whittled away, leaving the girl with no choice but to flee.

Sending the Shadow Lion out had been a hasty decision. She should have kept it by her side to protect herself, until the very end.

She was always one step behind. —In truth, it was supposed to be her forcing the enemy into such decisions.

Girl: "Elsa~…!"

Just as her options dwindled and her voice grew faint, her thin throat called out for her one and only ally.

The name had not been that of a Witchbeast controlled by her Divine Protection, nor of someone who had been ordered to accompany her by her terrifying Mother; it was the name of the one person she could truly consider her ally.

She was not here right now. She had been summoned and temporarily left her position. Ordered to stay behind, the girl was the only one remaining at the post. It was then that she was attacked.

Could it be, that even that summons was a ploy to separate her from her ally?

Girl: "It's just, so wei~rd…"

Such a scheme was beyond merely predicting someone's actions.

To control, manipulate, reel in the opponent's actions, and finally achieve their inscrutable stratagem—was it not truly like the handiwork of a Witch?

???: "—Finally ran out of cards, huh? You really were a pain."

Girl: "—Hk"

Immediately afterwards, the girl's strength left her legs as she held her breath at the sound of the voice that had been thrown her way.

She slumped down and turned around. Her eyes met those of a figure emerging from the shadows of the trees she had just passed, and her throat went dry.

Girl: "—Ah, ah."

She had been wondering who could have set up such a trap, her mind swirling with confusion.

She had considered the two maids left behind in the mansion—aside from the Spirit she had heard about, one of them might have noticed their hidden presence and launched a counterattack. In that case, since one of the maids was someone she was familiar with, it naturally led her to suspect the other woman.

However, she was mistaken. Completely off the mark. —No, she should have realized it sooner.

Even Elsa had mentioned it. He was present at the scene of the failed mission in the Royal Capital.

The girl herself had seen him there. He was present at the scene when her plan had been thwarted and ended in failure. So why, up until this very moment, had she overlooked such a dangerous opponent?

???: ""He wasn't even on my radar.""

Girl: "…"

???: "And that's fine. In fact, that's what allowed me to set up this situation. Sorry, but I'll have to capture you now."

She was unable to say anything to the one who had read her thoughts.

She could only feel relieved that her life would not be taken here and now, though she was not sure if feeling relieved was the right response. Nevertheless, if she could survive this encounter—

???: "—I can't take Elsa down without you."

Those words, spoken so casually, shattered the faint hope that had begun to take root.

To capture her, and subdue Elsa. To use the girl as a bargaining chip, to make Elsa submit.

The moment she heard that, the girl's vision turned crimson with rage and she tried to bite at him,

Girl: "—Ah."

As she stepped forward, a white handkerchief was pressed against her mouth. The pungent smell assaulted her senses, pulling her consciousness away.

Though she realized she had been made to inhale something, it was too late. Strength drained from her limbs, her knees buckling beneath her. As her body began to collapse, surprisingly strong arms caught her and lifted her up.

—No. He was different, completely unlike the person he once had been.

Girl: "N-No~…"

The hoarse mutter was not directed at herself, nor at the person in front of her, but at someone who was not present.

You must not fight him. You must not challenge him or even face him. —You absolutely cannot win.

Desperately, frantically screaming these words in her heart, the girl's consciousness sank into darkness.

CHAPTER II:

ACCUMULATING LIFE IN ANOTHER WORLD FROM ZERO WITH A WITCH

1

???: “Oh, ooooh—!!”

Using the slope to his advantage, he launched himself upward, his arms outstretched toward the head of the colossal beast towering above him.

At the end of his arms was a pickaxe meant for breaking rock, which he then used with all his strength to slam at the enemy’s head—or rather, into the twisted horn protruding from there.

???: “—!”

The force of the impact reverberated up his arms, and the pickaxe he had struck with all his strength was violently repelled.

Landing on all fours upon the blackened earth, he caught a glimpse of the fallen pickaxe at the edge of his vision, frustration biting at him as he clenched his molars. —He had screwed up.

???: “—AROOOOOO!!”

A deafening roar blasted over him, freezing him in place and momentarily robbing him of control over his whole body.

With its arrival, was an inevitable shock that one could not bear even if one were to anticipate it. The bestial pressure that shook his very core, originating from the overwhelming difference in strength between species.

Pathetically, he had never once been able to withstand such a force, nor had he ever managed to evade it.

Every hair on his body stood on end, his blood froze in his veins, and his lungs ceased their function, as if they had been torn apart.

Even his heart seemed to forget to beat, and by the time his senses returned, it was already too late.

Before his eyes, he saw the gleaming claws of the beast as it swung them down at an angle, directly toward him.

In his strangely slow-moving vision, each claw seemed as large and sharp as a sword, each slash comparable to being torn apart by a bundle of blades.

It is said that when one faces a life-threatening situation, time appears to slow down. It is a defensive instinct of the brain, frantically searching for a way to survive in those fleeting moments.

Experiencing flashbacks during a crisis is similar to this defensive instinct, not as a way to re-experience one's memories, but as a means to search for a method of survival based on past experiences to overcome the immediate crisis.

But alas, how unfortunate. —In this slowed-down world, in all his past experiences, there was not a single way for Natsuki Subaru to escape from this situation.

Subaru: "—Ah."

A merciless slash cut diagonally across Subaru's body, the beast's claws hooking into his chest and abdomen, effortlessly ripping them apart with an unsettling ease that human bodies should not possess.

The burst of blood and the searing pain that followed arrived just a beat too late to register before the surreal sight of his body being torn asunder.

Thanks to that, Subaru was given ample time to thoroughly witness the horrific spectacle of his own body being shredded, a sight that would undoubtedly rank at the very top of the list of things no one should ever witness in their lifetime.

Though the experience of seeing his own organs was not entirely new—

Subaru: "Bgh."

No matter how many times he had seen it, the impression it left never changed.

In an instant, an overwhelming sense of loss surged through him, followed by a searing pain that threatened to consume his mind. His vision became clouded and chaotic, and he fell backward as if his entire body had been ripped away.

The agony, the sense of loss, the encroaching awareness of Death; these feelings jumbled together in his consciousness, turning his mind into a chaotic mess.

But all of it, everything—

???: "—Whoa, that looks pai~nful. You're rea~lly unlucky, Onii-san."

His vision, was white and blurry. Someone appeared beside him. Or perhaps she had stood there all along. It was hard to tell if his ears were working properly. He could only hear a distant, high-pitched ringing. Mixed with that sound, a voice, half-exasperated, half-sympathetic, seemed to reach him.

???: "I don't particularly want to make you suffer, you kno~w? This kind of killing, like Elsa would do, it's not my style at a~ll."

With a shrug, she offered a flimsy excuse. Though, to the one being killed, such words held no meaning. It was merely an attempt to lessen her own guilt. —No, she was probably unaware of that.

This truly was nothing more than idle chatter, made all the more grotesque by the bloody scene around them. She stood over a dying person, his innards spilled out, and

yet spoke as if nothing unusual was happening.

What a monster. Time and time again, he had faced this creature, been killed by it, and learned of its cruel nature.

Subaru: "…"

Whether it was because his ability to feel pain had shut down, his thoughts were hazy, but remained rational.

His mind was already racing ahead to the "Next" time, frantically trying to gather as much information as possible. Even if he could redo everything, there was no reason to repeat the same mistakes.

He must make an effort to pick up every bit of knowledge he could in this loop—

???: "…Wha~t's with that look in your eyes, Onii-san? It's a bit sca~ry. —Shadow Lion-chan."

The presence crouched down right beside him, her voice growing quiet as if she had seen something unsettling. Following the command in that voice, the massive beast that had torn Subaru apart began to move slowly.

Shadow Lion: "—AROOOOOO!!"

The enormous creature growled in displeasure, and Subaru could feel its foul breath wash over him—

???: "Goo~dbye, Onii-san. I'll make su~re to send the others along to you as we~ll."

With those twisted words of misplaced compassion, Subaru's consciousness faded.

He could only imagine his upper body being crushed by the creature's massive jaws as darkness finally overtook him—.

2

Subaru: "—Fucking hell!!"

???: "Whoa there."

In his rage, Subaru swung his leg upwards, his foot colliding violently with the white table, sending it flying.

The steaming white cup, the confections: all of it flipped over, scattering across the green hilltop, and the sharp sound of breaking porcelain echoed as it shattered into pieces.

Perhaps the sound of shattering might have cooled the blood that boiled from his furious mind—

Subaru: "Fuck, fuck fuck fuck fuck fuck…!"

Clawing at his head, Subaru continued to grind his teeth painfully, with little hope for relief.

Frustration. Agitation. His vision turned red as an unbearable fury swirled within him. Though he knew it was pathetic to lash out at objects, he could not control the surge of his emotions.

Treading over the broken cup on the short grass, he sought solace in the sensation of destroying something beneath his heel. Yet, it was futile. The anger, the irritation: both only continued to grow.

???: "You are quite agitated, no?"

Subaru: "Huh?"

Breathing heavily and deeply, Subaru turned his head toward the voice that addressed him.

Beyond the overturned table, sitting calmly in the only chair that remained intact, was a Witch whose existence could be summed up in the stark contrasts of black and white—Echidna.

Before the table was kicked over, she had managed to secure her cup, bringing it to her lips as she serenely observed Subaru, who was consumed by intense emotions. Her calm gaze only served to further irritate him.

Echidna: "It seems like you have hit a wall. From the looks of it, it must have been quite a struggle."

Subaru: "Cut the crap already! Don't talk like it's got nothing to do with you…!"

Echidna: "Unfortunately, at this moment, it really is not my problem. After all, I have not been filled in on what exactly happened to you yet."

Subaru clicked his tongue in frustration as he stepped closer to Echidna, who spoke in an indifferent tone.

Subaru reached into his chest pocket and pulled out the black Magic Crystal that hung around his neck. With a rough motion, he threw it at Echidna.

And then—

Echidna: "Ouch!"

Failing to catch it, the Magic Crystal struck Echidna on the forehead, leaving a cut on her alabaster skin. A pointed edge must have hit her, as a trickle of blood began to seep from the wound, running down the bridge of her nose.

As Echidna licked away the blood that dripped down with a soft swipe of her lips,

Echidna: "That hurt, Natsuki Subaru."

Subaru: "Shut up. I'm sick of your little theatrics."

Echidna: "Theatrics? How rude. I have no desire to suffer pain for no reason. I explored those curiosities fully in life, after all."

As she spoke of memories that hinted at harrowing experiences, Echidna bent down to pick up the Magic Crystal. Pressing it to her still-bleeding forehead,

Echidna: "*Myon myon myon myon myon*…"

She began another one of her familiar, nonsensical antics.

Subaru: "…"

The blood flowed from her forehead, and the Magic Crystal in her hand emitted a faint, eerie glow.

As Subaru watched Echidna's white eyelashes tremble with her eyes closed, he righted the chair he had knocked over and sat down heavily upon it.

He bounced his leg restlessly, dropping his clenched fists onto his knees over and over again. There was nothing here he could destroy in a fit of rage. At best, just the table or his own body.

Echidna: "I would not recommend self-harm. It is not particularly enjoyable to watch, from what I have seen. If you must unleash your violent urges, it is better to direct them at me."

Seeing Subaru's frustration, Echidna made an extreme suggestion.

Echidna had stopped pressing the Magic Crystal to her forehead and had ceased her ridiculous chanting. It seemed she had succeeded in inheriting the Memories and now understood the situation.

In other words—

Echidna: "Despite managing to avoid the issue of the Sanctuary, it seems you have been stuck for quite some time without resolving the problems at the mansion."

Subaru: "…"

Echidna: "Although, since time resets each time you experience Death, what you perceive as a long time is just a matter of your own subjective experience."

Subaru: "…"

Echidna: "Hmm… in the past, when I said something like this, I remember it provoked quite a strong reaction from you. But it seems that trick will not work anymore."

Echidna squinted with one eye, as if disappointed that her attempt to provoke Subaru had failed.

Indeed, there had been a time when her words, filled with empty provocations, had stirred Subaru's anger, causing him to lash out with a fierce impulse.

He could not remember how many times ago that had been, nor did he want to recall that awful memory.

The worst thing was not taking out his anger on something. Subaru knew this, not just as knowledge, but from experience. —That was what truly made it the worst.

Echidna: "It is a pointless regret. After all, was it not my suggestion when we made our Contract? I told you that, when you could no longer bear the weight of your repeated Deaths, you could use me as an outlet. You are free to punch, kick, or even strangle me; whatever you like. Of course, other things are fair game, too."

Subaru: "…Stop it."

Echidna: "Do not worry; I am quite accustomed to most forms of humiliation. Pain is no exception. I can control my emotions, so I am well-suited to be a sandbag."

Subaru: "Stop it."

Echidna: "Or would it comfort you more if I cried and begged, clinging to you for mercy? I am not particularly good at it, but it is not like I cannot do it. If it helps you let off steam, maybe it would not be a bad idea to learn such techniques. I could shed tears, plead for forgiveness, and…"

Subaru: "STOP IT—!!"

Shouting, Subaru surged to his feet and shoved Echidna backward, toppling the chair along with her. Straddling her as she lay on the ground, he wrapped his hands around her slender neck.

Her white hair and black dress were in disarray as Echidna narrowed her black eyes, gazing up at Subaru. As he met her captivating stare, Subaru could hear the thunderous pounding of his own heartbeat in his ears.

If he applied enough pressure with his hands, he could silence her by snapping that slender neck.

And so—

Subaru: "—Ah."

His hesitation lasted only a moment. Perhaps one could say he was overcome by a sudden, wicked urge.

There was a light snapping sound, like breaking a twig, and along with the sound of her breath escaping, a dreadful sensation ran through Subaru's hands. Her body immediately went limp beneath him.

Subaru: "…"

Echidna's head tilted to the side, her flowing hair concealing her face from Subaru's view. Yet, even with her face hidden, the stench of death that clung to the motionless Witch's body was unmistakable.

—She was dead. No, he had killed her. Subaru had snapped her neck with his own hands.

Subaru: "…Urghh."

The hands he pulled away from her pale neck felt unbearably repulsive. A wave of nausea surged up, and with a groan, Subaru vomited up bile from his empty stomach.

Splattering yellow gastric juices across the dead woman's chest, he swung his arms down beside her lifeless body, again and again, wanting his wrists, his forearms, his entire arms to tear off.

The lingering sensation of snapping her neck stayed with him, and it was unbearably revolting.

If it would help him forget that feeling, then he did not need his arms. —No, he did not need anything at all. Not his eyes, ears, nose, mouth, legs, or even his internal organs. Every part that made up his body was unnecessary.

After all, it was all useless. It was just there, making him feel sick. If it was all worthless and had no reason to exist, then it would be better if it were broken. Yes, that would be for the best.

Subaru: "Die, die, die die die die, just die, Natsuki Subaru…!"

Hot tears streamed from the corners of his eyes, and snot smeared across his face.

Thinking himself filthy and repulsive, Subaru stopped using his arms and began to slam his head into the ground over and over. Again, and again, and again—

Subaru: "I'm dirty, dirty, dirty dirty dirty dirty dirty dirty dirty dirty…"

???: "—It is okay, you are not dirty."

Subaru: "…"

As Subaru wished to erase his filthy self, his body was gently embraced from behind.

He held his breath at the warmth of the touch, unable to immediately understand where that comforting warmth was coming from.

However, a familiar voice and warmth pulled Subaru's head closer, whispering softly into his ear.

Echidna: "No matter how much you deny yourself, I will affirm you. You are not wrong. And even if you are, you can make things right. So, there is no need to be anxious."

Subaru: "Ugh…"

Echidna: "Even if you split my forehead, break my neck, and vomit on my corpse, I will forgive you."

It was a form of acceptance so violent that it could hardly be called total affirmation.

It was something seemingly darker, unrelated to kindness or compassion or such warm things; something ill-suited to soft descriptions. That was why it could only be rephrased as acceptance or tolerance.

And, perhaps, because of that, he did not need to harbor false hopes, or suspect some form of deceit.

Subaru: "Ugh, ah, aaahhh—!"

Echidna: "There, there, it is okay. Cry as much as you want. No one else is listening."

Subaru grabbed onto the arms holding him, pouring out the torrent of emotions swirling within his body.

The Witch accepted it, quietly allowing him to do so.

She forgave, accepted, and embraced it all. —As if, she knew that was the best remedy.

3

???: "Have you calmed down now?"

Seated on a chair, Subaru had slumped forward onto the table. A voice called out to him.

However, Subaru could not respond. He held his head in his hands, feeling drained and wishing to escape from everything.

Yet, the Witch, with her insidious nature, blocked any path of escape Subaru might have had.

Echidna: "Oh, I did not hear a reply. Could it be a side effect of having my neck broken?"

Subaru: "…I'm sorry."

Echidna: “Huh? What? Sorry, I did not quite catch that. You know, since my neck was broken.”

Subaru: “I said I’m sorry! And what does breaking your neck have to do with your ears?! Do you lose your hearing if you break your neck?! Who the hell came up with that theory, huh?!”

Infuriated by the persistent Witch’s teasing, Subaru sat up abruptly. In response to his outburst, the white-haired Witch leaned back with an exaggerated “Oh” as the chair creaked beneath her.

Around her slender neck, the marks of strangulation remained, and traces of blood were still visible on her face from the wound on her forehead.

Subaru: “Is this some kind of harassment?”

Echidna: “It is just a bit of cute payback. I was hurt by your tantrum, after all. If I did not retaliate like this, you would just keep feeling guilty, would you not?”

Subaru: “…If that’s your way of being considerate, you probably shouldn’t have said it out loud, should you?”

Echidna: “Sorry. I could not help but prioritize teasing you over being endearing.”

Echidna stuck out her red tongue slightly, a mischievous expression on her face.

Not that Subaru would say that was a bad thing, but he let out a deep sigh. At the same time, he realized that the storm of furious emotions swirling in his chest had subsided, and it was becoming easier to breathe.

This was all thanks to Echidna, who had put herself on the line to help him vent his frustrations.

Echidna: “Well, this is not the first time I have seen you this worked up. I have confidence in the amount of knowledge I have accumulated. —I can handle something like your periodic Days of Wrath.”

Subaru: “…Days of Wrath, huh.”

Echidna: “A fitting naming, is it not? I am also quite fond of the contrasting Days of Calm. They carry the weight of the history we have built together, after all.”

A faint blush colored Echidna’s cheeks as she wore an expression akin to one reminiscing about fond days gone by. However, what she was actually referring to were Subaru’s Days of Wrath, when he was no longer able to suppress his emotions and would explode; and the opposite, the Days of Calm, when his emotions would die, leaving him like a living corpse.

Neither scenario matched the girlish expression Echidna was wearing.

Thinking of this as Echidna’s way of helping muddle Subaru’s feelings of shame might have been giving her a bit too much credit.

Echidna: “I do not mind whatever biased view you have, so long as you keep thinking highly of me.”

Subaru: “…*Ding, ding, ding*.”

Echidna: “Hmm, it seems I did not quite succeed this time. I thought I was getting pretty close, though.”

Echidna shrugged her shoulders, disappointed at having pushed too far. But, she was not wrong.

This time, she had almost managed to change his opinion of her. Not that there was any rule saying he could not reassess or acknowledge her.

Subaru: "But still, it would feel like I lost on an emotional level…"

Echidna: "Well, considering you broke a girl's neck in a fit of anger, it is safe to say you have definitely lost if we had to speak in terms of victory and defeat."

Subaru: "Ugh."

It was such an irrefutable argument that Subaru could only let out a groan as a form of rebuttal.

At any rate—

Echidna: "—It seems like you are struggling."

As the previous topic was wrapped up, she introduced a new subject.

It was one that had caused Subaru's mental state to fluctuate wildly, so his response was anything but cheerful. As Echidna had mentioned, he had successfully managed to avoid the issues surrounding the Sanctuary.

By taking control of Ryuzu Shima, warning Garfiel about the approaching Great Rabbit, and persuading him to help evacuate the people remaining in the settlement, Subaru had cleared the Sanctuary and lifted the barrier surrounding it by completing the Trials in the tomb.

Naturally, he had to pay significant sacrifices to clear the second and third Trials, but,

Subaru: "That was just my death count piling up. It's not a big deal."

Echidna: "True. Seeing you push through with brute force, just as you had declared, was rather refreshing. Though, the second Trial is essentially a one-shot challenge."

Subaru: "A one-shot challenge…"

Echidna: "It is a choice between staying in an alternate Present or coming back. If you fail, the challenger's spirit cannot return here. Quite a risk, would you not agree?"

Echidna spoke nonchalantly, but Subaru was taken aback by the sheer ruthlessness of it.

At the same time, he felt a sense of relief that Emilia had not been forced to undertake such a dangerous Trial.

She, too, needed a chance to challenge herself and break out of her shell.

However, that opportunity did not need to come in a high-stakes situation. One where failure would mean more than just her own life, but also the lives of many others.

Subaru: "Anyway, I've cleared the Trials. Though, it's annoying that every time I start over, I have to take on the Trials again, since my Return by Death resets everything to just before I face the Trials."

Echidna: "Any complaints about that should be directed to the one who has bestowed that Authority upon you. Still, showing them the moment when the barrier

around the Sanctuary breaks has helped you gain the trust of Garfiel and the others, has it not? It has given you quite a bit of extra time."

Subaru: "Yeah, true."

Only when both conditions, the approach of the Great Rabbit and the lifting of the barrier, were met, would Garfiel listen to Subaru. Although his cooperation was reluctant, not having to rack his brains to convince him each time was a result of Subaru's repeated trial and error.

However, the other issue that had arisen simultaneously with the Sanctuary had yet to be resolved, despite Subaru's numerous attempts through trial and error.

Echidna: "The duo that appears at the Roswaal mansion, the Bowel Hunter, and the Witchbeast Master…"

Subaru: "…No matter how many times I go through it, someone always ends up getting killed. Beatrice, Petra, Frederica… and, Rem."

Echidna: "And, half of the villagers who stayed behind in Arlam Village. If only you could decide whom you wanted to prioritize in saving…"

Subaru: "—Echidna."

Subaru stopped rubbing his forehead and called out to Echidna in a low voice. Immediately, Echidna withdrew her statement, raising both hands and saying "I was just kidding".

This, too, was an argument they had gone through many times before—if Subaru could choose whom to save, more options might open up, and he could find a breakthrough.

Trying to save both the mansion and the village was what made it impossible. If he could just ease up on his efforts to save the villagers, how much easier would it be—.

Subaru: "There's no way I'd be allowed that kind of weakness."

Echidna: "Not allowed, you say? And who exactly would not allow it? The God from your world?"

Subaru: "…"

Echidna: "Sorry to disappoint, but there is no God in this world. The closest thing would be something called Od Lagna, but it has no will, nor does it judge people."

The term "Od Lagna" was one he had heard a few times before. —It seemed to refer to an unimaginably vast conceptual existence in this other world.

It existed, but did nothing. In a way, it might have been similar to the God Subaru knew from his own world. In that sense, he agreed with Echidna.

However—

Subaru: "It's not God, or whatever that Od thing is, that wouldn't allow it. It's me."

Echidna: "Hmm…"

Subaru: "Choosing whom to save and whom to let die is the kind of thinking a God would do. If I start picking and choosing whom to save, I'd be no different from some mechanical God."

In the end, Subaru was just an ordinary, mundane human being.

Those under the delusion of excessive power or authority would easily be led astray. Subaru knew that once he crossed a certain line, he would start taking the easy way out.

That was why, he could never lower the hurdle he had set for himself.

Subaru: "I'm going to save everyone, both those in the mansion and the village. I won't decide whose life is worth saving and whose isn't. Don't make me have this conversation again."

Echidna: "I shall keep that in mind. However, you have to understand that I am not always aware of your past experiences before sharing your Memories with me, so please be a bit lenient on that."

Subaru: "Then, at least act as my strategist, and show that you're worth having around."

Subaru and Echidna exchanged sharp words, glaring at each other. Then, with a snap of Echidna's fingers, their usual tea and tea cakes were laid out on the table.

Indeed, this routine had become so ingrained that it could have been called their usual way of operating.

From breaking her neck to losing his sanity, the repeated trial and error were filled with grim, inevitable events.

In such an environment, maintaining some routine of normalcy was necessary to avoid being swallowed by madness.

So, Subaru and Echidna each picked up a cup and drank their tea.

—To set aside the notion that both killing the Witch and engaging in self-harm were simply part of the bargain.

Echidna: "Anyway, let us get back to the main topic. Though, the cause of death this time is pretty clear."

Subaru: "…Yeah. I got my head bitten off by one of the beasts of the Witchbeast Master, of Meili."

Subaru responded as he straightened his posture, refocusing on the main issue that Echidna had brought up.

To be precise, Subaru's death was sealed the moment he was struck by the beast's claws. His entire front had been ripped open, and with his insides spilling out, there was no way he could have survived.

However, more than the fatal injuries, it was the shocking impact that was etched into his memory. Being eaten headfirst by a Witchbeast was, after all, a particularly intense experience.

Honestly, being eaten by a Witchbeast was not an uncommon cause of death for him lately. Even so, he could never get used to the feeling of his very existence being devoured and lost to another creature.

Echidna: "Just when you managed to avoid getting chomped on by the Great Rabbit in the Sanctuary."

Subaru: “Whether it’s a giant Witchbeast or a small one, being eaten feels just as bad either way… It’s impressive, that Wilhelm-san managed to escape from the White Whale’s belly, though.”

Echidna: “His training was on a different level, and when you are talking about such a vast difference in size, that changes things as well.”

In Subaru’s memories, it felt like ages ago when he had faced off against the White Whale. And yet, he recalled Wilhelm, who had once been swallowed by the creature during that battle.

In the end, he had managed to slice his way out of the Witchbeast’s body, and escape from within.

Could the difference really be attributed to something as simple as a difference in physical capability?

Echidna: “You do not think it is just a matter of sheer determination, do you?”

Subaru: “—. You think it’s unrelated?”

Echidna: “Not just unrelated; I think it is a nonsensical notion. Firstly, how much of a difference in determination do you think there is between an old swordsman, who has spent over a decade hunting the Witchbeast that killed his wife, and you, who continues to die to protect those around you?”

Subaru: “I…”

Echidna: “It is not something that can be quantified. That is why I will say it again: this is pure nonsense.”

Echidna cut down Subaru’s thoughts without mercy, her voice firm.

The way that she occasionally slipped in words from Subaru’s world was a result of her learning from viewing his Memories, as well as a sort of persuasive tool.

The extent to which Echidna understood Subaru was precisely what made her arguments compelling when he was seized by weak thoughts, becoming a reason for him to listen to her.

Subaru: “But, if it’s not about a lack of determination, then what am I supposed to do to fill that gap…?”

Echidna: “—Hmm. Perhaps, we need to approach this from a different angle. Up until now, you have focused all of your efforts on defeating the Guiltilaw, the Witchbeast Master’s trump card. Correct?”

Subaru: “…Yeah. There were times when things went well when I just killed it.”

Nodding at Echidna’s words, Subaru recalled the Witchbeast that had devoured him.

The Shadow Lion, the Guiltilaw, was a Witchbeast with the head of a lion and a body that looked like it was made up of parts from various animals. It had the appearance of something akin to a chimera, and was just as troublesome to deal with.

In any case, it had immense physical strength and was extremely ferocious. Because of its somewhat reckless nature, like that of a charging wild boar, there were a few times when it had been brought down by traps. However, that only dealt with the

Guiltilaw itself, and did nothing to address the problem of Meili, who was controlling the Witchbeast.

Therefore, he was seeking more than just the defeat of the Guiltilaw.

Subaru: "That's why, I want to break its horn."

Echidna: "If the horn of a Witchbeast is broken, the Witchbeast must obey the commands of the one who broke it. If you can tame the Guiltilaw, it might provide a countermeasure against the Witchbeast Master. However…"

Subaru: "—? However, what? The way you're saying it, it's definitely not going to be good news."

Furrowing her well-shaped eyebrows, Echidna hesitated, causing Subaru to grimace.

In recent attempts, he had been repeating Deaths with the strategy of trying to steal away Meili's powerful Witchbeast pawn. Echidna's hesitation seemed to be throwing cold water on that plan.

Echidna: "I mean, it is a bit hard to say it."

Subaru: "I see. Well, I'll go ahead and die a few times with the current plan until you make up your mind… it's not like I'll say that. Each and every time, I'm doing it with the literal intention of dying."

Echidna: "I understand. I do not want to have my neck broken by you again in a fit of madness."

Subaru: "Look, I've already apologized for that…"

As Echidna brought up the topic they had previously put behind them, Subaru glared at her. In response to his piercing gaze, Echidna raised both hands and said, "You win, you win".

Echidna: "Really, there is no need to make such a scary face. It is not like I am simply joking around."

Subaru: "If you want me to believe that, then start talking. What's so hard to say?"

Echidna: "Alright… I think it would be better to give up on the plan, to break the Witchbeast's horn."

With a raised finger, Echidna proposed a complete reversal of their strategy.

Subaru's eyes widened slightly at her words, but he quickly took a deep breath to calm himself. He did not immediately raise his voice in anger.

Subaru: "Let's hear your reasoning first. We can talk after that."

Echidna: "I appreciate your rationality. It is not a complicated matter. Do you remember what I told you about how Me… how that girl controls the Witchbeasts?"

Subaru: "—It's the Divine Protection of Fiend Manipulation, right? You said it's a Divine Protection that allows her to command Witchbeasts."

Echidna: "That is correct. Even without breaking a Witchbeast's horn, she can control them just like someone who has broken it. It is a Divine Protection that truly befits the Witchbeast Master."

Subaru narrowed his eyes at Echidna, who nodded while clasping her hands in front of her chest.

The coercive power of a Witchbeast's horn was perhaps the only fair characteristic of these dangerous and ferocious creatures, which were not even suitable for consumption. Despite this, Meili could ignore this fundamental principle, and convince the Witchbeasts she was their master, exerting her control over them.

Echidna: "That said, there is a limit to Divine Protections. Your plan to break the Guiltilaw's horn was based upon expecting that limit."

Subaru: "If we actually break the horn, we could find out whether the Divine Protection or the horn's coercive power is stronger…"

The recent deadly battle had been, in a sense, a challenge to determine that. Unfortunately, even when he had managed to land a powerful blow, the Witchbeast's horn did not budge, resulting in a series of futile deaths.

However, what seemed like meaningless deaths to Subaru was not necessarily viewed the same way by the Witch.

Echidna: "Even if you did not manage to break it, you dealt considerable damage to the horn. It would not be strange if that had caused some disruption in the Guiltilaw's movements. And yet, there was no such effect. Perhaps…"

Subaru: "Perhaps?"

Echidna: "Perhaps there was no effect because Meili's Divine Protection, is far stronger than we anticipated."

Comparing her knowledge with the current situation, Echidna reassessed the power of Meili's Divine Protection.

Then, with a snap of her fingers, Echidna said, "Listen up,"

Echidna: "—Is this not just perfect for putting our thoughts in order?"

As Echidna spoke triumphantly, the world around Subaru abruptly transformed before his eyes.

The green hill where the tea party was taking place changed in an instant, and before he knew it, Subaru found himself in a familiar place—inside a school classroom.

Before he knew it, both Subaru and Echidna were wearing school uniforms.

Just like when they had met in the fabricated past world, during the first Trial in the tomb.

Subaru: "…What's the meaning of this?"

Echidna: "Like I said, it is to help us sort things out. I wanted to use this thing called a blackboard. As for our outfits, think of them as a little surprise."

Echidna swished the hem of her short skirt playfully as she walked over to the blackboard. Grabbing a piece of chalk, she began writing in white letters, thoughtfully laying out information in Subaru's native Japanese.

Her writing was authentic, using hiragana, katakana, and even kanji with great proficiency.

Subaru: “If you accidentally got reincarnated into my world, I have a hunch you’d do just fine.”

Echidna: “I appreciate the compliment, but it is all thanks to peeking into your Memories. It is kind of like cheating.”

Subaru: “Then, I’ll praise you for being good at cheating.”

Echidna: “I am not sure if being called a good cheater is really a compliment.”

With a wry smile, Echidna continued writing on the blackboard without hesitation.

Watching her back, Subaru rested his chin on his hands atop the desk in the classroom, a place that held no fond memories for him. Outside the window, he could faintly see the schoolyard and the cityscape.

If this place truly was a perfect recreation of the world from the Trial—

Echidna: “—Your parents, they are not here.”

Subaru: “…”

Echidna: “If I gave you false hope, I do apologize. I only borrowed this classroom because I needed it.”

Placing the chalk down, Echidna spoke to Subaru, who was gazing outside.

Subaru replied softly with a simple, “I see”. Even if this world had been perfectly recreated and his ersatz parents were here, what would it matter?

Would he cry to them about being thrown into situations where his emotions repeatedly exploded and sank like clockwork, making him feel as if he were in hell?

Subaru: “Like I could ever be that unfilial… Echidna, continue your explanation.”

Echidna: “Understood. Now, please look at the blackboard.”

Without any unnecessary consideration, Echidna pointed to what was written on the board.

Drawn in white chalk were the names of Witchbeasts and a series of simple illustrations depicting them. The drawings, capturing the creatures’ distinctive features, were surprisingly well-done, causing Subaru to widen his eyes in astonishment.

Echidna: “It might come as a surprise, but I have written quite a few books. Including illustrations makes things easier to understand, so I can do this much.”

Subaru: “I see, I’m genuinely surprised. So, about these illustrations…”

Echidna: “There is the Shadow Lion, the Double-Headed Serpent, the Blackwinged Mice… and, I think I saw a Rock Pig in the mix.”

Drawn on the blackboard were images of Meili’s forces, the Witchbeasts she had used to attack the Roswaal mansion. The approximate numbers and size comparisons were also sketched out, making the information easy to comprehend, although it was frustrating to admit.

Echidna: “These are the Witchbeast troops you need to handle. Any questions?”

Subaru: “Ah, I have a question that isn’t specifically about the mansion, but about Witchbeasts in general… for example, if the horn of the boss of a herd is broken, what happens? Will the rest of the herd submit as well?”

It was a notion derived from stories in his original world, the kind of scenarios often seen in manga or anime, where defeating the leader of a group would result in the entire group falling under the victor's control.

He wondered if such rules could also apply to the Witchbeasts, and whether this could serve as a countermeasure against Meili's Divine Protection—

Echidna: "It is an interesting conjecture, but that is not how it works. If the leader… the boss of a herd has its horn broken, that individual loses its status as the leader. The moment its horn is broken, it is deemed unfit to be at the head of the herd."

Subaru: "…Well, that does sound like a likely rule."

If the hierarchy of wild animals was determined by strength, then a leader whose horn was broken would not maintain its position. For Witchbeasts, it seemed that having a broken horn symbolized weakness.

To damage such a symbolic trait was to invite that outcome. He had also heard about this before from Ram.

An Oni with a broken horn would be scorned and called hornless.

Echidna: "In other words, there is no loophole in the rules. We have to face Meili's Divine Protection head-on, even if it is an unfair advantage."

Subaru: "Unfair advantage, huh… I'm sure Meili would say the same thing about me, a Witch's accomplice who uses Return by Death."

Echidna: "I would have to disagree with that. Authorities are privileges that allow one to interfere with the world, while Divine Protections are like afterthoughts, tacked on as a nuisance to people like us."

Subaru: "I feel like this is important information, but it doesn't seem related to subduing Meili, does it?"

Echidna: "Oh my, you still are not interested in indulging my digressions, are you?"

Echidna shrugged her shoulders, looking dissatisfied as she stood at the podium. However, Subaru was not concerned with the truths of the world, or of the origins of Witches.

His only focus, was on overcoming the obstacles in his path, and securing a future with everyone.

Subaru: "Let's get back on track. What did you mean when you said Meili's Divine Protection might be far stronger than we anticipated?"

Echidna: "It is not commonly known, but… Divine Protections can have individual differences, and even potential for growth."

Subaru: "Seriously?"

Echidna: "Yes, seriously."

Echidna nodded repeatedly, smiling as she affirmed Subaru's surprise.

Her attitude was rather frivolous, but for Subaru, who did not possess a Divine Protection, it was a complete shock. Since he naturally did not have one, he never had the chance to think deeply about Divine Protections in the first place.

Echidna: “For example, the Divine Protection of Wind Evasion, which the whole species of ground dragons possesses, is an easy one to understand. This Divine Protection prevents the wind or any turbulence from affecting them while they run… however, the range and duration of the Divine Protection can vary greatly between a ground dragon that has run long distances and consistently used the Divine Protection, and one that has not.”

Subaru: “So, that’s what you mean by individual differences and growth in Divine Protections.”

Echidna: “In most cases, if their Divine Protection were to stop working, it is usually assumed that the ground dragon simply got tired from running. Since ground dragons do not talk, it is easy for it to go unnoticed.”

Other than the example of ground dragons, it seemed that users of Divine Protections could often use their abilities more effectively as adults than they could as children.

This was often misunderstood as simply becoming more accustomed to their Divine Protections over time.

Echidna: “Many cannot fully grasp the potential of their Divine Protections, and end up being overwhelmed by them during childhood. There may even be people close to you who have suffered because of their Divine Protections.”

Subaru: “When you put it like that, Divine Protections don’t seem like they’re just convenient powers.”

Echidna: “They truly are not. Having a power that others do not have might make one feel special, but having a third arm or a third eye does not necessarily make a person happy.”

Subaru: “…”

Echidna: “I suppose you would agree with that sentiment, considering you possess an Authority unlike any other, would you not?”

Echidna slowly stepped down from the podium and walked over to Subaru’s desk, tilting her head slightly. As Subaru watched her soft, white hair cascade over her slender shoulders, he fell silent.

Needless to say, Echidna was referring to Subaru’s ability, Return by Death. And, of course, Return by Death was far from a convenient Authority.

If he could go without using it, he would. It was more like a curse that he would prefer to avoid.

Subaru: “…So, what you’re saying is that despite all the attempts we’ve made so far, we haven’t uncovered the limits of Meili’s ability. That means, if we keep fighting the same way, it might not yield any results.”

Echidna: “Exactly. That understanding is spot on.”

Subaru: “Then, that means there’s nothing we can do?!”

Setting up the classroom and making a big deal out of it, only to end up with no solutions, left him deeply frustrated.

Leaning back in the familiar feel of his chair, Subaru looked up at the ceiling lined with fluorescent lights. Even though the environment had changed, the sense of confinement and suffocation remained the same—

Echidna: "Nothing we can do, you say? —I see you are underestimating me."

However, as Subaru lamented their lack of options, the white-haired Witch appeared upside down in his field of vision. Leaning over Subaru's face from the side, Echidna smiled at his surprised expression.

Echidna: "Four hundred years ago, rulers from all over the world came to me for counsel. You should understand that the Witch with whom you made a Contract is such a being."

Subaru: "…You mean, you have another plan?"

Echidna: "Of course I do. Otherwise, what would be the point of having you take my hand in the first place?"

Echidna answered with complete confidence, and Subaru's eyes widened at her words. He slowly straightened his body and pressed his forehead against hers as she leaned in to look at him.

At such a close distance that he could feel her breath, Subaru gazed into Echidna's black eyes,

Subaru: "Tell me. How can we deal with Meili?"

Echidna: "…Sometimes, you just erase the distance I have courageously closed in an instant. It does not feel bad, but I do feel like I am being played with, you know."

Echidna pulled her forehead away, gently touching her slightly reddened cheek. Meanwhile, Subaru stood up from his chair, facing her directly and urging her to continue.

Seeing Subaru's reaction, Echidna let out a sigh and prefaced her statement by saying, "About Meili's Divine Protection,"

Echidna: "Its limitations far exceed what we initially expected… so far, so good?"

Subaru: "Yeah. If that's all there is to it, then I'll be left feeling completely hopeless."

Echidna: "I hope that hearing the rest will lift your spirits. Now, I have outlined the types of Witchbeasts that Meili controls. Considering the ones stationed around the mansion and keeping an eye on Arlam village, it is safe to say that she has hundreds of Witchbeasts under her command."

Subaru: "…"

Hearing Echidna's rough estimate, Subaru felt as if his vision was going dark.

To be honest, even a single small Witchbeast would pose a considerable threat to Subaru. But here, he was dealing with hundreds of them, including the ferocious Guiltilaw among them.

How on earth could this situation possibly turn into good news—

Echidna: "As a result of your bold attempts, there has not been any disturbance in the Guiltilaw's control. In other words, it is safe to say that she can handle controlling

hundreds of Witchbeasts without any issue."

Subaru: "The more I hear, the worse I feel. Are we supposed to launch a missile at them or something?"

Echidna: "Back when I was alive, I might have been able to do something similar, but whether that would annihilate them is questionable. Also, have you noticed? I have been subtly dropping hints."

Subaru: "Hints?"

Hearing her words, Subaru widened his eyes in surprise, thinking that the crux of the matter was still to come.

He had assumed that the writing on the blackboard was simply a way to outline their dire situation. But, to hear that there were hints hidden within it for dealing with Meili—

Subaru: "—Oh, I see."

As his thoughts raced, he could almost hear the gears in his head clicking into place.

Seeing Subaru mutter to himself as if guided by that sound, Echidna gave a faint smile. It was the entrancingly beautiful, yet cruel smile of a Witch.

Subaru: "…"

As the Witch watched over him, Subaru tried to put together the possibility that had come to mind.

At this stage, it was just an idea. The method to make it a reality would come next.

But even so, if he could think of a possible way to break through this situation.

Echidna: "Your Authority allows you to pry open even the tiniest possibility."

Subaru: "Echidna…"

Echidna: "By repeating endless attempts and trading away pieces of your worn-out soul, you can turn any possibility into reality. Stacking up countless corpses of yourself, you reach for heights otherwise unattainable. That is something only you can do."

Gently, Echidna extended her hands and wrapped her arms around Subaru's neck. Subaru found that, for some reason, he could not reject the soft, slender arms of the Witch.

Even Subaru himself could not be sure whether he was being captivated by the Witch, or trembling with anticipation for the challenge that awaited him.

But—

Echidna: "—No matter how many times, hundreds, thousands, tens of thousands, or even hundreds of millions of times you try, I shall be with you."

The Witch whispered this reassurance into his ear, and in that moment, her embrace felt like a salvation to Subaru.

Subaru: "…"

Held by Echidna's slender arms, which radiated warmth, Subaru closed his eyes.

In the end, Subaru could not shake the feeling that he was being manipulated in the palm of the Witch's hand. But, that was fine. To avoid collapsing here, Subaru needed

some form of emotional support.

In that sense, the presence of Echidna, who called herself his accomplice, was quite convenient.

So long as he was aware of this relationship, he could convince himself that he was not completely bewitched by the Witch.

Subaru: "…We've found a way to deal with Meili. Now, all that's left is…"

Echidna: "The existence that is even more troublesome than the Witchbeasts. Shall we come up with a strategy for that together as well?"

Subaru: "—No, I already have an idea."

Echidna: "Oh? How impressive."

Admiration shone in Echidna's eyes as her alluring aura seemed to fade slightly. Subaru sighed and gently removed her arms from around his neck.

Freed from her embrace, Subaru stepped back, putting some distance between himself and the Witch. Echidna narrowed her eyes at this action, but did not press further; instead, she crossed her arms over her chest,

Echidna: "So, shall we give it another try?"

Subaru: "—. Yeah, let's do that. But, before we start, there's just one thing I want to ask."

Before restarting the battle to subdue Meili, Subaru fixed his gaze on Echidna's face. He then asked her a question, catching Echidna off guard.

Subaru: "You came up with a way to deal with Meili much earlier, didn't you?"

Echidna: "…It was difficult to bring up."

Subaru: "Go to hell."

Subaru contorted his face in a dramatic grimace, raising his middle finger and cursing at her.

After being made to die in vain so many times, he figured he had earned the right to do that much at the very least.

4

—Why had he not made that choice?

If you asked him, he would likely say he had simply been too afraid.

Their last encounter had seared itself into the chronicles of Natsuki Subaru's life as the worst event he had ever endured. It had left such a lasting scar that he had resolved to sever all ties from the very start.

But when circumstances made avoidance impossible, he knew he had no choice but to swallow his dread and press forward. After all, had he not overcome the most harrowing of Trials?

Therefore, even if their chemistry was the worst imaginable, he should be able to overcome it.

Subaru: "—Roswaal, I know about the Book of Wisdom. I know you've been orchestrating all sorts of sinister schemes. So let's talk with that in mind."

With the room cleared, Subaru spoke, and for a moment, Roswaal's eyes widened in astonishment.

His mismatched eyes—one blue, the other yellow—stretched wide in surprise. For a fleeting second, Subaru glimpsed something almost human behind them.

Despite his disgraceful nature that made him never hesitate to sacrifice others for the sake of his own aspirations.

They were in the Sanctuary. The house belonged to Ryuzu, yet Subaru could not help but always think of it as the place where Roswaal convalesced.

Wrapped in bandages from head to toe, lying on that bed—Roswaal had been in that state for so long that it had become his new, permanent image in Subaru's mind.

The thought of his usual jester-like outfit did not stir any fondness in him. Subaru had no intention of reflecting on it, nor did he care to.

Roswaal: "…Subaru-kun, did you hear about it from meee~?"

After a brief silence, Roswaal's lips formed a familiar question.

The last time Roswaal had asked this, Subaru had been speechless. And in return, Roswaal had slaughtered Ram and Garfiel before his very eyes. Fortunately, the two of them were not present this time.

Garfiel had been clued in on the removal of the barrier and the incoming threat of the Great Rabbit. By now, he was likely being persuaded by Shima. As for Ram, Otto had taken her away to distract her, as per Subaru's instructions.

Emilia was still resting. She needed solace after her heart had been shattered by the Trial, and it was fine for her to learn later that Subaru had completed the Trials.

Indeed, everything else could wait. Nothing mattered except this conversation with the warlock before him.

Roswaal: "Subaru-kun, won't you answer me? Who told you about my book…?"

Subaru: "Yeah, it was from you, Roswaal. You told me yourself. Does that answer satisfy you?"

Roswaal: "—!"

At that moment, Subaru could see delight swirling in Roswaal's eyes.

Subaru had seen Roswaal laugh and raise his voice many times before. But now, he intuitively sensed that none of those instances had revealed his true colors.

The pure joy he displayed now, with a hint of childlike innocence to it: this, Subaru realized, was Roswaal's true face.

Roswaal: "If… if what you say is true, then surely you know what comes next?"

Subaru: "…You'll summon snow upon the Sanctuary, and the Great Rabbit, drawn by the Mana, will swarm here. Every last soul in this place will be devoured, including you."

Roswaal: "Ahh, I see. So, my manipulation of the weather serves another purpose beyond just tarnishing Emilia-sama's impression of me. But, as for dealing with that

snow…”

Subaru: “I’ve already dealt with it. I’ve cleared the Tomb’s Trials. The barrier is gone. By now, Garfiel is persuading everyone to evacuate.”

Roswaal: “Fuh, haha! Hahahahaha!”

Roswaal’s voice trembled, his hand pressed to his forehead as he erupted into raucous laughter, his mouth stretching wide.

Subaru frowned at the display. Roswaal quickly shook his head and offered an apology before continuing.

Roswaal: “I expected this outcome… no, I hoped for it. Yet, now that it’s happened, I can’t help but find it… oh, so very strange.”

Subaru: “Strange? What’s strange about it?”

Roswaal: “Don’t play it off so casually, Subaru-kun! Are you truly unaware? You have broken the barrier that has bound this Sanctuary for four hundred years, and shattered Garfiel’s rigid, childish obsession, all in just half a day. How could anyone not laugh at such a thing!”

Hearing Roswaal’s words and boisterous laughter, Subaru became aware of the discrepancy between their perceptions.

To Roswaal, Garfiel, and everyone else in the Sanctuary, Subaru was just a newcomer who had arrived less than half a day ago.

Yet, despite this, Subaru had found the solution to many problems in half a day—or more precisely, within just a few hours, since his Return by Death had set the starting point at the tomb.

It was no wonder Roswaal would describe his accomplishments as strange.

Subaru: “So, what? Are you starting to feel scared of me?”

Roswaal: “Oh, I wish you wouldn’t say it so lightly. The truth is, yes, I’m terrified. I had anticipated the outcome of your Authority. But this… This far exceeds what I imagined…”

Subaru: “I’m not here for idle chatter. I’m running out of time, and of all people, you know exactly why that is.”

With both his words and gaze sharp, Subaru stared directly at Roswaal, who lay on the bed, his eyes narrowed.

Roswaal’s gaze was attempting to gauge Subaru’s intentions, but if he wanted to understand them, he was welcome to try. If Roswaal’s earlier claim of fear was sincere, Subaru would make sure it cut deeper.

After all—

Subaru: “You’re the one who sent the assassins to the mansion, Roswaal.”

Roswaal: “—. Would it do me any good to deny it or offer excuses now? Especially since, as you say, I’m the one who told you.”

Subaru: “Unfortunately, this isn’t something I heard directly from your mouth. I just pieced together scattered information, and you were the only possible culprit left. We haven’t spoken much recently, after all.”

Roswaal: “Hoh?”

With Roswaal not denying his pointed accusation, Subaru felt a mix of relief and bitterness well up inside him.

Holding onto those feelings, he dragged a chair next to the bed and sat down roughly, bringing his gaze level with Roswaal’s as he faced the unfeeling warlock head-on.

Roswaal: “May I ask what you meant when you said we haven’t spoken much recently?”

Subaru: “I’m not going to answer that. The point is, I’ve turned into the joker you were hoping for. So, the attack on the mansion doesn’t need to happen anymore, right? Call them off.”

Roswaal: “Oh my, how cooold~. If you’ve truly become the trump card I’ve long desired, why would you make such a request in the first place?”

Subaru: “…”

Roswaal: “With your all-powerful Authority, you can draw out the answers you seek. You shouldn’t need to rely on me for anything. But, if you can’t even do that…”

Roswaal squinted his yellow eye, scrutinizing Subaru as if measuring his worth.

The warlock’s gaze was assessing, as if he was trying to determine whether Natsuki Subaru was truly the disappointment he suspected.

If that suspicion became a certainty, Roswaal’s actions would surely turn ruthless.

Subaru: “Are you planning to burn everything to the ground again?”

Roswaal: “As I stand now, that’s nothing but empty slander, Subaru-kun. But I suppose it does shed some light on why you’ve been avoiding meee~.”

Touching his chin thoughtfully, Roswaal closed one eye and smirked.

The look in his eye, his knowing expression: everything about him grated on Subaru’s nerves. It was not just his schemes; it was his entire demeanor that made Subaru avoid engaging with him until the last possible moment.

Even though Subaru had used Return by Death to the fullest to accumulate experience and gain an advantage, Roswaal, driven by his own obsession and talent, was closing the gap Subaru thought he had widened in an instant.

Even with the head start Subaru had gained, Roswaal remained a formidable foe he could not afford to underestimate.

Roswaal: “You understand the danger I pose. And yet, you can’t bring yourself to get rid of me. That’s because you know just how essential I am to Emilia-sama’s rise to the throne.”

Subaru: “You really are an unbelievably troublesome bastard.”

Roswaal: “Securing my usefulness is a talent I’ve honed to perfection, after all. If someone gets in the way of your goal, you remove them, no matter who they are. It’s natural to prepare for such possibilities.”

With a smile that never wavered, Roswaal exposed Subaru’s weakness.

In truth, Roswaal's perception was accurate. His scheming and plotting made him a lethal poison to the safety of Emilia and everyone in their faction, yet he was also a necessary evil that they could not afford to lose.

Without him, Emilia's chances in the Royal Selection would all but crumble. That would be a catastrophic loss for Subaru, whose aim was to see her fulfill her ambitions and stay safe.

However—

Subaru: "But are you really irreplaceable, Roswaal? Do you seriously believe we can't move forward without you? Knowing what I'm capable of, can you seriously say that to me?"

Whether Subaru would directly acknowledge that to Roswaal, was another matter entirely.

Roswaal: "—Hmm."

Hearing Subaru's bluff, Roswaal let out a thoughtful hum as if contemplating his words.

Seeing him lost in thought like that, Subaru could not help but notice a resemblance to Echidna. He knew that Roswaal was obsessed with the Witch of Greed, but perhaps there was more to their connection than he realized.

In any case, Subaru decided this was the moment to press his advantage.

Subaru: "Sure, removing you would complicate things, but it wouldn't be a fatal blow. You understand that, don't you? The true devastation for me would be…"

Roswaal: "Losing Emilia-sama, correct? But if you're so focused on protecting the mansion, then perhaps you aren't quite as decisive as you like to think. Am I mistaaaken~?"

Subaru: "I won't deny it. But that doesn't mean I've fallen short of your expectations. —It just means I've decided to save everything, without any more hesitation."

Roswaal: "…"

Subaru slid his chair closer to Roswaal, closing the distance between them.

Bringing himself within arm's reach was Subaru's show of force.

He knew that if Roswaal so wished, he could easily kill him with a single chop of his hand. However, Subaru wanted to show him he had nothing to be afraid of.

Roswaal: "…If I were to refuse your request, would I become a target you need to eliminate?"

Subaru: "Yeah. I don't want it to come to that, but let's just say an "accident" might happen."

Naturally, it was nothing more than an empty threat.

Subaru would not be able to justify himself to Emilia and Ram, and he did not think he could recover from the aftermath either.

His words sounded like something a villain or mastermind would say, and Subaru almost wanted to laugh at himself for it. But, now was not the time for laughter. —He

had to carry this bluff through to the bitter end.

Roswaal: "…I can't order her to stop."

Subaru: "You…!"

Roswaal: "Wait, wait. I'm not finished. You understand who's attacking the mansion, right? Do you really believe she's the kind of person who can be easily persuaded?"

Subaru, who was about to grab Roswaal, stopped in his tracks at those words.

With his eyebrows lowered in frustration, Subaru could not deny that Roswaal had a point. —The assassin, Elsa, also known as the Bowel Hunter, was the type who would not back down, not even against someone like Reinhard.

Even if her employer withdrew the request, it was hard to imagine Elsa would simply give up on her prey.

Subaru: "Why would you hire someone so difficult to handle…?"

Roswaal: "I chose her precisely because she's difficult to handle. If I'm going to test you, Subaru-kun, then the ordeal needs to be worthy of you. Wouldn't you agree she's performing that role peeerfectly~?"

Subaru: "This isn't funny! Fuck, you really had to pick the most troublesome method possible…"

Roswaal's schemes had been exposed, and yet he continued to remain a formidable adversary. Clenching his teeth in frustration at the traps Roswaal had laid, Subaru desperately racked his brain for a solution.

He knew that calling off Elsa and her associate would be the best possible outcome, but if that was not an option, he had to make sure he was not left without any cards to play.

For instance—

Subaru: "So you can't stop Elsa. Fine. But you can tell her to change the plan, right?"

Roswaal: "—That should be possible. But what kind of change are you proposing?"

Subaru: "It doesn't need to be anything specific. So long as we can split them up…"

Hearing Subaru's answer, Roswaal furrowed his brows.

Even he could not fully grasp what Subaru was planning, which gave Subaru a small sense of satisfaction.

That said, Subaru's plan was not overly complicated. He had already devised a strategy to deal with Meili based on Echidna's advice. All he needed was to incorporate Roswaal's involvement into that plan.

Subaru reviewed the different combinations of options he had in his mind, and then lifted his head.

He could not definitively say which combination would be the best. However, that did not matter. So long as he had cards to play, and the opportunity to fight—

Subaru: “Then I’ll just keep playing the game as many times as it takes, until I get the best hand possible.”

5

—Just like with Garfiel, he could tell when he had hit the “jackpot”.

???: “…”

It was likely the result of the staggering number of times he had repeated Return by Death.

He was already aware that his ability to smell Death had sharpened. As that sense expanded, and the equation between failure and Death became clear, he naturally learned to instinctively recognize the signals that spelled failure.

Thinking about it that way, considering how few of his experiences had ended in success compared to Failures, it might have been more accurate to say that he simply was not picking up on the stench of defeat this time.

Subaru: “It doesn’t matter, either way.”

If the result was the same, he did not care whether the path to that result was predominantly positive or negative.

The separation and diversion had been successful, leading to the enemy’s isolation. All that was left was to carefully observe and ensure that the baited target did not make any unexpected moves.

???: “Huff, huff…”

Ahead of him, a girl was running down the mountain path, gasping for breath.

Repeatedly looking over her shoulder to check for pursuers was a poor choice. He understood that instinct, but fleeing without regard for appearances was the best way to ensure survival. Looking back in fear only slowed her down, and invited Death to catch up.

Though she should have understood, even without thinking about it, that being caught meant certain death.

Subaru: “Ah, right, it really is over for you when you die.”

He shook his head, correcting the discrepancy in his thinking.

—The rules of life and death were absolute, except for Natsuki Subaru.

If he lost sight of that fact, it would eventually trip him up. He needed to remind himself of it regularly.

Girl: “This is strange… so stra~nge…!”

Her voice trembling, the girl’s breathing grew more frantic with each gasp.

It was no wonder. An unfamiliar mountain path, lack of stamina, and a chest full of fear made her lungs quiver, making normal functioning impossible. Subaru had experienced this before.

Though it had been a while since he had felt that kind of fear.

Girl: “This, this is just like…”

The girl, thrown into an unimaginable situation, seemed to have seen something unbelievable. If it were Subaru from a short time ago, he might have described it this way. —It was just like a nightmare.

Girl: "Shadow Lion-chan…!"

Her cheeks stiffened as the girl let out a desperate cry from her frail throat.

The name she called out was that of a brave Witchbeast that had followed her orders to hold back her pursuers—but, her scream never reached the Witchbeast.

Instead of the reassuring roar she had hoped for, all she heard was a bone-chilling, agonized death wail.

The Guiltilaw, a Witchbeast that had caused Subaru countless hardships, let out a blood-curdling scream as if it were vomiting blood. The death cry was cut short, likely because it had lost the ability to make a sound.

Girl: "—Hk"

It was a mistake. Instead of using the Guiltilaw to stall her pursuers, she should have used it to aid her own escape.

Had she ridden on its massive back and fled through the hills and fields, she might have had a chance. But, that opportunity had slipped away with one poor decision. Naturally, he had been the one to close off that path.

The experience from a previous encounter, where she had escaped into the mountains with the fight ending in a draw, had proven useful this time.

Considering the threat she posed, allowing her to escape was not an option. No matter what, he had to end things with this dangerous assassin here and now.

Girl: "Elsa~…!"

Tears streamed down her cheeks as she stumbled over branches and roots. Her braids came undone as she awkwardly ran, calling out her companion's name in a desperate plea for help.

She called out the name of her closest ally, more dependable than the Guiltilaw, or any of the other countless Witchbeasts.

In truth, if that person had been by her side, Subaru would have stood no chance.

That was why, he had used a card he was reluctant to use in order to separate the girl from that woman.

Girl: "It's just, so wei~rd…"

Cornered and overwhelmed by her circumstances, the girl shook her head in denial.

She understood her situation: separated from her ally, and stripped of the advantage her Divine Protection once provided. Her mind was in complete disarray, struggling to comprehend the reality she found herself in.

—And, at the same time, he could tell she had no more cards to play.

Subaru: "—Finally ran out of cards, huh? You really were a pain."

Girl: "—Hk"

Holding her breath, the girl came to a halt and collapsed to the ground. Her forehead was damp with sweat, her bangs clinging to her skin as she—as Meili turned

to look at Subaru with an expression as if she had seen a ghost.

Seeing Subaru step out from between the trees ahead of her, her throat tightened in fear.

Meili: "—Ah, ah."

Her eyes widened in shock, confusion clear in her gaze.

Perhaps, because of their previous encounter during the Ulgarm incident, Meili might have thought that Natsuki Subaru would have been an easy target.

However, that perception had been completely overturned, as she had been utterly and decisively outmaneuvered.

It was no surprise. To her, the real threats were the Great Spirit and the combat-capable maid left back at the mansion. As for Subaru—

Subaru: ""He wasn't even on my radar.""

Meili: "…"

Subaru: "And that's fine. In fact, that's what allowed me to set up this situation. Sorry, but I'll have to capture you now."

Meili had no more pawns left to use. Even knowing this, Subaru could not afford to linger. While it was true that he did not want to give her any chance to fight back, there was another, more pressing reason.

Subaru could not risk getting killed himself in the process of executing his plan to suppress Meili.

As Subaru took a step closer, Meili's expression showed a hint of relief. Realizing that she would not be killed right here, her fear seemed to ease slightly.

That reaction sparked intense anger within Subaru.

Did she have any idea, just how much suffering she and her allies had put Subaru through?

So, just before capturing Meili, Subaru decided to deliver a parting shot.

Subaru: "—I can't take Elsa down without you."

Subaru intended to use Meili as leverage against Elsa. Oddly enough, it seemed Elsa had a soft spot for her kin. Even a villain like her, must have had a sliver of humanity.

For a moment, Meili's face twisted in shock, and she opened her mouth to bite back at Subaru. However, the Witchbeast Master, left with no Witchbeast at her side, was no match for Subaru.

Meili: "—Ah."

Subaru pressed a handkerchief soaked in a poisonous herb, one with a sedative-like effect, over her nose and mouth, causing Meili to lose consciousness.

The herb was said to be toxic in high doses, potentially leaving lasting effects, but Subaru chose to ignore that risk. After all, he was sparing her life, which was far more merciful than what she and her comrades had ever offered him.

Meili: "N-No~…"

Her strength drained from her limbs, and Meili collapsed, her body going limp as Subaru caught her.

As her eyelids fluttered shut, tears trickled down her cheeks, but they stirred nothing within Subaru's heart. No pity, no guilt. All that lingered was a quiet sense of relief, and—

Subaru: "—A feeling of satisfaction, that you got what you deserved."

???: "I see. That must feel quite satisfying, I'm sure."

A woman's voice emerged from the shadows, as though it had crawled out of the very darkness itself.

Subaru, still holding Meili, turned to face the woman who had materialized from the gloom—a figure that seemed as if a shadow had taken solid form.

He had made it just in time, teetering on the very brink of being too late, but—

Subaru: "Seems like I can finally settle my score with all of you. I'm really sick of seeing your face."

Woman: "I don't recall us meeting enough times for you to grow so tired of it…"

As she spoke, the woman tightened her grip on the *kukri* knife in her hand, a flicker of disgust glinting in her dark eyes as she glared at Subaru.

She was being uncharacteristically emotional. Subaru found this quite satisfying, and smiled.

A twisted, mocking sneer spread across his face, dripping with malice.

Woman: "You've grown far more unpleasant since the last time I saw you in the Royal Capital."

Watching Subaru's behavior, the woman—Elsa Granhiert muttered with visible displeasure.

6

Subaru: "—Don't move. I know how much you care about Meili."

Facing Elsa, the jet-black assassin, Subaru mercilessly carried out his hostage plan.

Holding the unconscious Meili from behind, he pressed a small knife against her neck. Even with Elsa's inhuman speed, Subaru would still be able to slit her throat first.

Elsa: "…"

As expected, Elsa narrowed her eyes and remained still, just as Subaru had demanded.

However, the dangerous killing intent radiating from her entire body did not diminish in the slightest.

Elsa: "So, what now?"

Subaru: "Huh?"

Elsa: "What are you going to do next? You've taken Meili hostage, and immobilized me. I'll give you credit for that… but what's your plan from here?"

Twirling the *kukri* knife in her hand in an exaggerated manner, Elsa asked Subaru what he intended to do next.

It was true that Subaru had succeeded in restricting Elsa's movements by using Meili as a hostage. But, even if he were to command Elsa to take her own life, she would not comply without a guarantee that Meili would be safe.

In fact, risking Meili's life and attacking Subaru was probably the better option for her.

He could not let that happen. That was why—

Subaru: "You have your own rules. You won't abandon Meili. But, I also know you won't gently back down, either. So, I have a compromise."

Elsa: "A compromise, you say? I suppose I can at least hear you out."

Subaru: "I'll guarantee Meili's safety. In return, you'll obey me. If you do that…"

Elsa: "—I refuse."

In an instant, a chillingly seductive voice whispered close to Subaru's ear.

At the same time, a black blade slashed through the air, aiming for Subaru's right arm, which held the knife to Meili's throat.

Her intent, was to sever his arm from the elbow, and to rescue Meili.

But—

Subaru: "If this were the first time, you would've won."

Looking down upon Elsa, who was poised from her strike, Subaru spoke with a cold, cruel tone.

Hearing his words, Elsa lifted her face, her expression twisting as she saw Subaru soaring above the treetops, ascending into the sky. It was clear what had enabled him to achieve this.

It was only natural. From Elsa's perspective, this was nothing short of betrayal.

Elsa: "…Wasn't I acting on your request?"

???: "Yes, that's riiight~. I'm truly sorry about that."

The one responding to Elsa's resentful remark was a jester-like warlock hovering in the air—Roswaal L. Mathers, who had grabbed Subaru from under his shoulders, and saved him from the assassin's lethal strike.

Roswaal, the client, was now opposing Elsa, who had accepted his request.

Subaru: "It's because you didn't back down that we ended up in this ridiculous situation."

Still holding Meili under his arm, Subaru was pulled up by Roswaal as he spoke thus to Elsa. At his words, Elsa furrowed her brow as if to say she was being unfairly accused.

Since the person in question was not aware of it, it was understandable that she would want to claim innocence. However, considering how many times they had gone through this, and how she always refused to listen, Subaru was no longer moved.

In any case—

Subaru: “We’ve finally secured Meili, and guided the evacuation of the mansion and Arlam Village… now, all that’s left is to finish you off.”

Elsa: “…”

Subaru: “I’ll be sure to use the same methods your sister did.”

Coldly stating this, Subaru’s gaze shifted to behind Elsa. Noticing the intent in his eyes, Elsa slowly turned to glance over her shoulder.

Her back was completely exposed, but he did not make a move. There was no need to do any such thing.

Even without him having to lift a finger, Elsa had already fallen into a hopeless trap.

Elsa: “—Despicable.”

As Elsa spat out those words, an eerie presence began to close in around her, gradually tightening the noose.

It was not just one, or two. Not ten, or a hundred. There were far more than that. After all, it would take a number far greater than that to overpower the Divine Protection of Meili, the Witchbeast Master.

—The sound of evil fangs clacking together resounded, a noise that Subaru had heard countless times.

This was the trap that had been set to eliminate both Elsa and Meili, who had attacked the mansion.

Subaru: “Even knowing it’s a trap, you still can’t abandon Meili. You, you’re a lot more human than I thought.”

Roswaal: “And, that’s why we will defeeeat~ you.”

It was unpleasant for Subaru to be lumped together with Roswaal, but in truth, without his cooperation, the plan to defeat Elsa and Meili would not have succeeded.

Roswaal’s presence was absolutely essential for luring the Great Rabbit, Subaru’s ultimate joker.

Subaru: “Only someone with vast amounts of Mana and such great mobility could act as bait.”

Roswaal: “You’re quite demanding in how you use people. But, I truly, truly admire your willingness to use whatever is avaaailable~ to you.”

Subaru: “Tch. Stop with the unnecessary—”

He was about to tell Roswaal to hold his tongue, but his words were abruptly cut off.

The reason was Elsa, who had rushed up the trunk of a tree and leapt toward him, landing right in front of Subaru.

Subaru: “…”

Elsa’s sense of timing was commendable, exploiting the brief moment of distraction caused by his conversation with Roswaal. This development caught Subaru off guard, as it was something he had not yet experienced.

Therefore, it was purely by chance that Subaru thrust Meili into the path of Elsa's blade.

Had Elsa not possessed such superhuman capabilities, she might have cut through Subaru's torso along with Meili. But, she was endowed with prodigious abilities.

Which, had allowed her to stop her blade the moment she realized it would kill Meili.

Subaru: "You really do care about your family. —It makes me want to puke."

Suspended in midair, Elsa was kicked away by Subaru, who spoke with disdain.

Elsa's body slowly tilted backward and fell, plummeting straight down without any means of protection. She descended into the midst of the swarm of Witchbeasts, eagerly clicking their fangs and licking their lips at their prey.

She fell, completely helpless to stop it—

Elsa: "—You're despicable."

Subaru: "I know."

Once more, Elsa spat out an insult uncharacteristic of herself.

It was uncertain whether Subaru's reply had reached Elsa's ears. There was no time to confirm, as she was immediately engulfed by the swarm of Great Rabbits, biting into her from every direction.

Great Rabbit: "—*Kichi kichi*."

The slayer swung her *kukri* knives and flailed with her limbs, tearing into the approaching Witchbeasts. However, it did not last long. As her fingers and ankles were bitten off, her body helplessly crumbled.

Being hard to kill only served to prolong her agony before the Great Rabbit. It was nothing more than a cruel spectacle.

Roswaal: "Well done."

As they watched down below as Elsa was devoured, Roswaal whispered to Subaru. Hearing the tone of his voice, Subaru twisted his lips in displeasure.

Roswaal: "Oh my, it's quite disheartening to see that expression. I assure you that my congratulations are sincere."

Subaru: "Shut up. It's not over yet."

Roswaal: "Indeed, we—no, your esteemed self and I still have the task of luring the Great Rabbit to the Great Waaaterfall~."

Subaru looked at Roswaal with suspicion as he shook his head and corrected himself in more formal language.

Noticing Subaru's intent to understand the reason behind the sudden formality, Roswaal smiled and continued,

Roswaal: "You are my savior. You have proven it splendidly. Therefore, I wish to offer the appropriate respect your esteemed self is due. That is all there is to it."

Subaru: "…Is that so."

The sincere admiration, the chewing sounds of the Witchbeasts below devouring his bitter enemy, and the faint heartbeat of the girl in his arms: all of it was irritating,

causing Subaru to grimace as he touched the Magic Crystal around his neck.

Only the black Magic Crystal knew the extent of Subaru's success, and the countless failures he had endured after each attempt.

His throat dry, Subaru clearly understood that this knowledge was his only solace.

Great Rabbit: "—*Kichi kichi*."

Chomp chomp, crunch crunch. The sound of the Great Rabbit's gnawing echoed loudly.

Right now, more than anything, all he wanted to hear was the aloof voice of the Witch.

7

Shrouded in white light, his vision suddenly cleared.

What greeted Subaru was a green meadow and a cool breeze, a white table and chairs set up on a small hill, a steaming cup of tea, and sweet-smelling tea cakes.

And, the one who had prepared all this was a Witch, whose appearance was defined by the stark contrast of black and white.

Echidna: "—Well done, Natsuki Subaru. At last, you have fulfilled your dearest wish."

As Subaru climbed the hill and stood before the table, Echidna watched him and gave a small round of applause.

Even her words of congratulations and welcome seemed laced with ulterior motives. It was almost a kind of talent. Subaru scratched his cheek, her demeanor threatening to ruin the afterglow of his sense of accomplishment.

Still, she was a familiar face. Her voice was one he had grown used to hearing.

Echidna: "—? What is the matter? You do not look very happy. Could it be, that my congratulations were too plain?"

Subaru: "No, that's not it…"

Echidna: "I even thought about making it more extravagant, decorating the place and inviting the other Witches for a grand celebration. I could have changed into a more festive dress instead of my usual outfit. You are a boy, after all, so I thought you might hope for a bit more of a welcoming spectacle…"

Subaru: "That's definitely not the case. This is fine as is."

Misinterpreting Subaru's brief silence, Echidna tried to make everything more complex, so Subaru motioned for her to stop with his hand.

Then, he sighed and sat down in the seat prepared for him across from Echidna. Gently, Subaru picked up his cup, letting the warm aroma waft into his nostrils.

However, it was a strange tea, one whose scent gave no indication of whether it was sweet or bitter.

Echidna: "Have you grown addicted to it yet?"

Subaru: “When it comes to Dona Tea, I always tell myself that if I don’t drink this, I won’t be able to Return by Death next time.”

Echidna: “What a way to phrase it. Well, considering it is your lifeline, I suppose you are not entirely wrong.”

Despite her words, Echidna gave a wry smile, seemingly enjoying herself.

Perhaps, she truly was pleased that Subaru had achieved his goal.

Subaru: “That would be surprising.”

Echidna: “What do you mean by that?”

Subaru: “I thought you’d be hoping I’d struggle more.”

Echidna: “Hey now, you are being quite blunt with your words. I am still the Witch who made a Contract with you, am I not? There is no way I would dislike my contractor’s wish coming true. That is something only those creatures from your memories, uh…”

Subaru: “—Demons.”

Echidna: “Yes, that was it. Only a demon would feel that way, do you not agree?”

Echidna pursed her lips, snapping her fingers and pointing at Subaru.

Subaru offered a brief apology. Whatever the truth might have been, it was true that Echidna had genuinely congratulated him on achieving his goal, even if it was just on the surface.

In that case, accepting it, even if it was just a pretense, was the proper thing to do.

Subaru: “I’ll gratefully accept your lip service.”

Echidna: “I thought we were talking about how it was *not* just lip service…”

Echidna sighed deeply as she spoke. Then, bringing her cup to her lips, she continued, “Oh well, no matter”,

Echidna: “It is hard to get you to accept things at face value… but, you have done it. That is a fact. Right?”

Subaru: “—True. Yeah, you’re right.”

Reminded by Echidna, Subaru blinked a few times before nodding.

Indeed, just as Echidna had said, Subaru had finally achieved his goal after countless failures. He had resolved the problems surrounding the Sanctuary, dealt with the Great Rabbit and Garfiel, passed the Trials, and saved everyone.

He had also solved the issues at the Roswaal mansion, defeated Elsa and Meili, thwarted Roswaal’s schemes, and saved all those he wanted to save.

He had found solutions to both situations, which had seemed to be at a dead end, and reached the right conclusion.

Without anyone dying, without letting anyone else die, they had all finally reached Tomorrow together.

And yet—

Subaru: “…I just don’t feel it.”

Echidna: “…”

Subaru: “Step by step, I went over everything, making sure there were no mistakes or oversights, scrutinizing every move. And, I finally made it here, but…”

Looking at his trembling hands, Subaru could not be sure if he had truly reached the opposite shore he had desired.

So long as Subaru kept pushing forward, he was able to keep his doubts at bay. He could focus entirely on how to overcome the problems right in front of him, without getting distracted by unnecessary thoughts.

However, now that all those efforts had borne fruit, what had surfaced instead were feelings of anxiety and uncertainty.

He did not feel the slightest bit of a sense of accomplishment; no feeling of satisfaction filled his heart.

Subaru: “If anything, I just feel more and more anxious.”

Echidna: “Anxious? Why?”

Subaru: “I don’t know! I really don’t get it. I don’t know the reason at all. It’s just that, if things go on like they have before, then the starting point for Return by Death will probably be updated.”

If Subaru’s previous experiences and Echidna’s speculation were correct, Subaru had to overcome a significant challenge for the starting point of Return by Death to update.

On the other hand, while he had infinite chances to try again, Subaru could never return to a problem he had already cleared. Even if he had left something behind.

He was worried that he might have left something else behind again, just like how he could not save Rem from her coma.

Thinking that way, he felt like he was unable to contain himself.

Subaru: “Did I really not screw anything up? Is it okay for me to celebrate solving that problem? Has something irreversible happened somewhere I can’t see?”

Echidna: “…Within the range of what I can observe, nothing of that sort has happened.”

Subaru: “But, your sight only covers what I can already see! What about beyond that?”

Grabbing the Magic Crystal from around his neck, Subaru slammed it down on the table.

The crystal, a symbol of his Contract with Echidna, allowed her to see what Subaru saw. However, it did not extend beyond his field of vision.

If someone far away, separated from him, were to get hurt, Subaru would not be able to know.

Subaru had thought he had finally overcome the wall standing in his way, but now this anxiety and fear were coming at him in a new form—

Echidna: “—Calm down, Natsuki Subaru.”

As Subaru trembled in fear of the unknown, a gentle voice softly reached his earlobe from close by.

Echidna, who was standing beside Subaru, gently pulled his head to her chest, cradling it softly. She stood to his right, embracing his head tenderly.

Subaru: "…"

Subaru held his breath, and stiffened in surprise at the Witch's unexpected action. As she gently stroked his head, Echidna asked softly if he had calmed down.

Echidna: "I have heard that the sound of a human heartbeat has a calming effect on others. What do you think?"

Subaru: "…I can't hear your heartbeat."

Echidna: "Hmm, maybe that is because I am dead. I never really paid attention to that before."

Echidna seemed surprised by this unforeseen issue, but not appearing particularly concerned about it,

Echidna: "But, *I* can hear your heartbeat very clearly. At first, it was fast and loud, then it jumped strongly for a moment, and now it is still a bit fast, but quieter."

Subaru: "Gh…"

Echidna: "It seems my soft skin had some effect after all."

Subaru: "G-Get away from me!"

Subaru ground his teeth as Echidna grinned triumphantly, and he shook off her arms that were holding him. As she backed away with a playful "Whoa there", Subaru glared at her and stood up from his chair.

Subaru: "Stop messing around! I'm serious here. I've been seriously thinking and worrying…"

Echidna: "You are worried about everyone around you. I know that. I was not messing around, either."

Subaru: "Then…!"

Echidna: "I just chose the quickest way to help. According to my calculations, we do not have much time to ease your anxiety. It seemed best to make a quick decision."

Subaru leaned on the table with one hand, eyeing Echidna suspiciously as she answered.

Did she just say, she would ease Subaru's anxiety? But, how could she do that?

Subaru: "Is there a way to do that…?"

Echidna: "I understand the worries and concerns that torment you. It is true that I cannot see beyond your field of perception, and I had not expected this kind of pitfall. I had not expected that your heart would not be at peace after solving your problem."

Subaru: "Answer. My. Question! Echidna! Can, you get rid of this anxiety?"

Stepping forward, Subaru closed the distance between them. He fixed his eyes on the white and black Witch, his voice rising with intensity.

Subaru wanted a straightforward answer without any pretense. How could he find relief? —No, Subaru did not care about himself. What he wanted, was to save everything else.

To save the people around Natsuki Subaru, those who made up his world.

For that, he needed to know—

Subaru: “What should I do?!”

Echidna: “—You should die.”

Her face was so close to his that he could feel her breath, her long eyelashes nearly brushing against him. Her otherworldly beauty stared straight into Subaru’s eyes as she quietly sentenced him to death.

Die. That one word that had passed Echidna’s lips made Subaru’s eyes widen, and his breath catch in his throat.

Instead of reacting with immediate outrage, Subaru tried to accept and understand that Echidna’s words were not a joke or jest.

And, after asking himself why over and over again, the answer became clear.

Subaru: “So, you’re saying I should try again, to find a better path?”

Echidna: “—Yes, that is exactly it. You have resolved the issues of the Sanctuary and the mansion, and you have most definitely saved everyone there. But, if there exists any regret or dissatisfaction with the outcome, you can still address those as well.”

Subaru: “…I, could do it better next time.”

Echidna: “I am certain you could. But, you have to do it before the one who granted you this Authority deems this situation acceptable. Before the checkpoint of Return by Death is updated.”

Spreading her arms wide, Echidna added this clarification to ensure that Subaru understood.

The new path Echidna had suggested was nothing short of a revelation to Subaru.

After all, Subaru had chosen the right path. He had made the correct choices. And yet, because the result did not sit well with him, he could throw it all away and start over, in search of something even better.

Doing such a thing would be the epitome of—

Echidna: “—Greed.”

Hearing Echidna voice the word that had come to his mind, Subaru stared intently at her.

He expected to see her laughing with a wicked expression in response. But, Subaru was mistaken. —Instead, Echidna’s eyebrows drooped, not in mischief, but in quiet sorrow.

Echidna: “It is a cruel path which I suggest. You realize that, do you not? If you continue like this, even when you choose the right path, it is likely you will never be satisfied.”

Subaru: “…And, you’d be happy to watch that, wouldn’t you? To see all the different outcomes unfold.”

Echidna: “Please do not take this lightly. I am genuinely worried about you. If you keep pushing yourself, one day, your heart may crack and shatter.”

Echidna’s serious gaze took Subaru by surprise, making him raise his eyebrows.

At the same time, Subaru started to wonder if he had been mistaken in his understanding of Echidna, of the Witch.

Echidna had witnessed these hundreds of journeys alongside Subaru. He had thought those experiences would not affect a Witch like her.

However, that was Subaru's way of looking at things; a view filled with pride.

Subaru: "—I won't break."

Echidna: "You cannot be sure of that. This has already gone far beyond what we had originally envisioned…"

Subaru: "But, you're here, aren't you?"

Echidna's eyes widened in surprise as Subaru cut her off mid-sentence.

Amused by her surprise, Subaru gave a wry smile, his shoulders relaxing.

Subaru understood Echidna's concerns. He also realized that he was about to throw himself into an unimaginable struggle, and that it was reasonable to doubt his sanity.

But, if he was going to risk breaking, if he was going to walk that razor-thin line between sanity and madness, Echidna would be his reassurance.

Subaru: "Your job is to keep me from losing it, isn't it? That was part of the Contract. Have you already forgotten the terms of your own sales pitch?"

Echidna: "I-I have not forgotten. Of course, I intend to do everything I can."

Subaru: "Then, do just that. —I'll make sure my heart doesn't break, either."

Subaru's argument was weak in terms of justification, but Echidna remained silent for a while after hearing it, her shoulders slumping. She pressed her hand to her forehead, and shaking her head,

Echidna: "Fine, fine. You are right. It was I who had suggested this in the first place. If you need to, you can take out your frustrations on my body however you like…"

Subaru: "Yeah, that helps. Keep a stock of neck bones ready."

Echidna: "There are other ways to comfort you besides breaking my neck, you know!"

Echidna's voice rose in response to Subaru's excessively unscrupulous comment.

Subaru could not help but laugh, as his exchange with Echidna had become so funny to him.

To his frustration, the fear and anxiety that had been swirling around in his chest until just moments ago had subsided enough for him to take another step forward towards a reckless plan.

He had found the correct answer. And yet, seeking an even better outcome, he would plunge back into the darkness once more.

Subaru: "If I'm going to die anyway, I might as well aim for the best outcome."

Echidna: "You know, that kind of resolve does not really suit someone about to throw themselves into death. You really are serious, right?"

Subaru: "Yeah, I'm serious. I've always been serious. It's too late for you to have any regrets now."

Subaru extended his fist to Echidna, signaling for her to join him on this journey to hell. At first, Echidna hesitated, confused for a moment.

Seeing Echidna's uncertainty, Subaru pushed his fist forward again, making his gesture clear.

Subaru: "This is a new beginning for Natsuki Subaru. You had better hold on tight and come along for the ride."

Echidna: "Very well. —Truly, you are a most remarkable contractor."

With a faint blush on her cheeks, her eyebrows lowering with a mix of sorrow and other emotions, Echidna brought her arm forward to meet Subaru's outstretched fist with her own.

And so, Natsuki Subaru decided to start anew, seeking new possibilities.

Echidna: "—Yes, you truly are an exceptional contractor."

Watching her contractor depart with renewed determination and vigor, the Witch narrowed her dark eyes.

He moved forward with a positive attitude, diving into the darkness to pursue a better future.

She had not truly guided him. She had simply mentioned it because the opportunity presented itself, hoping for that outcome. If things went well, it would be a gain; if not, there would be no loss.

That said, it was true that she did not want to see him get hurt.

She had no hesitation in using her knowledge, experience, and resources to prevent his heart from breaking.

Echidna: "Though, it would be nice if that obsession of his made him take a bit more interest in me."

Putting aside her previous sentiments, the Witch muttered to herself as she ran her hands over her figure.

She knew she was not lacking in charm. In fact, she considered herself to be in the better category, which made Subaru's indifference all the more perplexing.

Echidna: "Well, I suppose it is rather charming, too. Not everyone is like this single-minded boy, so devoted that he is willing to sacrifice himself time and time again. —For now, I shall respect that obsession of his."

After all, his determination was so powerful that he no longer viewed Death as Death, or even feared it.

If that burning desire was his driving force to move himself forward, she, the Witch of Greed, would never deny it.

—For now, she would simply wish in silence, hoping that her contractor's new challenge would be filled with the sweet unknown.

PROLOGUE III:

THE VERSATILE STEWARD

—That was, the way of a soul who had lived a fearsome number of years and vehemently matured.

It was beyond conjecture what way of life must one take, for the soul to get shaped this way.

He had walked this world for what felt like an eternity, yet standing here, he realized just how narrow his understanding still was.

He was taught so, however, threw all of his sentimentality for it behind.

There existed no time to halt, to contemplate. The crisis had already been set in motion.

???: "Even if I were to surrender, a way to survive surely would not be presented before me. Nonexistent."

He had unwittingly danced upon a carefully laid-out board, moving exactly as the enemy had desired.

By the time he took notice, no place to escape remained, and he had been entirely isolated from the environs. For him to be helplessly isolated here, he could find no such spectacle in even his oldest, most ancient of memories.

Overwhelming disadvantage, the choice to flee also came to his mind, however—,

???: "—To let that thing go, would be outrageous. Foolishness."

He could not choose that option, his sense of purpose, now akin to decaying wood, asserted.

As aforesaid, what made him pile up the impossible experience of doubting his own eyes, was the existence of the owner of a soul smothered in wounds and patches.

However, the object awakening his greatest sense of crisis and vigilance was not his personage.

Nestled beside that soul, the owner of the traces of a dusky, wicked, devious and malicious existence. —That which he was acquainted with, was the soul of a Witch who should have perished centuries ago.

???: "Not even considering that the Factor came unstuck and got inherited by the next vessel, to think she yet has not cleared herself of her flawed ideas…. no, perhaps that tenacity itself is precisely their true form. Dispiriting."

A hand on his eyebrows, he adjusted the slightly off monocle back to its position and sighed.

Their relationship could not be labeled as a friendship from antiquity, nothing more than acquaintanceship that existed long in the past. Anyhow, reuniting with an acquaintance after this much time had passed was not something particularly frequent.

And, reuniting with the Witch, was something not meant to be ever again.

???: "The world is already in a new era… to barge onto its stage. Inelegant."

The world, was something that ought to be the stage of those living in that era.

Himself and the rest, as well as those women and the rest, had an era where they had the world as their own stage. Their selves had lived through that era, and had expired. That was how it was supposed to be.

Yet, to cling to the stage even after death, was befitting of being labeled as the acme of boorishness.

???: "…"

Upon directing his concentration toward his environs, the presences of many people clamored within the magnificent structure.

A Witchbeast called a calamity, and a hazardous person who had tormented people for long had been respectively subjugated, this was a ceremony to thank, reward and commend those who achieved these meritorious feats.

The Royal Candidates too were attendees, thus it was a significantly auspicious event for the Kingdom.

Hence, neither could the opponent do anything untactful, he therefore intended to finish this in one move.

When it came to the chaos and hounding subsequently caused as well, he was supposed to have readied himself to counter, and yet.

???: "It is as though, my actions had been foreseen… no, to say as though, it is but a foolish act to repudiate what is transpiring. Senility."

To do away unanticipated actions of the opponents as sheer coincidence would be the deed of a simpleton.

Moreso when those except himself, were always contemplating the greatest way of action. He must simultaneously attempt to outstrip those greatest ways of action.

That was the readiness of the almighty steward, and the minimum courtesy for confronting the Witch.

???: "—Witch."

Yes, the opponent was a Witch. One who should have already perished and lost any means to interfere with the world.

Now that it had appeared forth once again, as one acquainted with those dark ages, his morality of rights and wrongs was—,

???: "—Hey hey, where are you, bro! Playing hide and seek? How cold!"

The next instant echoed the mighty voice of the youth intimidating and constraining him.

The young man, laughing mockingly, stood on the balcony overlooking the garden, searching for him. The unmistakable presence of evil radiating from his chest made it clear that he was carrying some kind of supernatural Anchor.

Though he wanted to openly highlight that and implore who was the one to blame, he would forfeit any chance of victory upon doing so. Who could ever, possibly meddle with him via words.

For the youth was indeed one of the lead actors of this evening.

For he was the one and only Knight of the silver-haired half-devil who made immense contributions to subjugate great evil threatening the world.

???: "Knight to the Witch of Frost, and a contractor to a Witch of Sin… Distasteful."

Faced with such outrageous titles, he could only laugh; this was precisely what it meant.

Though unfortunately, he refrained from expressing a smile thirsted of loathsomeness beyond criticality.

???: "I've given you company till now. Stop running around like a mouse, and come at me from the front!"

Though he seemed to not have ascertained this side's position, the youth's voice sonorously resounded into the air of the chilling night. The will to vexate sojourning his tone, was a substitute for rubbing the opponent in the wrong way.

It shan't make for an easy escape should he err the significance of the danger which the youth posed.

???: "So, it seems you are not a simple puppet of the Witch. Obstreperous adversary."

To begin with, the cause behind tonight's ceremony of conferring honors, the subjugation of the great catastrophes were battle accomplishments the youth had attained regardless of the Witch.

Of course, he was no ordinary individual. —A contractor of the Witch who made full use of her.

???: "Thinking back to it, even in that era, I never experienced meeting an opponent this malevolent. Uncharted."

Once again, he piled up identical contemplation as before.

Having lived for long, his disposition came to be that he had seen the entirety of the world, but that did not hold true. Neither for people, nor for the world, nor for things other than those, nor for anything or everything.

???: "The future holds bright for the lively, pure world. Blessing."

Despite the predicament of being cornered, to hold his head high upon thinking of the future was the special privilege of the old.

Concealing his brazen smile with a hand, he took action conforming with his own mission.

???: “—I cannot allow the world to be brought to ruin by the insatiable, unbounded “Greed”. Promise.”

There once lived those, who fought to preserve this world.

Likable people, and correspondingly discordant people, however, the direction they all looked in, and what they all wished for was supposed to be the same.

—As the final one to remember those wishes, he could not possibly give up.

CHAPTER III:

ACCUMULATING LIFE IN ANOTHER WORLD FROM ZERO WITH A WITCH

1

It happened without warning: a sudden, jarring shock that tore through the air.

???: "—Hah."

With a single exhale, Subaru's body crumpled forward, collapsing as though the strength had been drained from him entirely.

No one was there to catch his fall, therefore he tumbled from the platform, rolling helplessly to the ground below.

???: "Subaru—?!"

A scream echoed, sharp and panicked, and in an instant, chaos rippled through the crowd in the wake of this abrupt incident.

He could feel the presence of people rushing toward him and from the platform above, astonished gazes bore down upon him. Subaru's body twitched uncontrollably, limbs spasming like a dying insect.

—Nay, not like an insect on the verge of death. Like one already doomed.

He knew the feeling all too well. The familiar touch of Death crept up behind him, wearing a thin smile, already resting its hand on his shoulder.

???: "Subaru! S-Someone! Please, somebody! Help!"

???: "Ferris, hurry! Get over here!!"

Hands grabbed his shoulders, pulling him upright. The moment he was turned over, blood exploded from his mouth, a violent torrent.

It sounded akin to one's submerged head breaking the surface of a bath. It was blood. A whole bucket's worth. Far too much for a human body to hold. Something inside him had ruptured violently and irreparably.

Someone nearby gasped, and he could see the large, heavy tears brimming in her eyes.

The sight pierced his heart, and it ached. He regretted it deeply, knowing that he had made her cry.

Because of Natsuki Subaru's pitiful, miserable death, he had once again forced that sorrowful expression onto her face.

Echidna: "*If you are going to die anyway, would you rather do it where no one can see you?*"

The room erupted into a cacophony of shouts and cries; but, amid the uproar, a calm, cutting, almost penetrating voice reached his ears with stark clarity.

It was like it had come from a world entirely separate from this one. —No, not "as though." It was from another world. That was the truth.

The cold black stone at his chest hummed with that voice as Subaru felt the warm waves of healing magic flow through him. Yet, deep down, he knew it was all in vain.

There was no mistaking it; the sensation of Death had a singular, unmistakable presence.

He understood now, without question. He was dying. And once he accepted that, only one thought remained—

Subaru: "W-Who…"

—Who was it? Who had killed Natsuki Subaru?

2

???: "*Myon myon myon myon myon…*"

???: "…"

A slow, carefree voice drifted across the breeze, carrying over the green expanse of the grasslands.

This familiar, almost prank-like ritual repeated itself with such diligence that it seemed a necessary step for the inheritance of Memories.

Then again, it could very well be her way of messing with Subaru, dragging this on and on.

Subaru: "If that's the case, your pettiness has reached new heights."

???: "Myon… oh, do you still doubt me? No matter how much time has passed in the real world, we have been together for a while now, have we not? Is it not about time you started trusting me completely?"

Subaru: "Trust you completely…? What, did I bash my head in or something?"

Pointing to his head, Subaru grimaced dramatically. Hearing his response, the Witch— Echidna puffed her cheeks in exaggerated displeasure.

It was a pouting face Subaru had grown accustomed to. As annoying as it was to admit, Echidna was not wrong. She had become a constant presence in Subaru's life in terms of time spent together.

At least enough to say that, in this other world, hers was the face he had seen more than anyone else's.

Subaru: "For someone I've been with for so long, you still make me feel like I can't put my guard down around you. You're quite one hell of a woman."

Echidna: “Oh? Hehe, it does not feel so bad being treated like a girl, you know.”

Subaru: “If that’s what you call being treated like a girl, you’ve got a long way to go.”

Watching Echidna deflate as the air left her puffed-up cheeks, Subaru sighed deeply.

Then, leaning forward weakly, he slumped onto the table before Echidna. Collapsing carelessly over the objects on the table, naturally, he knocked over the cups and tea cakes.

As she watched them tumble under the table, Echidna, closing one eye,

Echidna: “You are so rude. Even if I can conjure these things whenever I wish, it does not feel good to have my hospitality so thoroughly slighted.”

Subaru: “Think of it as an art form that expresses my utterly crushed spirit.”

Echidna: “Calling a simple tantrum art? Picasso or Van Gogh would be furious with you, you know?”

Echidna teased him, referencing great artists from Subaru’s knowledge. Subaru, not bothering to respond, tilted his head to the side.

Echidna: “This is serious. That being said, I do feel sorry for you. —Still, it has only been a month.”

Subaru: “…”

Echidna: “One month since you dealt with the Sanctuary and the mansion, and made a Contract with me… and now, you are wrapped up in yet another Death. It really is a kind of talent, would you not say?”

Subaru: “Talent? What kind of talent is that? The talent to die? I’ll murder your ass!”

Echidna: “Oh my, so scary.”

Subaru cradled his head in his hands while the Witch, lying sideways in his view, gave a mocking shrug of fear.

Sighing deeply at her usual attitude, Subaru slowly pushed himself upright.

Then—

Echidna: “It seems you are done venting. So—”

Subaru: “A snap of your fingers to replenish the Dona tea and cakes. Ahh, I know. I know.”

Looking exasperated, Subaru grabbed the newly-appeared cup. Gulping it down in one go, he then stuffed some cakes into his mouth as if to clear the taste.

Both the tea and cakes were Echidna’s creations. There was probably no real difference between them, but liquid and solid forms somehow felt distinct in his mind. It was all psychological.

He had to keep this mindset, or the weight of the situation would crush him.

Echidna: “Nevertheless, being killed in front of a crowd like that; it was quite a bold move.”

Subaru: "…Yeah, I was completely caught off guard. But, isn't it natural to let your guard down sometimes?"

Responding to Echidna as she broached the main topic, Subaru reflected on what had happened to him.

—The ceremony was meant to commend those who had defeated two of the great threats to the world: the White Whale, and the Sin Archbishop of Sloth.

That prestigious event had been the stage for Subaru's newest Death.

The Crusch Camp, the Anastasia Camp, and naturally, the Emilia Camp, including Subaru, were all gathered. Nobles and high-ranking officials of the Kingdom were present as well. It was a high-class, formal affair.

How could he have possibly expected to be killed in such a setting with all eyes filed upon him?

Echidna: "In fact, it was your grand debut as the Knight of your beloved. I was hoping it would go smoothly, considering how much time I spent helping you with etiquette…"

Subaru: "Yet you can't hide that smirk on your face. You're enjoying this, aren't you?"

Echidna: "—. Do not get the wrong idea. I am not wishing for your death. I simply cannot suppress my overflowing curiosity about the unknown."

Subaru: "They say only fools learn through death, but I guess not even death has cured your nosiness."

Echidna offered a feeble excuse, but Subaru deliberately chose words he knew would annoy and irritate her.

For someone who openly claimed to be driven by curiosity and a thirst for knowledge, she sure hated being called a busybody. Then again, Subaru would probably hate being called a veteran of death, so perhaps it was mutual.

In any case—

Echidna: "—This is the start of another Death loop."

And so, Echidna clearly confronted him with words about a reality that was hard to deny.

Subaru could not look away as he violently scratched his head,

Subaru: "I don't like that term, "Death loop". It sounds too much like something from a game or a manga and makes it less serious."

Echidna: "I think it is convenient and easy to understand… but, I will stop if you really hate it."

Nodding at Subaru's complaint, Echidna added a casual "Well then" and continued,

Echidna: "Now, about this Death that struck you in such a situation… this time, the cause was almost instantaneous."

Subaru: "…It was when I was about to say something on the platform."

The ceremony proceeded solemnly, and while Wilhelm and Julius received first and second honors for their achievements in slaying the White Whale and the Sin

Archbishop of Sloth, respectively, Subaru was awarded the third honor.

This was recognition of his achievements, second only to the two who directly had taken down the main enemies; it was even more so than that of Crusch, who had led the forces, or of Anastasia, who had provided military cooperation.

Subaru felt quite embarrassed by being awarded the third honor ahead of the Royal Candidates, but Crusch and Anastasia acknowledged Subaru's efforts and achievements, and Wilhelm and the others respected that judgment.

Having taken the position of Emilia's Knight, Subaru himself wanted at least some form of distinction. So, he humbly accepted their goodwill and gratefully received the third honor.

As a result, Subaru, who had been called up to the stage, received words of praise for his achievements from a representative of the Council of Wise Men, who spoke on behalf of the absent King.

And then—

Echidna: "Just as you turned to face them, you collapsed and departed, never to return."

Subaru: "Watch how you say that…! Weren't you able to tell what happened, either?"

Grimacing at her matter-of-fact tone, Subaru flicked the Magic Crystal hanging from his neck.

As their Contract deepened, Echidna gained the ability to share real-time information with Subaru outside of the tea party. He found it annoying when she constantly talked to him, but her perspective was invaluable in situations like this.

Subaru asked with that hope in mind, and Echidna shrugged,

Echidna: "Sorry that I cannot meet your expectations, but I did not pick up on anything."

Subaru: "You useless, blabbermouth Witch…"

Echidna: "Yes, I cannot deny that one this time. Honestly, the most likely cause seems like sudden death… Although, I just had a thought: what if it was a chronic condition, like a heart attack? What would we do then?"

Subaru: "…Guess I'd just have to hope that my starting point for Return by Death takes me back far enough to improve my lifestyle."

There was not much else Subaru could say to her blunt concern.

As Echidna had suggested, Return by Death probably could not do much against natural causes of death such as illness. After all, even the strongest warrior race in the universe could not defeat something like heart disease.

Subaru: "So basically, I need to eat my veggies if I don't want to drop dead."

Echidna: "At least you are reflecting on your daily habits. Now, let us talk about the parts of this that are worse."

Clapping her hands in front of her chest, Echidna steered the conversation to the real issue.

Switching topics with a clap was a routine part of his interactions with Echidna. Subaru followed her lead, replaying the events in his mind to sort through his thoughts.

There was no denying the lack of information, but some facts could still be inferred from the current clues.

For example, the cause of Subaru's Death.

Subaru: "…Was it magic, or maybe poison?"

Echidna: "It could be. I did not sense any magic being used, so that is unlikely. But if it was poison, there is no way I could have known."

Subaru: "You weren't on full alert for magic either, were you?"

Echidna: "Well… no, I was not. I suppose if a pro assassin had been hired, it is not impossible that they could have slipped past my watch."

Subaru: "An assassin…"

Hearing that word, Subaru's face twisted into a scowl.

After all, it had not even been a month in real time since he had managed to fend off an attack from a pair of assassins. Fully aware of his situation, Echidna quickly realized the reason behind Subaru's distaste.

Echidna: "I understand how you feel. But right now, you are a person of public interest. You were one of the stars of this ceremony… it would not be surprising if someone sent an assassin after you."

Subaru: "That's…"

Echidna: "Of course, it is also possible that the Witch Cult is behind it. In this case, you might find it more reassuring if your enemies are cultists."

Subaru: "It's kind of messed up that I'd feel better thinking it's an act of terror by the Witch Cult than suspecting Crusch-san or Anastasia-san of trying to have me killed."

Subaru furrowed his brow as Echidna offered a faint smile with her words.

To say that it would be preferable to face off against the Witch Cult rather than accuse political allies was something anyone would think to be insane. But perhaps the only one who could understand that feeling was Echidna.

Echidna: "But, surely there is reason for suspicion? The two you mentioned are also rival candidates in the Royal Selection. They have more than enough motive to send an assassin after you."

Subaru: "Maybe. But after being targeted by someone I thought was like family, I'm not about to start buying into every logical argument."

Echidna: "Hmm, a sound argument, but still… Roswaal truly complicates things."

Echidna groaned, knowing that Roswaal's involvement made for a strong counterpoint, but there was no point in prolonging unfounded suspicions any longer.

At the absurd idea that Crusch or Anastasia would target Subaru,

Subaru: "Clearing those doubts quickly is the smart move. Then we can have a more constructive discussion."

Echidna: "Oh, feeling confident, are we? Do you have a brilliant plan in mind?"

Subaru: "You're not gonna like it if I tell you it's the boring way."

Without much fanfare, Echidna tilted her head as Subaru calmly laid out his thoughts.

She clearly preferred seeing Subaru running in circles, but he was not naive enough to cater to her whims or to sell his life cheaply.

Even if he had infinite attempts, wasting them accreting meaningless Deaths would be absurd.

Subaru: "Simply put, I should surprise Crusch-san and Anastasia-san with a direct question. If I suddenly ask them, "Are you the one who's trying to kill me?", they'd be quite rattled, right?"

Echidna: "Hohoh, I see."

Subaru: "And anyway, if I'm going to suspect anyone, it'd only be Anastasia-san. I don't think Crusch-san can scheme like that in her current state."

Crusch, who was the victim of having her Memories stolen, was still reeling. Though she was present at the ceremony, Subaru doubted she was fully aware of her position or surroundings. If she had already begun maneuvering behind the scenes to eliminate political rivals, then her aptitude for politics would be truly terrifying.

As for Anastasia, it seemed unlikely for her to be the mastermind.

Subaru: "I don't think she'd intentionally tarnish her camp's reputation by pulling something like this during the ceremony. And killing me in front of everyone would only risk undermining her accomplishments."

Echidna: "Hmm, a logical answer. I have nothing to add."

Subaru: "Just how many times do you think I've died so far? I've learned to think things through a bit."

In response to Echidna's words, Subaru tapped his head with his finger.

It was not something to boast about, just a simple fact.

Return by Death did not accumulate physical experiences, but the mental scars stacked up with every attempt.

No matter how many times he experienced Death, the helplessness, the overwhelming loss, never dulled. And the pain, he would never get used to that; but—

Subaru: "—The fear of it has definitely faded. That, too."

Echidna: "Oh, you are making me blush, saying it is all thanks to me."

Subaru: "I didn't say that."

Subaru clicked his tongue, annoyed by Echidna's coy smile.

In truth, he had not said it. He had not, but he could not deny it internally.

Without Echidna, Subaru doubted he would have maintained his sanity through the many times he had already endured Return by Death.

Of course, he had no intention of voicing any gratitude for that.

Subaru: "Anyway, that's why I don't suspect the two camps."

Echidna: "Then, what about the two camps who were not present at the ceremony? The candidates not involved in this commendation might have had reasons to make a move here, correct?"

Subaru: "…I don't know about Priscilla, but Felt and Reinhard wouldn't do it."

Pressured by Echidna's persistent questioning, Subaru replied in a lower tone.

He did not have a particularly deep connection with Felt or Reinhard. It was by mere chance that they had helped him escape his first Death on the day he was summoned to this other world.

But, in that short time, he had come to trust them. Felt was not the type to tolerate underhanded tactics, and Reinhard was the picture of honesty and integrity.

Subaru: "Even if my last interaction with them wasn't the greatest."

Echidna: "Ah yes, there is that Memory of you driving them away with some harsh words. Maybe they were hurt more than you realize. Is it not possible they would want you dead?"

Subaru: "Come on, I'm not getting assassins sent after me over a temper tantrum."

Besides, if Reinhard wanted to kill Subaru, he would not need to send an assassin. His own skills would allow him to do the job himself in an instant.

Even with the success Subaru had achieved, if Reinhard decided to kill him out of anger, Subaru doubted anyone in the Kingdom would bother to come to his own defense.

Echidna: "At least you have me on your side. That is reassuring, is it not?"

Subaru: "And what could an evil spirit who haunts my head possibly do for me in a court of law?"

Echidna: "Calling me an evil spirit is a bit much!"

In any case, the scenario where Reinhard acted out of anger at Subaru over their last encounter could be dismissed.

In that case, that left Priscilla as the only remaining suspect among the Royal Candidates, but she also seemed unlikely.

Subaru: "This is just a baseless hunch, but Priscilla doesn't seem like someone who'd go through the trouble of hiring an assassin… if she wanted me dead, she'd come right at me, face-to-face."

Echidna: "I wonder about that. Based on what I have seen from your Memories, I think she is more of a pragmatist than you give her credit for. If necessary, she might resort to dirty tactics, as any ruler might."

Subaru: "I don't think she's a ruler yet…"

However, Subaru agreed that Priscilla had a regal demeanor, even as a candidate. And he could not completely dismiss the idea that she would use underhanded methods if she deemed them necessary.

Thus, it might be prudent to consider Priscilla or the Witch Cult as immediate potential enemies.

Echidna: "Of course, there is always the possibility that someone trying to gain favor with one of the Royal Candidates got ahead of themselves and decided to take you out, but that would make finding the mastermind much more difficult."

Subaru: "Stop it! I had thought of that too, but I didn't dwell on it because it's too damn depressing!"

Widening the pool of suspects like that would even put Crusch and Anastasia in a dubious light. This was why political strife and internal conflicts were the bane of nations.

Subaru: "Anyway."

And, Subaru slowly rose to his feet, feeling sufficiently miserable after all these grim thoughts.

Still seated, Echidna widened her eyes and asked, "Leaving already?"

Echidna: "You could stay a bit longer and rest."

Subaru: "Why bother keeping me here? You can watch the outside world through the Magic Crystal, so you don't have any reason to be bored."

Echidna: "It seems you genuinely believe me to be heartless, but I truly do care about you, you know? I am the one who wanted this Contract, after all. Is it not only natural that I would worry when you are about to throw yourself into another fight so soon?"

Subaru: "You always catch me off guard when you say things like that."

Echidna puffed her cheeks in mild frustration at Subaru's flippant tone, but he merely shrugged.

A door appeared down the hill, one that opened to the outside world, signaling the moment to leave this dreamlike castle and return to reality. Reality— that is, the very moment Subaru, who had just lost his life, would return to.

Echidna: "So, what is your next move?"

As she asked this to his retreating back, Subaru waved his hand without looking back.

There was no clear, immediate solution to figuring out who had killed him or how it had happened.

So—

Subaru: "For now, I'll just get killed a few more times, and see if I can piece things together."

He had no intention of wasting his life carelessly, and he certainly did not want to contribute to the accretion of meaningless Deaths.

Yet, if necessary, he would sell his life and accrete Deaths without hesitation.

For Natsuki Subaru's soul had already been sold to the Witch of Greed.

3

Subaru: "—Is it you, Crusch-san? Are you the one who's trying to kill me?"

Crusch: "Excuse me, what are you talking about, Natsuki Subaru-sama? I have been told you are my benefactor. Even with my lost memories, I would never think of repaying kindness with treachery."

Subaru: "—Is it you, Anastasia-san? Are you the one who's trying to kill me?"

Anastasia: “Huh? What’s goin’ on that you’d say somethin’ like that outta nowhere? Are ya feelin’ like you’re bein’ threatened or somethin’? If so, ya can consult with me.”

Subaru: “—Is it you again, Roswaal? Are you the one who’s trying to kill me?”

Roswaal: “Myyy~, my, that is quite the harsh statement, Subaru-sama. There is no longer any reason for me to test you like before. You know that quite well, don’t you?”

Subaru: “*What do you think?*”

Having gathered responses from those he wanted to clear suspicions from, and those he needed to clear suspicions from as well, Subaru stood at the corner of the commendation ceremony and silently directed his question toward the Magic Crystal hanging from his neck.

In response to Subaru’s question, the inhuman Magic Crystal emitted a dull glow,

Echidna: “Roughly the same impression just as you would expect. Some were startled, some laughed it off as a joke, others smirked knowingly… well, there did not seem to be anything too revealing.”

Subaru: “True.”

Subaru gently rubbed his chin, mentally conversing with the voice that resonated inside his head.

He was communicating with Echidna, who dwelled within the Magic Crystal. They communicated without words, their conversations flowing telepathically if put simply, a method that had become invaluable for resolving issues.

That said, during more peaceful times, Subaru often found himself at the mercy of her endless small talk, which frequently left him frustrated.

Subaru: “Still, this is where you come in handy… For now, it seems none of them are the mastermind.”

Echidna: “That, or they are just so skilled at hiding their true feelings that even a little prodding would not make them flinch.”

Subaru: “If I start doubting them like that, it will never end.”

If Subaru assumed his opponent was always one or two steps ahead, trying to uncover their plot would seem utterly foolish. It was a pathetic conversation between him and the Witch, both racking their brains and getting nowhere.

After all, he had already died three times, all for the sake of extracting fresh reactions from each suspect. At the very least, he wanted to cross them off the list for good.

—The time was the opening of the commendation ceremony, and Subaru’s Return by Death had set its starting point here.

At worst, there had been a possibility that he would have been sent back several days before the ceremony, so finding the save point much closer than expected brought a sense of relief.

Echidna: “Having a few more days would have made it easier to prepare, would it not?”

Subaru: "If I had prepared too much, they might have called off the attack altogether. If that had happened, the culprit would have slipped away, and that would be much more troublesome"

Echidna: "I see. Easier to smoke them out if you know where they will be and whom they are targeting."

Subaru: "The last thing I want is for them to escape, and for the target to shift from me to Emilia and the others."

For that reason, Subaru would ensure that whoever was after him would be dealt with here and now.

Thanks to Echidna's assistance, he had successfully utilized Return by Death, but the conditions for updating Return by Death's checkpoint remained unknown as ever. The hypothesis was that it was only after overcoming the difficulties that befell Subaru, but that too was not certain.

More importantly, if someone other than Subaru were to get hurt, there was a strong possibility that his Authority, Return by Death, would not allow him to save them, just as it had failed to save the now comatose Rem.

Subaru: "So, I'll make sure to finish off the enemy who's been killing me right when they do it."

Echidna: "A strange way of putting it, but I understand. —So, shall we proceed according to plan?"

Subaru: "Yeah. It's all on you. Show me I can trust you."

Echidna: "Huh, so you still do not trust me…"

Unknowingly wounded by a matter entirely separate from the main issue, Echidna reacted subtly. Ignoring her response, Subaru withdrew his consciousness from the Magic Crystal and shifted his attention back to the lively hall.

He heard a voice akin to a silver bell, summoning him toward the line of people awaiting their commendations. Subaru smiled back at the girl beside him, who gently spoke to him. Her nervousness increased as they awaited the announcement of who would be honored for their contributions.

Of course, Subaru already knew the details of the ceremony. He also knew its conclusion.

As a result, there was no tension and no sense of anticipation for him. If there was any emotion stirring within him, it would be the simple wish to avoid seeing the girl beside him, hopeful for Subaru's merits to be recognized, ending up with a sad expression on her face.

However—

Echidna: "If circumstances were to change, it could shake the foundation of our analysis, so you mustn't overlook that."

The warning was one Subaru already knew well, and he wrinkled his nose in irritation. That very nose was then playfully poked by the girl beside him as she told him to stop.

???: “—Now, we shall begin the commendation ceremony for the defeat of the White Whale and the Witch Cult’s Sin Archbishop!”

The one who swiftly controlled the restless atmosphere of the venue was a man of imposing stature, clad in armor: the captain of the Royal Guard, who had also facilitated the announcement of the Royal Selection.

Wilhelm’s name was called first, commending him for his significant contribution in defeating the White Whale.

It was clear, however, that he was not in a state to fully appreciate the praise. His mind was weighed down by the condition of his lord, Crusch, and the old wound on his shoulder that would not heal. Subaru, too, could not help but wish to alleviate the cause of Wilhelm’s suffering.

Next, Julius was summoned to receive the second-highest honor for his role in defeating the Sin Archbishop of Sloth. The ceremony continued, and soon, in a deep and authoritative voice, Subaru’s name was called to the stage to receive the third commendation.

With a gentle push from the girl beside him, who was overwhelmed with emotion, Subaru ascended the stage. There, his achievements were acknowledged by one of the Council of Wise Men’s elders, a man whose beard and eyebrows were far too long, and after he offered him words of praise—

Subaru: “—Blergh!”

Without warning, just like before, Subaru coughed up blood and collapsed, dead.

4

Echidna: “I have finally confirmed something about the cause of your death. —It was not any kind of magic.”

Even though Subaru could not see her face, her smug tone through the Magic Crystal made it easy to imagine her proud look.

Subaru, however, was not entirely convinced that this was information worth boasting about. Considering the dozens of times he had died just to figure out the cause of his Death, it felt like a rather underwhelming revelation.

Subaru: “If it wasn’t magic, then what was it? Poison? A curse? I’ve already matched the faces and names of those who might have touched me during the ceremony.”

Echidna: “If we are dealing with a Curse Arts User, that would most certainly be a solid strategy. Usually, there is no saving you the moment they touch you, but your case is an exception. However…”

Subaru: “However?”

Echidna: “This time, that was a wasted effort. It was not Curse Arts, nor was it poison.”

Her tone was so full of confidence that Subaru found himself listening intently.

With magic, Curse Arts, and poison off the table, Subaru felt utterly stumped. But, perhaps there was a technique in this world that he still had no knowledge of.

Echidna: "There is an unusual technique called the Flow Method. Even those without talent can use it, but it requires hellish training."

Subaru: "I see. Sounds like something you wouldn't casually ask to learn. But, never mind that."

In fact, there did seem to be techniques he was unfamiliar with, but they were unlikely to be something he could learn on the spot, nor would they suit him anyway.

Instead, Subaru redirected the conversation back to the main issue, and after a brief pause, Echidna added—

Echidna: "Judging by the number of attempts you've accreted, it is safe to say an Authority is what took you out."

Subaru: "An Authority… so, that means it was the Witch Cult, then?"

Echidna: "Exactly. Whoever did this to you must be someone on the level of a Sin Archbishop. Authorities stem from Witch Factors… and there is a pattern of sharing them with their Apostles."

Subaru: "…"

Echidna's voice carried an air of quiet intensity as she explained.

To someone who claimed to be the world's foremost expert on magic, the Authorities wielded by the Sin Archbishops must have been an irresistible object of fascination— or, simply put, the perfect additions to her collection, driven by her insatiable Greed.

Ignoring her peculiar inclinations, Subaru scanned the venue, observing the crowd of attendees.

Thinking that one of the Witch Cult's Sin Archbishops could be hidden among them —

Subaru: "…Could it be Gluttony?"

Swallowing hard, Subaru felt a mixture of faint unease and growing anticipation rising in his throat.

Subaru figured that if anyone in the world would welcome the arrival of a Sin Archbishop, it would likely only be himself, Wilhelm, and possibly Ferris.

If the Sin Archbishop of Gluttony was truly present here, it would be like a moth flying straight into the flame.

It would be the perfect opportunity to make him pay for the devastation he had caused, and reclaim what he had stolen.

Echidna: "If it is truly the one you are hoping for…"

Subaru: "Then it's obvious. —I'll take Rem back."

Clenching his fist, Subaru spoke out the unwavering resolve that had taken root deep within him.

Even now, Rem, who had both her Name and Memories stolen, remained trapped in her endless sleep. The desire to bring her back was one of the main reasons Subaru had

decided to make a Contract with Echidna.

If the enemy truly was the Sin Archbishop of Gluttony, it would be the jackpot he had been waiting for. Even if it turned out not to be him, they would at least gain a lead on the whereabouts of that monster and his detestable mouth.

Subaru: "So, how do we identify the Sin Archbishop?"

Echidna: "Well, that is the problem."

Subaru: "…The problem?"

Contrary to Subaru's steely resolve, Echidna's response was casual and light. A bad feeling crept over Subaru, and as he furrowed his brow, the voice in his head continued with an ominous, "Actually,"

Echidna: "Normally, a Witch… ah, right, we are dealing with a Sin Archbishop here. Normally, a Sin Archbishop would be surrounded by Miasma. It should make them easy to spot."

Subaru: "Miasma… so, I'm the problem?"

Echidna: "Sadly, you are correct. Due to all your accreted deaths and use of your Authority, your Miasma is now so thick it is practically drowning the entire venue, concealing any Sin Archbishop who might be present."

The cruel irony of the situation left Subaru unable to blame Echidna.

Subaru saw this as a consequence of his decision to fully leverage Return by Death. Even if he had known about it beforehand, the option of not using it was never on the table.

Subaru: "No point in regretting what's already done. So, what should I do now?"

Echidna: "It will take a slightly unusual approach, like… a human wave attack."

Subaru was momentarily confused by Echidna's suggestion, but the answer soon became apparent.

Echidna's description was apt: an unusual human wave attack, indeed.

Subaru: "There must be at least… what, four or five hundred people here?"

Echidna: "Then, even if you are hopelessly unlucky, it should only take five hundred tries."

She said it so nonchalantly, and Subaru had plenty of things he wanted to snap back with, like how there was no way he could be that unlucky, but he held his tongue.

After all, it was not like he could boast about having any luck.

5

Easily swayed by the Witch's sweet words, Subaru's chosen strategy was a simple one.

In essence, it was the same tactic he had used on Crusch, Anastasia, and even Roswaal— approaching people randomly and asking, "Are you a Sin Archbishop?"

Ideally, he would have preferred to ask multiple people as a joke in one go, but Subaru quickly learned just how much the Sin Archbishops were despised in this world.

In most cases, just mentioning the term caused intense tension, and the moment Subaru threw accusations of being a Sin Archbishop, his targets would become deeply agitated.

At first, he had hoped that their reactions were signs of having been identified as a Sin Archbishop, but—

Echidna: "You are one of the most renowned Witch Cult hunters, having defeated a Sin Archbishop. If someone like you were to suspect one of being a Sin Archbishop, they would deny it with everything they have."

And so, Echidna's reminder prompted Subaru to reconsider his approach and the need to be more careful in how he phrased his questions.

And so, accreting more retries, Subaru meticulously questioned each participant in the ceremony. Frankly, reaching five hundred attempts was the worst-case scenario, and he had expected to find the answer in far fewer attempts.

However, reality was unforgiving to Subaru, as the number of trials exceeded four hundred, pushing relentlessly toward the dreaded five hundred mark.

Subaru, however, had his justifications.

Naturally, in this kind of operation, he started by targeting people whose backgrounds were unknown or suspicious.

In this case, unknown meant people with whom Subaru had little to no personal connection.

He first questioned unfamiliar faces, other factions' supporters, and the ceremony staff. When that yielded no results, he moved on to the next stage: targeting individuals from other camps and people he knew by name.

Honestly, this was little more than a precautionary measure. He did not expect to find the culprit here, but once he had started, he had to see it through.

That was all there was to it. And yet—

???: "—Why would you think such a thing? Unfathomable."

The response he got from one particular person sparked something strange within Subaru.

Even in hindsight, he could not quite understand why that answer lingered in his mind. Some had misunderstood his intentions, and others had asked him similar questions.

And yet, for some reason, this person stood out to him in a way the others had not, though he could not explain why.

So, to get to the bottom of it—

Subaru: "Are you a sin Archbishop?" "Are you familiar with the word "Gluttony"?" "Do you happen to be a spy from one of the Camps?" "What do you cherish?" "Who's your family?" "Where are you from? "If you were to be an animal, what would you be?" "Does hearing the word Witch delight you?" "Do you know about Petelgeuse?" "What do you think of Petelgeuse?" "Shall we talk together about Echidna?" "Where did you meet Roswaal?" "Aren't you frightened of the Silver Haired

Half Elf?" "E.M.T." "What do you think about betraying?" "What do you value?" "Do you like money?" "What do you like?" "How are you doing?" "Did you get a haircut?" "You're trying to kill me, aren't you?"

He fired off his questions relentlessly, and he deliberately took to the stage for the final round.

The wise elder with the long white beard presented him with the commendation, and asked him to say a few words. Normally, this was the point where Subaru would turn and be killed by "something."

But, as Subaru turned around this time, nothing unusual happened to his chest. He took a step forward, looking down at the people waiting for his words, and spotted a face in the corner of the venue.

And, Subaru smiled at the person who had been watching him all along—

Subaru: "—You are my enemy, Clind."

6

—Subaru knew shockingly little about the blue-haired man called Clind.

Technically, Clind was a member of the Emilia faction— though strictly speaking, it was because his master, Annerose Miload, was a branch of the Mathers family, thus aligning him with their camp.

That said, he had known Roswaal's maids, like Ram and Frederica, for quite some time, and even Emilia was familiar with him. In other words, he seemed to have a deeper connection to Roswaal than even his own master, Annerose.

That was precisely why Subaru had postponed questioning him. In hindsight, this was a mistake that had needlessly increased the number of attempts.

Subaru continued questioning every last participant just to be sure, but Clind was the only one who had raised any alarm for both him and the soul bound to his mind.

In other words, Clind was likely involved with the inner workings of the Witch Cult and wielded an Authority—

Echidna: "Of course, just because someone has a Witch Factor does not necessarily make them part of the Witch Cult. My friends and I were not, for example."

Subaru: "But, you guys were just as dangerous as them, right?"

Echidna: "Well, yes, each of us almost destroyed the world at least once…"

Echidna, the wicked soul, spoke as if it were no big deal, but if someone had nearly wiped out the world even once, they should absolutely be classified as a threat.

Setting aside Echidna's skewed sense of reality, Subaru refocused on how to deal with Clind.

Subaru: "So, we know Clind is using an Authority to kill me, but what exactly is it?"

Echidna: "I do not know. The effects of each Authority vary from one person to another. I am sure even the current Greed manifests an Authority different from mine."

Subaru: "So, he could be using invisible hands to kill me, like Petelgeuse?"

Petelgeuse's Unseen Hand had indeed allowed him to commit such acts. Subaru had been lucky to see them early on, but had they remained invisible, it would have been a nightmare to deal with.

Much like back then, this battle would start with uncovering the nature of his opponent's Authority.

Subaru: "Got any leads on how he's killing me?"

Echidna: "I have a few ideas. From what I have seen, your heart is being destroyed while you are on the stage. So, invisible hands are definitely a possibility, though using something similar to Petelgeuse would be boring."

Subaru: "This isn't a manga serialization meeting. We don't get to choose abilities based on how interesting they are."

It was incredibly versatile and hard to defend against. Unseen Hand was an outstanding ability in that regard. It would be a terrifying threat if multiple people could wield such power.

On top of that, Petelgeuse had the resilience typical of Evil Spirits, making him incredibly hard to kill. Even now, thinking back on it, he was a formidable foe, one Subaru would never want to face again.

Echidna: "But even so, you cannot back down if you are against a Sin Archbishop."

Subaru: "—. Sin Archbishop or not, I'll crush anyone who lays a hand on my own people."

Echidna: "Ohhh, so scary. And the worst part is, I know you mean it."

Subaru could almost imagine the unseen Echidna shrugging at his response. His exchange with the Witch felt so natural that, without missing a beat, Subaru began planning his next move to deal with Clind.

At the very least, so long as he knew that Clind would make his move while he was on the stage—

Echidna: "Where will you start?"

Subaru: "Isn't it obvious?"

The excitement in Echidna's voice was barely concealed, as if she were anticipating the unraveling of the unknown.

The Witch's inappropriate eagerness was oddly reassuring to Subaru. With that thought in mind, he closed one eye.

Subaru: "—Gathering intel. If you know the enemy and know yourself, you need not fear the result of a hundred battles"

Echidna: "I doubt Sun Tzu considered that in order to avoid danger in a hundred battles, one might have to lose hundreds of times first."

Subaru smiled at Echidna's wry remark, and said "That's a fair point."

7

???: "Clind, is it? Yes, I see. He has been serving the Master for many years, and now, on the Master's orders, he is working as Annerose-sama's steward."

???: "As per the Master, most of the Mathers household servants are trained by Clind. Embarrassing as it is, even I learned the basics of being a maid from him."

???: "Skilled, versatile, the perfect steward… There's no end to the praise for Clind. His abilities as a steward are truly unmatched, and I still feel ashamed of how much I have to learn. But…"

???: "But, as a person, he is far from admirable. Some might mistake him for a devoted, caring teacher… but, it is all just superficial."

???: "His true nature is that of a beast who blatantly favors the young. Once someone grows up a bit, he loses interest. I, too, was treated horribly…"

???: "Subaru-sama, you need to be careful. Not for yourself, Subaru-sama, but for Emilia-sama. She may look mature, but emotionally, she is still very much a child…"

???: "Clind's focus is not swayed by looks or actual age. He claims to see the soul or whatever; anyway, that's how it is!"

????: "Concerning Clind…? Once again, you are stirring up unnecessary trouble before a big event."

????: "You will be called up to the stage when the award ceremony starts. Stay quiet until then. If you mess up during the ceremony, no one will be able to bail you out."

????: "…You want to chat to calm your nerves? You would be better off talking to Emilia-sama if that's the case. And of all things, you choose to talk about Clind?"

????: "—. No, it's fine. This is Barusu we're talking about, after all. There must be some meaning behind it. Rather, if there isn't, Ram would be surprised. And despise you for it."

????: "Clind is Roswaal-sama's steward. He can handle most tasks single-handedly, and he is incredibly skilled. He has never been seen breaking a sweat."

????: "He is currently serving under Annerose-sama, and is particularly attached to that young mistress… He has a soft spot for children. He used to dote on Ram quite a bit… And on Rem too, surely."

????: "If that girl is Ram's sister, she naturally must have also had interactions with Clind, right? Well, that doesn't matter now since that has all been forgotten. Back to the matter of Clind."

????: "As for how long he has served Roswaal-sama, even Ram does not know. It's said that their relationship goes back quite far, so you should ask Roswaal-sama directly."

????: "…Not quite sure what your intentions are, but Ram would avoid quarrels with Clind. It's not a matter of strength or weakness. He is just impossible to figure out."

?????: "Curious about Clind? Oh, that's an eaaasy~ request. He and I have known each other for quite a long time. I'm sure there's plenty I could teeell~ you."

?????: "To begin with, he's serving Annerose on my orders. Annerose is, after all, a candidate to become the next Roswaal, you seeeee~. I needed some insurance to keep "her" safe."

?????: "I've made a Contract with him. So long as it does not interfere with his duties, he is contracted to protect my assets. Annerose is considered one of those assets."

?????: "Compensation for the Contract, you ask? Oh, that was settled long ago. Yes, it was a joint effort to defeat a certain enemy. It was an old nemesis of mine, so the timing was quite convenient."

?????: "Ever since, Clind has been faithfully keeping up his end of the Contract. Althooough~, I doubt he expected to accompany me for this looong~."

?????: "He is exceedingly principled, you see. He could have walked away the moment the generation he had made the promise to had passed on. It seems that being able to see souls makes him a bit rigid in his ways."

?????: "As for any weaknesses… I can't say I've come across any. If I had to name one, it would be his particular attachment to Annerose. Not just out of duty as a servant to a master, but out of fondness."

?????: "It is nothing romantic, mind you. He's just drawn to her nature. There's a brilliance within her… a purity and innocence he can never have. And that, I believe, is what keeps him tied to the world of the living."

8

???: "—Subaru-sama, do you have a moment? Time."

Just as Subaru searched for the person he wanted to find, the person in question called out to him.

Subaru turned around to find a slender-faced figure in a butler's uniform standing before him. He had neatly-cut dark blue hair, a monocle adorning a sharp eye, and the kind of handsome, upright bearing that one would expect to see in a painting; yet, strangely, his presence felt faint.

When Subaru had asked him about it before, he had explained that a servant should not stand out in front of others.

It was certainly a fearsome skill if he could consciously erase his presence like that. But for now, that did not matter.

Subaru: "Sure, no problem, Clind-san. I have lots of time to kill."

Clind: “Killing time, you say? How humble. Today, Subaru-sama is one of the main guests of honor… surely, no one would leave you alone. Busy.”

Subaru: “Well, it’s more like everyone’s being considerate of me, so I’m left sitting quietly in a corner. Ram even scolded me for acting like a kid.”

Clind: “I see. That sounds typical of her. Immutable.”

At the edge of the venue, Subaru shrugged his shoulders in his unfamiliar formal attire while Clind gave a soft smile.

Clind had always given the impression of being expressionless, but while his reactions were subtle, he did in fact display emotions. Subaru had assumed that being an exemplary butler meant remaining composed, and by extension, emotionless, but this had proven to be a misconception.

Clind: “Subaru-sama? Puzzled.”

Subaru: “Ah, sorry. I was lost in thought for a moment… this is the first time we’ve really had a proper conversation, Clind-san.”

Clind: “Regarding that, I apologize for the belated greeting. I should have been visiting the Mathers’s main estate more frequently… Reflection.”

Subaru: “Yeah, and I would’ve loved to help out with the cleanup after the Witchbeasts wrecked the place, but I had some business to take care of.”

Clind: “—Business?”

Clind murmured, narrowing the eye behind his monocle. For a brief moment, Subaru caught a glimpse of something predatory, a hawk-like sharpness in Clind’s gaze, and it made him involuntarily wince.

At the same time, Subaru could not help but mock his own acting ability as they continued this shallow conversation.

At some point, he had developed the ability to hide his true feelings, even when he knew what the other person was plotting.

Even if something unexpected were to happen, so long as it led to Subaru’s Death, there would always be a chance to correct it. —Thus, he had grown harder to shake.

Echidna: “That is why you managed to keep it together even when you found out someone who was half a friend was an enemy.”

Echidna’s commentary on Subaru’s thoughts chimed in like clockwork in his mind.

At this point, perhaps discerning between her helpful advice and useless chatter had become a skill unto itself.

Clind: “Subaru-sama, concerning the other day…”

Subaru: “Yeah?”

Clind: “Where were you while Emilia-sama and the Master stayed at our residence… at Annerose-sama’s Miload mansion? Inquiry.”

Subaru: “Where was I…”

Clind raised a finger, asking the question with a casual air. But, Subaru knew the innocuous tone belied the suspicion behind Clind’s question.

He was referring to the time after Subaru had simultaneously resolved the problems at the Sanctuary and the mansion: when the Mathers Estate had been ravaged by the Witchbeasts' attack, and had been temporarily relocated to the Miload Estate. Though the entire affair had lasted fewer than ten days, unlike Emilia and the others who were at Annerose's mansion, Subaru had been absent most of that time due to another task.

That other task, of course, was—

Echidna: "—Preparing to take me out of the tomb, right?."

Exactly as Echidna's voice confirmed in his head, that was the reason he had acted separately.

Subaru: "…"

There were three conditions for Echidna to be released from the tomb.

The first was clearing the Trials to lift the barrier; the second was securing a Magic Crystal to house Echidna's soul; and the third was finalizing their Contract—

Echidna: "To put it simply, my soul was forcibly tethered to the tomb. We needed to reassign your body as my next host to get me out of there."

Subaru: "That was one damn painful ordeal… by the way, don't you think there are too many hidden costs in this Contract of yours?"

Echidna: "Think of it as renting an apartment where they do not disclose that the previous tenant committed suicide… no, that sounds too cheap. Let us say a condo instead. Yes, that fits better."

Subaru: "I think you're missing the point of what's cheap here…"

Echidna's strange obsessions aside, Clind's curiosity was suspicious.

Subaru had told him that he had been out on an errand. That should have been the end of it. Especially for someone in his position, known as the versatile steward, pushing further would have been overstepping.

And yet, the reason he chose to press the issue anyway was—

Subaru: "Clind-san, cut it out with the phony questions."

Clind: "…"

Subaru: "You already know the answer. That's why you came to talk to me. Right?"

Subaru had already figured out Clind's intentions, and met his gaze head-on with a wary glare. In response, Clind slightly widened his eyes, straightened his posture, and said, "With all due respect,"

Clind: "Subaru-sama, you are carrying something rather nasty. Danger."

Subaru: "Danger, huh? You mean this thing hanging around my neck?"

Clind: "The answer to that is both affirmative and negative. That is not what I was referring to. Misjudgment."

Clind gestured toward the Magic Crystal dangled on Subaru's chest with a lowered voice. There was no longer any doubt. —Clind knew precisely what it was.

Clind: "I must advise you that this thing is far worse than dangerous. If you keep it at your side, it will bring harm not only to you, but to everyone around you. Unprecedented."

Subaru: "He's talking about you."

Echidna: "Yes, I can hear that."

Clind's earnest warning might have rattled Subaru in the past. However, the Subaru standing here now was no longer the Subaru he once was.

One could argue that Clind's mistake was underestimating Subaru.

Unfortunately, they had long passed the point where mere conversation could resolve anything between them.

Echidna: "He is the reason you have died more than five hundred times already, after all."

Subaru: "I've already taken every possible precaution at that level."

Clind: "—? What exactly…"

"are you saying?" was probably what Clind was about to say. But, before he could, Subaru, keeping his voice low enough not to draw attention, called out to him with "Clind-san,"

Subaru: "Why are you talking to me? You've already made up your mind, haven't you? You'll settle this when I'm called up to the stage during the ceremony, out in front of everyone."

Clind: "—Hk, how."

Subaru: "Well, It's strange, really. You're set on killing me, but you want to avoid causing too much trouble for Emilia and the others. So, you're aiming for a time and place where suspicion might fall outside of our camp, right?. I'm not sure I follow your reasoning."

Through countless trials and discussions with Echidna after Subaru's many deaths, they had concluded that Clind's intentions were exactly as expected.

In other words, Clind wanted to kill Subaru, the Witch's contractor, but he also intended to use Subaru's death as a benefit of Emilia Camp.

Therefore—

Subaru: "I can't figure out where your loyalty lies. So, be honest with me. —Are you a Witch Cultist? One of the Archbishops of Sin?"

Subaru's questions for Clind came like an ultimatum.

But it was still too indirect. He knew he needed to be more direct, to cut to the heart of the matter—

Subaru: "Do you know Gluttony? I've got something I need to attend to with him."

Clind: "—To all of your questions, no I shall answer. Denial."

Subaru: "I see… I see."

Clind shook his head in response, which was not the answer Subaru had hoped for.

But, as a result, it settled how he would deal with Clind.

Subaru: "Listen up, Clind-san. Where was Annerose again?"

Clind: "…"

Subaru: "That was what you wanted to ask me about right?"

Finding that his master was absent from his side, Clind had approached Subaru alone.

He must have thought that since Annerose was not near the key figures at this ceremony, Subaru would be the only one up to something shady.

It was an insulting assumption. However—

Subaru: "You're right on the money."

Clind: "Annerose-sama, where is she? Location."

Subaru: "She's now my hostage. I knew you'd try something on that stage, you see. How I found out is a trade secret."

Clind: "…So, that too is the work of the Witch that accompanies you. Strategy."

As Clind furrowed his brow in disbelief, Echidna muttered, "How rude," in Subaru's mind. But, this misunderstanding worked in his favor.

After all, Natsuki Subaru always found it easier to act when he was underestimated.

Echidna: "Being seen as formidable does have its perks in avoiding getting targeted, you know."

Subaru: "It's fine. If I look weaker than Emilia, then I will be targeted first."

While conversing with Echidna in his head, Subaru kept his eyes on the increasingly wary Clind.

Everyone praised him as a calm, versatile steward. However, even the most composed individual would hesitate to act when their most precious person was in danger.

In that light, bringing Annerose here seemed like a mistake, but it would have been cruel of Subaru to blame Clind for that.

Subaru: "After all, you only decided to kill me after we arrived here."

Clind: "—. How, to that extent could you…? Incomprehensible."

Subaru: "I heard it from you directly."

Clind was aghast. The clear divide between him and Subaru was the difference in knowledge.

Having all his thoughts, actions, and even what he held dear laid bare truly must have felt like a nightmare for Clind.

But, the feeling concerning nightmares was mutual. Subaru had been through his own personal hell more times than he could count.

Echidna: "Want me to tell you how many?"

Subaru: "I'll pass."

Rejecting his companion's offer, who likely had been dutifully keeping track, Subaru focused his attention back on Clind.

Behind those piercing eyes of his, Clind was grappling with inner turmoil. Whatever that conflict was, unfortunately, it lay entirely within Subaru's grasp.

Clind struggled between securing Annerose's safety, and pursuing his own objective.

And, Subaru already knew which way the scales would tip.

Subaru: “So, what will it be? Will you surrender?”

Clind: “—No. Preserving the world takes priority. Disloyalty.”

Clind’s gaze sharpened as he said this, his focus shifting toward Subaru’s chest.

Subaru sensed the impending danger. He knew Clind’s Authority of unknown origins would, just like before, try to destroy his heart and inflict a fatal, unrecoverable wound.

Which was why Subaru dealt with it before it could reach him.

Subaru: “—THE WITCH CULT!!”

Clind: “—?!”

Clind’s eyes widened as Subaru’s voice, filled with sharp tension, resounded through the hall.

Right after that moment, just as Clind gasped in surprise.

—A group of fierce warriors, radiating an overwhelming swordsmanship, attacked Clind all at once.

9

Preparing in advance had not been a difficult task for Subaru.

As had been repeatedly stated, Subaru was one of the main guests of honor at this evening’s commendation ceremony. Furthermore, his efforts in taking down the White Whale and Sloth had more than earned him the merit.

The idea that the Witch Cult had sent an assassin to the commendation ceremony to target Subaru was all too convincing to those who had recently clashed with the Cult.

Of course, there was some resistance to the suggestion that the assassin was none other than Clind, the long-serving steward of the Mathers family.

The one most strongly opposed to this was Frederica, who had been trained in the basics of service by Clind himself, and Ram also seemed to share her sentiments to some extent.

Therefore, Subaru had proposed one condition to convince them and those around him.

The condition was—

Echidna: “—That Clind shows murderous intent toward you.”

Subaru: “Well, things might get dicey before anyone can make a move if I provoke him too much.”

If things went wrong, he could always just start over.

In actuality, even with Annerose as a hostage, Clind’s inner conflict still pushed him to choose duty over the safety of his master.

However, the full significance of that duty remained a mystery.

Subaru: “Trying to dig out the true motives of the <u>type</u> of man who doesn’t care for parting words is no easy task.”

If every enemy were to spill their plans to their dying foe, not many in this world would be compatible with this as much as Subaru. It would make planning for their next encounter much simpler.

But, in reality, most people met their end without hearing much from their killer.

Perhaps they rambled on to their corpses after death, but it would no longer be Subaru's concern by that point.

In any case, Subaru had fulfilled all the necessary conditions to corner Clind.

Clind's fatal mistake was falling for Subaru's provocations and making his move on the spot. If he had taken a better look at his surroundings, he might have noticed that he was being watched.

Echidna: "But you secured his mistress to throw him off balance and keep him from noticing."

The fabricated information about Clind being a Witch Cultist, the efforts to ensure he would not realize he was under suspicion, and a hostage to force his hand.

Subaru had gone through all this just to bring things to this anticipated conclusion.

If any of these conditions had not been met, Subaru would have fallen prey to Clind's Authority for months and years on end— counting all the attempts required to identify him as the enemy, Subaru's retries easily reached four figures.

But, all that time and effort had paid off.

Subaru: "You tried to kill me right in front of everyone. There's no explaining your way out of that."

Indeed, security around the ceremony had intensified, and the evacuation of key figures was swiftly underway.

Seeing the situation turning against him, Clind had leaped from the balcony. However, in light of his previous actions, it was hard to believe he intended to simply flee.

Left unchecked, who knew what Clind might attempt next? Subaru was not the only one who thought so.

And if Clind was thinking the same, then the only logical conclusion was that tonight, here and now, would be the final showdown.

Subaru: "—Hey hey, where are you, bro! Playing hide and seek? How cold!"

Leaning over the balcony railing, Subaru called out provocatively into the garden below.

If he could not pinpoint Clind's location, he would just make himself a grand, obvious target. Anyone in Clind's position would feel compelled to take a shot at Subaru, seeing him standing there wide open and defenseless.

Echidna: "And if that ends up getting you killed?"

Subaru: "So long as I can figure out the trick behind Clind's Authority, I'll call it a win even if he crushes my heart!"

So far, the only thing Subaru knew was that Clind had managed to crush his heart from a distance.

It was an instant-death attack, but it could not be something he could use without any limits.

The number of uses, continuity, and activation conditions. Every time Subaru learned one more detail, he inched closer to putting Clind in checkmate.

Subaru: "Wilhelm-san, Julius, and even the captain of the Royal Guard are with me. I'm sorry it's so one-sided, but I'm gonna crush you with everything I have at my disposal."

Echidna: "You sure are talking a lot… Is this one of your Days of Joy?"

Subaru: "Is that so? I wasn't aware of that though."

Responding to the voice of Echidna in his head, Subaru bared his teeth as he searched for his elusive enemy.

As Echidna had called it, a Day of Joy was one of Subaru's mental states, alongside his Days of Wrath and Calm. It seemed to describe the emotional ups and downs he experienced.

Compared to the other two, Subaru did not show any particularly subjective symptoms. Unlike becoming violently aggressive or sinking into despair, it did not seem like a problem.

Therefore—

Subaru: "I've given you company till now. Stop running around like a mouse, and come at me from the front!"

He deliberately raised his voice, broadcasting his position, and acted provocatively, hoping to flush out his opponent.

Everything was part of the plan. There were no issues there.

Perhaps he was not exactly calm, but one could say he was in the zone. Riding this momentum would lead to a good outcome. Even though he could die as many times as needed, in this situation, he felt like he had died a little too much. Getting reckless with his lives was not the best idea.

Therefore, he judged that taking appropriate actions to secure victory was essential.

???: "—OHHH!"

Suddenly, a loud noise sounded from behind the venue.

It was likely that Clind had clashed with one of his pursuers. Subaru hurried toward the commotion, eager to join the fray.

It was not just his curiosity, influenced by Echidna's penchant for spectacle. No, it was crucial for Subaru to witness the facts with his own eyes.

—Otherwise, he would not fully grasp Clind's actions for the next round.

Subaru: "Tsk."

Rounding the back of the building, Subaru clicked his tongue at the sight that greeted him.

The neatly trimmed hedges and vibrant backyard flower beds were now marred by the bodies of those who had fought valiantly against Clind. They lay crumpled, utterly

defeated.

Among them were familiar faces, and Subaru scratched his head at the realization.

Subaru: "I thought I knew this already, but the troublesomeness of Authority holders really is too much to handle."

Clind: "…Is that all you have to say? Heartless."

Subaru: "Heartless? That's rich coming from the guy responsible for all this mess."

Without exception, every fallen figure had their life force entirely extinguished.

Whether it was out of courtesy or caution, Clind had shown no mercy. Either way, the scene was so gruesome that one would want to cover their eyes.

It would have been enough to leave him broken beyond repair had this situation not been reversible.

Subaru: "But, you're not unscathed either. So, who gave you the most trouble? You'd be doing me a favor by letting me know for future reference."

Clind: "—! Your acquaintances got rolled up into this and died, and yet this is all you care about? There is too much that is crooked about your way of being. Hideous."

Clind's lips curled as he spoke, his voice filled with emotion, his body covered in countless wounds.

He had faced numerous skilled opponents, some of whom even Subaru had relied on as top-tier fighters. Naturally, Clind had not escaped unscathed.

His tattered coat lay discarded, his shirt soaked in blood from a gash across his chest. His monocle lay shattered on the grass, exposing his sharp features as he glared at the defenseless Subaru.

His eyes were filled with fierce hatred and righteous indignation, as if cursing Subaru for being inhuman.

Subaru: "It seems like our opinions don't match. Guess this is the first time I understand how Echidna feels."

Echidna: "Maybe now you will treat me a little better."

Subaru: "I'll think about it."

Clind: "Natsuki Subaru-sama, it looks like we're both already not compatible with each other… Resolve."

Ignoring his side exchange with Echidna, Clind's eyes were locked on Subaru, full of unwavering hostility.

That hostility was about to take shape and strike Subaru down— right before something intervened.

Frederica: "CLIIIIIIIIND—!!"

A gust of wind tore between Subaru and Clind, accompanied by the flash of long golden hair and the imposing figure of a tall woman clad in a maid's uniform.

Her emerald eyes welled with tears, and her sharp fangs were bared in fury. It was Frederica.

At the sight of her, Clind's expression stiffened ever so slightly.

Clind: "Frederica…"

Frederica: “I always looked down on you, Clind. But regardless of what, I never expected you to get yourself involved with something so tyrannical…”

Grinding her teeth, Frederica surveyed the carnage around her, voicing her bitter frustration.

The blood-soaked garden Clind had created was littered with far more than just ten or twenty lost lives, and it utterly shattered the trust Frederica had held in him, trust that had held strong till the very end, into tiny pieces.

She knew the option of clearing up doubts through discussion was off the table, for it had been Clind who had first shown intent to kill Subaru.

Thus, Frederica glared at Clind with rage and sorrow in her eyes.

Frederica: “Why did you stray from the right path, Clind?”

Clind: “….No matter how much you say, nothing will change. Pointless.”

Frederica: “—! Whether it is meaningless or not is not for you to decide, it’s up to us!”

Clind: “—. I’m sorry. Apologies.”

As Frederica let out a fierce roar, Clind lowered his gaze and uttered those words.

In that moment, Subaru, though an outsider, could almost hear the sound of Frederica’s heart cracking.

Frederica: “…”

Frederica’s pupils narrowed, and a low growl rumbled from her throat.

In the blink of an eye, her body began to transform, white skin covered by golden fur as her bones audibly shifted. Frederica’s form grew in size at an incredible speed.

The next moment, a female golden leopard stood in her place.

The maid’s uniform was shredded apart as she transformed, clinging like tattered remnants to her hulking frame as the beast-like Frederica crouched low.

And then—

Clind: “No matter how many years have passed, you never change. Childlike innocence.”

Frederica: “How dare you… blown away!!”

With a swift leap, Frederica’s body became a whirlwind, the bloodstained petals around her dancing in the violent gust.

As she charged forward at terrifying speed, she caught Clind off guard, sending his body flying into the air. Blood spurted from his left shoulder as he spun, and before he could regain his balance, more savage strikes rained down upon him from all sides.

Echidna: “Tremendous.”

As Echidna’s brief remark suggested, Frederica’s speed was nothing short of extraordinary.

Her movements had always been impressive in her beast form, but the anger she channeled through her limbs after being betrayed had propelled her speed to an entirely new level.

Her claws and fangs tore into Clind's flesh, slowly but surely sapping his remaining strength.

Yet, the fact that Frederica's power could surpass that of the Knights, who had already fallen in the garden, was unlikely. Her fangs only found their mark because those who had fought before her had already weakened Clind's reserves and, perhaps, because of the emotional strain Clind was under.

Even someone as composed as Clind would struggle when faced with turning an old acquaintance into an enemy.

Subaru: "Maybe they're more than just old acquaintances."

Echidna: "—? What do you mean by that?"

Subaru: "It'd be hard to explain the intricacies of male-female relationships to you, so I'll pass."

Although they both saw the same thing, Subaru ignored the Witch and her inability to grasp the situation.

The battle between Frederica and Clind was reaching its climax before his eyes.

Clind: "…"

Still suspended in midair, Clind was helpless as he took the full brunt of Frederica's attacks.

The wounds he sustained and the amount of blood he was losing were accelerating, pushing him ever closer to death from blood loss. However, even with death looming, Clind's eyes remained undaunted.

Amidst the relentless onslaught, his gaze was firmly locked on Subaru.

As if Frederica was nothing more than an afterthought to him.

Frederica: "Where on earth are you looking at—!"

That realization seemed to dawn on Frederica as well.

Her voice trembled with frustration at being ignored, and to Subaru, it almost sounded like she was on the verge of tears.

It was the anguished cry of a young girl, desperately pleading with an adult for attention, unable to comprehend why he would not take her seriously. Her pained voice struck Subaru deeply, but the cold-hearted man remained unaffected.

Without shifting his gaze from Subaru, Clind reached out his hands and said,

Clind: "This too, is for the world… no, for the promise I made. Impoliteness."

With a voice tinged with regret, Clind's hands clenched.

In the next instant, Frederica, who had been charging across the ground, lost her balance and was violently thrown to the ground.

Frederica: "—hk?!"

Frederica, covered in dust, had no idea what had just happened.

All she knew was that her limbs had been crushed, and she had lost the ability to run across the ground. And—

Frederica: "S-Subaru-sama…! Please, you must flee!"

The path to Subaru was wide open, with nothing and no one standing in the way.

Frederica: "…"

Writhing on the ground, Frederica's body slowly began reverting from beast to human. But, of course, the wounds she had sustained did not conveniently heal in the process.

With her limbs crushed and her body covered in grievous injuries, Frederica lay there helpless. And yet, despite being horribly wounded himself, Clind walked past her with steady steps.

Clind's body was as battered and bloodied as Frederica's, but his eyes showed no sign of weakness. Only an unwavering, ironclad resolve.

Subaru: "So you can make that kind of face too. How unexpected, Clind-san."

Clind: "…The words I have exchanged with you are far too brief. Scant."

Subaru: "Yeah, you're right. I wanted to talk more to you…. It's sorta got a deceptive tone about it, but that's what I really think. Perhaps we could have built a different relationship."

In another timeline, in a what-if scenario, perhaps there could have been a different path.

But even if that path had existed, becoming closer to someone destined to betray him would only have hurt Subaru more.

Subaru: "That's why I am glad I didn't become friends with you. This is the right path"

Clind: "—. You really are acting complacent. No one can defend you anymore. Defenseless."

Clind frowned in suspicion as Subaru casually stood there with his hands in his pockets.

Subaru understood why he was confused, and part of him felt slightly guilty. But, after enduring countless Deaths, this was only natural.

Subaru: "Sorry, but you won't shake me so easily anymore."

Clind: "——?"

Subaru: "I'm not feigning confidence. If you wanted to, Clind-san, you could kill me in an instant. And that's not a big deal."

If he were to die, he would just come back with a new plan.

Echidna and Roswaal understood why Subaru's Authority was the most terrifying, yet the most remarkable. Even Subaru knew this was essentially cheating.

He was using his cheat ability to the fullest, as one would expect of someone who had been summoned to another world.

Clind: "Your thinking is hard to comprehend. Unfathomable. But, prepare yourself for—"

Subaru: "Oh, just one more thing."

Clind had given up on trying to understand Subaru's strange confidence.

But, before his hands could reach Subaru's chest, Subaru interrupted him, raising a single finger as he pulled his hand from his pocket,

Subaru: "—I made sure Frederica would be next if I died."

Clind: "…"

Subaru didn't miss the slight twitch that froze Clind's expression.

That reaction alone was more than enough of a gain.

Clind's weak point was neither his Contract with Roswaal, nor was it Annerose.

Clind: "The real threat was never the Witch. It was you. Wicked."

Subaru heard Clind mutter in a trembling voice, horrified to the core by the realization.

Calling him wicked might have been a bit much, Subaru thought, feeling dissatisfied as the moment his heart would burst was approaching—

10

???: "It was an unknown situation, but you handled it rather well. How are you feeling?"

Subaru: "Nothing to worry about. I'm feeling great."

On the familiar hill, Subaru responded to Echidna's straightforward question.

Subaru was dressed in the black formal attire he had worn for the commendation ceremony. It might be a bit late to mention this, but the dress code for the Witch's tea party was whatever the guest happened to be wearing when they were summoned.

As a result, he had been stuck in his tracksuit during the tea parties in the Sanctuary, and this time, he was stuck in his formal attire.

Subaru: "Let's just hope I don't get accidentally summoned while I'm in the bathroom."

Echidna: "Ah, that's a way to do it."

Subaru: "That wasn't a suggestion. You're more of a peeping Witch than a curious bystander."

Echidna snapped her fingers with a serious look on her face, and Subaru, leaning in, flicked her on the forehead. "Ow!" the Witch exclaimed, recoiling with a grimace.

Echidna rubbed her reddened forehead and said,

Echidna: "How rude of you. Not like by now there isn't a place on your body that I haven't seen."

Subaru: "Yeah, that's because I bring that Magic Crystal everywhere, even in the toilet and the bath! But, it's about my feelings, okay? Modesty is important. Absolutely."

Echidna: "You have the values of a maiden…"

Echidna muttered in exasperation, lowering her hand from her forehead, where the redness had already faded from her alabaster skin. Subaru could not help but be impressed by the Witch's flair for theatrics.

In any case, as Echidna had pointed out, the unknown situation had been handled.

Subaru: "Identifying the enemy, assessing the situation, establishing countermeasures, and finding the best solution…"

Echidna: “That fight revealed much about the tasks we face going forward. We might have lost some things, but I would say we gained just as much.”

Subaru: “I can’t argue with that… Though the follow-up with Annerose and Frederica won’t be easy.”

Subaru rubbed his chin, imagining the grief-stricken faces of the two women, and bit his lip.

In the end, they had resolved to frame the situation under the assumption that Clind had been a Witch Cultist.

Clind had shown clear intent to harm Subaru and retaliated without ever attempting to explain himself. With both of these facts in place, not a single person could defend him.

Strictly speaking, Subaru could have defended him, but that was a futile thought.

—Clind’s response to Subaru’s question had become the pivotal moment that sealed his fate.

Echidna: “Irony, isn’t it?. Had he truly been a Witch Cultist, you might have kept him alive to extract information about Gluttony. But…”

Subaru: “But Clind wasn’t a Witch Cultist. Which just made him a dangerous threat.”

And, Subaru was not confident enough to believe he could keep a dangerous man like him alive. At the very least, some kind of safeguard would have been necessary, and Clind had none.

Thus, Annerose and Frederica had been left in tears.

Echidna: “Beyond that, the damage was minimized. You could call it a result worth celebrating.”

Subaru: “…Yeah. It’d better be.”

If it were not, then there was no point in making them cry.

He had saved lives. He had prevented further damage. Moreover, he knew it would have been ideal to protect their hearts as well. He knew, but how could he possibly—

Echidna: “Natsuki Subaru, you must not misunderstand.”

Subaru: “Echidna?”

Echidna: “Your Authority allows you to choose the best result through infinite retries. But, the best result does not necessarily mean saving everyone involved.”

Subaru: “…”

Subaru fell silent as Echidna’s harsh words sank into his heart.

Even if he chose the best option, it was impossible to prevent everyone he cared for from receiving even the slightest scratch. But, if he accepted that, it felt like Subaru’s entire purpose would crumble.

It did not matter if he had to die a hundred, a thousand, or ten thousand times, so long as he could save everyone else.

That was the only reason Natsuki Subaru continued to challenge the spiral of Death.

Echidna: “Your feelings are noble, and your desire for your loved ones to be at peace is pure.”

Before Subaru, as his resolve wavered, Echidna spoke softly, her voice gentle.

In an uncharacteristically motherly manner, she gazed at Subaru and continued,

Echidna: “But, you cannot protect everyone forever, as if they were in a cradle. Even in the best of outcomes, shards of glass will slip through. And, those shards may cause wounds.”

Subaru: “…Then, how do I remove that glass?”

Echidna: “On that matter, my answer is as follows: You cannot remove all of the shards. There will be wounds. However…”

Subaru was about to protest her statement, but Echidna quickly continued, repeating the word “however” in a soft murmur,

Echidna: “So long as you stay alive, your wounds will heal. The Frederica and Annerose who you made cry today, tomorrow….or the day after, will stop crying.”

Subaru: “…”

Echidna: “Scratches will scab over, and eventually heal. If you worry so much about never even inflicting such wounds, your feet will stop moving, and you will be unable to move forward.”

Echidna’s carefully chosen words pierced Subaru’s heart without mercy.

Indeed, Echidna was right. Subaru had started to lose sight of what “best” even meant. He kept second-guessing himself, even after things had ended.

He had eliminated Clind. And as a result, Annerose and Frederica had been left in tears.

If he did not want to make them cry, should he have let Clind live? But, how else could Subaru have dealt with a man who wanted him dead?

That was—

Echidna: “—You are not wrong.”

Subaru: “Ah…”

Echidna: “I will continue to guarantee your righteousness. You have saved lives, found a way to the future, and left hope in your wake, thus paving the way for new possibilities. That is the result of your actions.”

Whenever Subaru’s resolve wavered, whenever he felt lost, the Witch was there to bring him back to reason.

Just as she had done countless times before, Echidna stood before Subaru and pulled him back from the brink.

He had used Return by Death hundreds of times now, and as a result, his fear of Death had dulled, and the crushing sense of loss and helplessness had faded. But still, some part of him was wearing thin.

His fraying and fragile soul was pulled back once again, and Subaru held his ground.

A swirl of wrath, calm, fleeting joy; this was what had overwhelmed his heart.

Subaru: “Even if I save them, wounds will remain. But…”

Echidna: “Where there is life…”

Subaru: “Where there is life… there is a future. Where there is a future, there is hope. Where there is hope, there is possibility. Where there is possibility—”

Echidna: “—People can be saved.”

Echidna quietly finished Subaru’s half-mumbled sentence.

People could be saved. The wounds they suffer would eventually heal.

The two who cried today would dry their tears tomorrow, lift their heads the day after, and the next day, perhaps even start walking forward again. Or, at least, begin to prepare to do so.

For that purpose—

Subaru: “—Let’s move time forward. I… no, we have a lot to do.”

Echidna: “—. Very well. So, where shall we begin next?”

Echidna deliberately did not comment on Subaru’s use of “we.”

And that was fine. He was not looking for her to cling to him.

He just wanted to confirm it: the unbreakable bond of complicity between her and him.

Subaru: “Ah, about that—”

And so, the journey of trial and error would continue, with the Witch bound to him in this shared complicity.

PROLOGUE IV:

THE PROGENY OF THE LION KING

???: "—Leave the Kingdom together with Old Man Rom. If you do that, your safety will be guaranteed."

In the middle of the night, she woke up to a presence entering her bedroom and shuddered.

The first thing that pierced through her mind was disappointment in her own loosened vigilance.

In the slums where she had originally lived, everyone around her was an enemy. There was no time or place where she could let her guard down. That was why she never lowered her defenses, even in her bedroom.

That should have been her source of pride for having grown up in the slums for fifteen years—

???: "I'm sorry for all the complications and self-reflection that's being posed on you, but you're not losing sleep over it, are you?"

Felt: "…Hey you, I don't know who the fuck you are or where you're from, but do you even know who you're picking a fight with?"

With a low-voiced threat, she argued back while still lying down on the bed.

Being treated with contempt was naturally the shameful sight it was, but she wasn't going to tolerate it indefinitely. So,

Even if this rubbed the other person the wrong way, she absolutely refused to grovel.

???: "You sure are acting tough, huh? Let me just tell you right now, that damn Reinhard is…"

Felt: "Screw you. Why did Reinhard's name come up when I'm the one that messed up, and now I gotta wipe my own ass?"

???: "…"

Felt: "I'm telling you, don't think you can get away with this for free. If you show me an opening, in an instant I'll… oh?"

She had intended with determination to bite his unguarded windpipe. However, her intent was dampened by the intruder's strange reaction.

Standing beside the bed, the intruder looked at her—suddenly, for some reason, his shoulders shook, and he began to chuckle a small laugh.

Felt: “Wh-What the hell’s so funny?”

???: “Hey, don’t use such a loud voice. I’m not sure if you can see what’s going on here… Well, you’re just being yourself by not calling Reinhard at this point, aren’t you?”

Felt: “Huh?”

She turned her head with a frown to the intruder, whose voice sounded somewhat distracted.

The initial sharp intensity was gone, as was the feeling of him doing something untoward if she moved. You could call it carelessness and it would be so, or you could call it intuition and it would be so.

In any case, it did not result in her regretting having turned around.

The intruder had done nothing to her, and more importantly, the person standing there was a familiar face.

Felt: “…Bro, what the hell are you doing here?”

???: “For no reason at all. My demands… wait, were you still half asleep and you didn’t hear me?”

Felt: “No, I heard you saying something about taking Old Man Rom and leaving…”

The demand did not match her impression of the person in front of her—a familiar, black-haired boy.

Looking at the boy, she saw he was unarmed, despite coming to threaten her.

He did not appear to be carrying a weapon, nor was he prepared to restrain her. As she slowly lifted herself off the bed, he did not tell her to wait or stop.

Naturally, she felt foolish for being so cautious, and roughly scratched her golden hair.

Regardless of the situation, there was no mistaking the fact that she had been caught off guard—

Felt: “Like, how did you even manage to sneak in? That damn Reinhard isn’t home tonight, but there’s other scary people here in this mansion…”

Black-haired Boy: “Yeah, there are. Flam and Grassis, yeah? The bodyguard twins, they might look cute, but they’re really good at what they do, so they gave me a hard time.”

Felt: “…”

Black-haired Boy: “And by a strange coincidence, I also know the three thugs you’re taking care of here at your place. I guess this is what they mean when they say that it’s a small world.”

When he had calmly pointed out those who should have been in the mansion, she fell silent.

Upon hearing that, she could feel a cold sweat breaking out on her back; and, gritting her teeth, she realized that her vigilance had been loosened in earnest.

The boy before her, his demeanor was certainly almost the same as the one she knew.

However, that in itself was unusual.

He had broken into a mansion that was difficult to infiltrate, even late at night, and moreover, he had managed to breach her guard and was now standing beside her bed, all the while remaining unchanged from before.

Felt: "—. What happened to the others? If you messed with them…"

Black-haired Boy: "No mercy? Don't worry. I'm not a kid who would retaliate just because I've been beaten up. And if you were to make a fuss, Reinhard would immediately come running."

Felt: "…And if I were to raise my voice, the same thing you did to them would happen to me, wouldn't it?"

Black-haired Boy: "Yeah, you're not wrong about that. So please don't. If you don't, then…"

Felt: "If I don't?"

Black-haired Boy: "—I'll keep your family's secret private."

He bent down slightly and whispered in her ear.

This was not a bluff or a random remark: she knew this by intuition, without the need for evidence.

And, in this case, "Family" could only refer to one person in her life.

Felt: "What do you know about Old Man Rom?"

Black-haired Boy: "A lot. I know a lot. In fact, it's not just about Old Man Rom, but I know far more about you than you do yourself…Though, I kinda feel like a stalker saying it like that."

Standing in front of her, the boy shrugged slightly and touched his neck—rather, the crystal hanging from it, with a wry smile as if he were sharing a joke with a friend.

The bizarre atmosphere made it impossible for her to deny him in this instance.

Black-haired Boy: "If you want to know all the details, I can tell you, but your family is quite the enemy of the Kingdom. If they were to find out his identity, they'd one hundred percent have him arrested and executed. It's at the level that you, and all the members of your Camp, would all be implicated. I really don't want to be doing that, either."

Felt: "What the hell are you even talking about…?"

Black-haired Boy: "I'm going to suggest it from my own mouth. …I may have come across as a little bit of a douche."

The boy scratched his cheek and showed no significant reaction to her swearing. It was as if he was already fully prepared, and all he had to do was to make her nod her head.

Felt: "…"

Perhaps, the boy was not in a situation that granted him as much leeway as it appeared.

In fact, if Reinhard were to be called, whatever the situation was, it would be turned upside down in an instant. However, it did not seem like he was anticipating that

to happen.

If Reinhard were to be called, surely information would be circulated that would put her family in danger.

Black-haired Boy: “If you can understand that much without me having to explain everything, then you must be a good candidate for King.”

Felt: “—Geez, that just sounds like sarcasm to me.”

Whether he was aware of it or not, his words seemed like a natural provocation.

Then there was a long, long silence—

Felt: “—I understand. I’ll do as you say.”

Black-haired Boy: “Is that so. That’s good. Well then, I’ve prepared various escape routes for you.”

As she nodded, he suddenly looked relieved, and the boy pulled a bag from under the bed. When she looked at its contents, everything was meticulously provided, and the preparations were thorough.

It was really eerie how everything had been studied and planned to such an extent, sending shivers down her spine.

Black-haired Boy: “Go straight to Old Man Rom’s room. I’ve already talked to him too.”

She had no interest in learning how he had accomplished it, and she did not bother to inquire.

Accepting the offered bag, she glided past the boy while still in her sleepwear, enjoying the feeling of being in control of everything. Just before leaving the room, she halted her step—

Felt: “—Not trying to be a sore loser or anything, but that face of yours looks like the devil, bro.”

Having spoken those words, she swiftly exited the room without waiting to witness his reaction.

There seemed to be no possibility of victory. Now that he had become their adversary, not even Reinhard, or…

Feeling such bone-chilling fear, the blonde royal selection candidate withdrew from the Royal Selection.

CHAPTER IV:

ACCUMULATING LIFE IN ANOTHER WORLD FROM ZERO WITH A WITCH

1

A dream, I had a dream.

A dream that would not fade, a dream that kept repeating, a dream with no end, a dream that would not end—.

Over and over again, many many times over, repeating mistakes over and over, correcting them more and more.

One thousand times, spinning. Ten thousand times, connecting. One hundred million times, overcoming them.

And before knowing it, losing track of counting.

Agony, terror, turbidity, ruin, hatred, madness.

Exhausted, shaken, twisted, corrupted, contorted, decayed, anguished; a heart smashed to pieces.

And yet, there was still a place I wanted to reach.

And yet, there was still a wish I wanted to protect.

Even if no one knew about the endless tragedies that repeated over and over, I would not forget.

Even if no one notices, only I am unable to forget.

—Even if the people I want to save wept, I still want to save them.

So, even now, I do not regret having taken that hand.

If there is something I regret, it would be that I was hesitant and indecisive in taking her hand, and the frustration towards my own weak, fragile heart that I could not steel.

2

—Waking up from an empty dream, the first thing he always felt was a throbbing headache.

???: "…"

Drowsily waiting for the awakening of consciousness, shrouded in ambiguous mist. It would not take long. The groggy awakening took only a few seconds, and immediately his consciousness detached from that sleep, awakening.

???: "Ah, Aaah."

As his physical body began to wake, he confirmed his body's condition with a drawn-out voice.

At a glance, it appeared like he was still half-asleep, but this was an important part of his morning routine. By lying on his back, he let out his voice and gathered several pieces of information.

The tone of his voice, the establishment of his consciousness, the safety of his limbs, the organization of his memories, the progression of his day, and the existence of his life—.

Even so, it was easy to lose track of the correct flow of time. He could not neglect to verify it.

All of this, was evidence that Natsuki Subaru had reached the morning without making any grave mistakes.

Subaru: "*Fuwa*…"

Peeling off the blanket while yawning, he slowly lifted his body from the bed.

He roughly scratched his head and looked around the room he had become accustomed to seeing—it was luxuriously furnished, and standing out within the room's interior was a canopy bed.

But, where Subaru had woken up was not the luxurious bed, but rather a sofa placed further within the room. Curled up in a ball, hugging a blanket, was how he had spent the nights recently—no, rather, this had been the nighttime habit of Natsuki Subaru for what he felt was several years now.

Be that as it may, there was not any significant reason for him to not sleep in his bed.

It was simply the result of striving to find a comfortable sleeping environment, even if just a little bit. After various trials and errors, he had found that he felt more of a semblance of peaceful sleep by sleeping on the sofa rather than in the bed.

Perhaps it was the feeling of being on the edge that suited his nature, as if one careless toss and turn would send him to the floor.

Subaru: "…"

Putting those feelings aside, Subaru stood up from the sofa and headed to the washroom so he could get ready. He washed his face in the washroom that was adjacent to the bedroom, and observed his wet face in the mirror.

His face held a look of fatigue, and his eyes gave off a sense of despondency. His face looked frayed with dejection, and his overall demeanor appeared listless in every aspect, both mentally and physically.

In an attempt to tighten his sagging expression, he slapped his own cheeks as hard as he could with both hands.

A dry sound and numbing pain accompanied the tears that welled up; in order to wash them away, he poured cold water onto his face. Once again, he looked at his wet face in the mirror, and whilst carefully kneading his face, eyes, and cheeks, he spoke.

Subaru: "Smile… you gotta smile. If you can't, then… die."

Chanting this incantation, Subaru bent his mouth into a terrible, crooked smile.

He flashed his white teeth, his smile narrowing his eyes so the whites were no longer fully visible; this was the villainous side of himself that he had been acquainted with for around eighteen years. He could "camouflage" his eyes, his facial expression, and his countenance with no issues.

Subaru: "Oookay, okay. Keep it like this."

Commanding his reflection in the mirror to maintain the smile, Subaru quickly dried his face with a towel and changed his clothes.

While living at the Mansion, Subaru's appearance was not garbed in a servant's uniform or a tracksuit, but rather, he predominantly wore the formal attire of a fairly dignified noble. He loosened the collar of his formal jacket, rolled up his sleeves to his elbows, giving a relaxed appearance, but surprisingly, there were no complaints about his manner of dress.

Given his position, and likely due to his achievements as well, he was expected to dress accordingly in public.

Individuals with power and high status were allowed some degree of personal freedom. —Just like how Roswaal, despite his clownish appearance, silenced those around him with his status of Margrave.

Compared to that, Subaru's disheveled formal attire could be considered charming. Despite feeling a bit stuffy, he was still dressing in a manner befitting his position. After all, this position was something Subaru himself desired.

It would be absurd to refuse himself that which he desired.

Subaru: "Can't stay here any longer. It's about time."

Straight away after he had finished changing, Subaru looked up to the Magic Hour Crystal that had been furnished above the room's door and muttered.

It had a dark green hue, signifying that it was morning: it showed that his time for getting out of bed was soon. Apparently, it seemed like this morning he had spent just a little bit too much time practicing his smile in front of the mirror.

In a few more minutes, a meticulously punctual girl would visit his room right on schedule.

Before that, he needed to finish everything he had not done yet.

Subaru: "…"

Letting out a long exhale, Subaru opened his shirt's collar with a feeling of gloom.

There, resting against his skin, even during sleep, was the dull shimmer of a black Magic Crystal. Clenching it in his palm, Subaru directed his consciousness towards the mysteriously gleaming crystal.

The sensation of the cold, hard stone, gradually warming within Subaru's palm, even induced an illusion that it started pulsating like a living thing.

At some point, Subaru's own heartbeat even began to synchronize with that of the Magic Crystal in his grasp.

The Magic Crystal continued to beat faster and higher than one's pulse after an all-out sprint. Its pulsation and Subaru's heartbeat perfectly overlapped, equalling each other. —Right after that.

Subaru: "…"

By the time he had realized it, Subaru's consciousness was enveloped in white light, and he felt detached from his physical body.

The separation of his consciousness from his physical body was almost a sign of awakening from sleep. He had tasted the sensation of being pulled up from the depths of slumber twice within such a short span, and his vision began to clear.

A vast, green plain spread out as far as the eyes could see.

The sunlight, almost blinding, poured down, and a sea of grass swayed magnificently in the sweeping wind. A world where the blue of the sky and the green of the earth went on forevermore, up until they hazily intersected in the distant horizon.

It was a dreamlike world, lacking a sense of reality, possessing an unreal beauty which suited it.

Magnificently clear, eternally silent. —Right at the center of it all, there was a small hill that harmonized with the landscape.

Atop the gently sloping hill, a white table and parasol could be seen from afar, and Subaru slowly directed his feet toward them as if he was being led.

Under the parasol, upon the round table, were cups emitting steam; within the ceramic cups, amber-coloured liquid was warmly contained.

Two cups had been set upon the table, and white chairs had been placed on both ends of the table.

Subaru did not even confirm that the chair was prepared for him before sitting down on it. Though the tea had just recently finished brewing, he held the cup to his mouth, wetting his throat with its contents.

He had already lost count of how many cups he had already consumed, as the enigmatic tea continued to fill Subaru's insides. This strange tea, tasteless and odorless, however, was an absolute requirement for attending this tea party.

Hand-prepared by the host of the tea party, it was a cup offered as a form of greeting, a mandatory gesture.

And, as Subaru accepted this strange hospitality,

Subaru: "Ah, I drank it, I drank it, thanks for the drink. Alright, let's quickly move onto the main subject."

???: "—Of course, I suppose I did say that the first sip worked as a greeting. However, I do not believe that means that you should never give me a simple hello, mhm?"

After emptying his cup, Subaru tossed it aside as he spoke. Upon the cup breaking on top of the hill and his rude response, the person sitting across the table from him voiced their dissatisfaction.

In response to this complaint, Subaru showed no signs of remorse, and,

Subaru: "There's no real reason to greet you. After all, since you're peering inside and outside of my head day and night, does saying hello or goodbye to you have any meaning?"

Girl: "This and that are different matters, you know? First of all, saying that I watch you day and night: I would like for you not to speak of it in such a scandalous manner. Even supposing it is true, I am still a young maiden, as delicate as a flower. Would my reputation not become all the more worse if it became known that I am always staring into a boy's mind?"

Subaru: "A young maiden, as delicate as a flower; did the meaning of those words change without my knowledge?"

Girl: "How scathing of you. Well, maybe it is unreasonable at my age to insist on calling myself a maiden."

Saying so, the girl relaxed her mouth into a smile, quite contrasting the contents of her complaints.

She did not seem to express a particularly strong sense of wariness or fear to begin with; in fact, the girl was quite tolerant of Subaru's casual, impolite language. Even this exchange seemed to be a source of amusement for her.

Subaru could not help but feel an intensifying sense of guilt within his heart upon seeing that smile. He knew the true nature of this guilt. —However, it was ugly enough to make him want to avert his gaze from it.

Thus, Subaru stared back at the girl who evoked such emotions, and averted his gaze from his own guilt.

Subaru: "As expected, you're such an unpleasant woman."

Girl: "How glad it makes me to hear that. Rather than becoming someone desirable to you in all manner of ways, rather than becoming someone apathetic for whom you cannot see the value in assisting with your helping hand, for your kind, greedy self, becoming someone hateful who cruelly wounds your heart and drives in a wedge that cannot be removed, would please me more than anything."

Even in the face of sarcasm without preamble, her response remained composed.

She was aware that her reply might have provoked a displeased expression from Subaru, or even have made him feel bitter, but she continued in that manner, leading him on.

Girl: "Now then, any more of this, and my heart will become pained from buying into your antipathy and being so loathed. Let us try to achieve the purpose for this morning's rendezvous, shall we?"

Subaru: "You weren't hoping to be hated?"

Girl: “It was the bluff of a cute girl, you know? This is what I want you to see and accept.”

Subaru: “Cute…?”

Subaru tilted his head in sincere doubt deep in his heart; his companion merely gave an ironic smile.

And then—

Girl: “Truly, you are a man fearless to a fault. As the Witch of Greed, I like that about you. —Natsuki Subaru.”

This contractor was worthy of being called the Witch of Greed.

Echidna narrowed her eyes with a sweet smile, a smile of genuine joy.

3

Subaru: “Today’s the fourteenth of Kisdam… right?”

Echidna: “Yes, you are correct. Fortunately, nothing abnormal happened to you last night. You slept on that cramped sofa and endured the night’s discomfort, waking up without any issues… But still, you are quite cautious, are you not? No need to worry so much, you know?”

Subaru: “Such stupid words. Living without caution, and waking up dead in the morning, is also a possibility. Us humans, we never know when or where we’re gonna die.”

Clicking his tongue at the Witch’s optimism, Subaru recalled the desperate feeling of loss his Deaths left him.

Without warning, the tomorrow he trusted would come would suddenly be taken from him by a Return by Death to the past—time forgotten by the people with whom he spent his time; how much fear and disappointment had he tasted upon realizing he would need to rebuild those relationships?

Subaru: “The world could end at any moment, and it wouldn’t surprise me anymore. That’s…”

Echidna: “—I agree. I was thoughtless just now. My apologies for that.”

Subaru: “…What, aren’t you being terribly meek right now?”

Echidna: “I apologise if you thought of it as a bad thing. I believe it is about time you acknowledged that I am not that bad of a woman.”

Resting her cheek against her palm, with her elbow on the table, Echidna sent a seductive sidelong glance toward Subaru.

Her enchanting white hair, long eyelashes, and a beautiful face with a straight nose were like a supreme work of art that was rarely seen, and many painters would break their brushes at such unreproducible beauty.

Sometimes jokingly, she boasted that she had received marriage proposals from royalty in the past; perhaps, this might not have been a lie.

However—

Subaru: “Hmmmm…”

Echidna: “—? What is it? Staring at my face in such a way… is there something on it?”

Subaru: “Aaah, just hair, and ears, and a mouth, and a nose, and eyes…”

Echidna: “…Hm, I wonder why? Even though you say something completely obvious, I feel insulted.”

When she showed such a vexed emotion, the solemn atmosphere of the Witch instantly dissipated.

What remained was the face of a remarkably youthful girl, contrasting with her actual age, despite her exterior matching the age one would expect. She would appear far more attractive to boys his age than a serene beauty, akin to a painting.

Of course, Subaru’s aesthetic sense had already determined the pinnacle of beauty, so discovering Echidna’s new charms would be just like adding another entry to an encyclopedia.

Echidna: “Did I receive a worse impression than I had thought just now!?”

Subaru: “I didn’t even say anything. That’s a false accusation.”

Echidna: “The way you put it, you might have been thinking something quite harsh, even if you did not mutter it aloud. Hiding things from me will not work. We are not that distant.”

Subaru: “I didn’t say anything because I didn’t want to intentionally sour our relationship…”

Echidna: “See! I knew you were thinking something terrible after all!”

Reacting as if she had taken an oni’s head, she made a fuss about Subaru’s inner thoughts.

Subaru knew from experience that either telling the truth or hiding it would only cause a fuss, so he covered his ears and lowered his head, waiting for the storm to pass.

Echidna: “Generally, your attitude as of late is becoming quite unbearable. You have been treating me, the Witch of Greed, with much disdain. I do not expect admiration or awe from you, but there must be a more appropriate way for you to treat me.”

Subaru: “An appropriate way of treating you, like what?”

Echidna: “More like treating a noble with respect, or treating a beautiful woman with hospitality.”

Gently placing her hand on her chest, Echidna threw out a troublesome request at him.

It had become a regular occurance, this time of Echidna seeking attention.

This was not to say that Subaru’s mental state was fluctuating due to experiencing successive Returns by Death, but rather that Echidna was extremely troublesome in this situation.

Also, he did not want to deal with her after having just woken up.

Echidna: “Your casualness is quite refreshing and pleasant for me. But, sometimes, I would not mind having a moment that reminds you of who I am, you know?”

Subaru: “A moment that reminds me of who you are… does that mean making someone puke upon meeting them for the first time?”

Echidna: “When you cut it down to just that, I feel that my nature is greatly misunderstood!”

Saying this and that, Subaru frowned at Echidna’s attention-seeking behavior.

In the past, he had tried to deal with her in a straightforward manner, but the more he did so, the more she took advantage of him, leading him to avoid taking her seriously ever since.

Therefore, Subaru quickly shifted the conversation off topic with an “Anyway”.

Subaru: “If you’re just gonna idly chatter, I’m out.”

Echidna: “Hmm… that is not exactly a heartwarming conversation. In the first place, you do not seem to be in great shape this morning. So, it would not hurt to rest here a bit longer.”

Subaru: “…Certainly, there are times when staying here brings relief.”

As he rose from his chair while cracking his neck, Echidna’s eyes lit up as she responded to Subaru with a “Right?” But there was more to Subaru’s words.

Indeed, during this tea party, Subaru’s consciousness was isolated from the outside world, allowing him to stay here longer in spirit alone. There had been times when this mental refuge had brought him solace.

Subaru: “In situations like that, I won’t hesitate to indulge you. But, not now.”

Echidna: “Are you worried of becoming weak if you rely on others? That is a stoic way of thinking, but does it really make sense? After all, I am your only accomplice… I’m someone with whom you can share your pain and sorrow.”

Subaru: “—. I’m grateful to you.”

In fact, without Echidna’s presence, the current Subaru would not exist.

By extension, that also meant that the peace that Subaru’s loved ones enjoyed today also would not be possible.

Echidna’s affirmation, support, and advice had all helped Subaru to overcome the numerous obstacles that had stood in his way. He had to admit that her presence had been empowering.

However—

Subaru: “However, I don’t intend to entrust my pain and sorrow to anyone. This is mine and mine alone, and I’m going to get over it on my own, which is why you and I made this Contract. Isn’t that right?”

Echidna: “…That is the one aspect you will not bend on. How lonely that makes me.”

With her eyes downcast, framed by long lashes, Echidna muttered with a sense of loneliness. As it was, she brought the cup to her mouth, a sign that she had let go of her intention to continue this conversation.

After witnessing this, Subaru turned his back on her and looked down the hill. Below the gentle slope, in the middle of the green meadow, an unnatural structure—a door, appeared.

This corridor was the only link between this Castle of Dreams and reality.

Subaru: "Earlier, you didn't deny the idea of peeping on me constantly, did you?"

Echidna: "…I thought I had prefaced that with "hypothetically"?"

Subaru: "With my language skills, that sounds like how a conniving mastermind would speak."

Echidna: "…"

At this hounding from Subaru, who had turned away earlier, Echidna let out a small sigh. Then she put her mouth on the cup once more. It was a sign that she had let go of her intention to continue this conversation—

Subaru: "From now on, I'm removing the Magic Crystal when I go to the toilet or wash myself."

Echidna: "Aahh"

Replying with "What's with that aahh?", Subaru clicked his tongue and finally left the tea party.

Standing in front of the door at the bottom of the hill, Subaru put his hand on the doorknob and casually turned around.

There, on top of the hill, Echidna's hair fluttered in the wind as she absentmindedly watched Subaru's back. Noticing his gaze, Echidna gave a small wave of her hand.

For a moment, Subaru hesitated whether to wave back or not, and then, with only a sigh, he pushed open the door.

—And, straight after, his consciousness that had been captured by the dream world was released, returning back to reality.

Subaru: "…"

When his consciousness came back to reality, Subaru was still standing in his own room, holding the Magic Crystal.

He let out a long breath and raised his gaze; the color of the Magic Hour Crystal had not yet changed. The time he had spent in the world of dreams was only a few seconds in real time. It could be said to be a Room of Spirit and Time.

Subaru: "Still, I'll never get used to it…"

It had become part of his morning routine to be invited to that world of dreams, and to participate in Echidna's tea party.

By doing so, it helped Subaru grasp the current situation, and it had become a habit to ensure that there was no discrepancy between his perception and what was true; however, he still struggled with the time lag when he returned from the tea party to reality.

Echidna suggested he could stay longer without any worries, but that seemed to come with its own set of problems.

Spending long periods in that spiritual world, only to suddenly realize that his soul had aged by hundreds of years, would be a truly historical mysterious turn of events.

???: "—The aging of your soul, and your links with the Witch, shall one day become poison that will definitely consume you. Please do not forget that. Reflection."

Subaru: "…"

Suddenly, Subaru's thoughts suddenly echoed with a man's last words and testament.

The poor enemy, who was completely seen through by the machinations of a Subaru who accumulated Return by Deaths, had all of his countermeasures prevented, had his escape route completely blocked, had lost his allies, and was left alone and helpless.

In the end, Natsuki Subaru's battle had become ultimately one-sided.

His foe's defeat was no exception. His rebellious spirit was completely conquered, and the battle was settled without causing any damage to the surroundings and without any bloodshed other than that of the enemy.

Those words that he heard were the final words of a man spoken in such a situation, with Death looming before him.

Someday, Subaru would regret his own way of being. If such a time were to come, would that man be waiting for Subaru in the depths of hell?

Subaru: "But, it's unfortunate. After I die, where my soul goes is predestined."

Even if all of his bitter foes were waiting for Subaru in hell, Subaru's soul would never arrive there.

They would be waiting there, all alone, forever, continuing to be consumed by Subaru, even after death.

But, he would like them to tolerate that much. Subaru, also, did not expect that the afterlife would be easy.

Subaru: "That's what they call a Contract with a Witch."

???: "…Um, did I ever say something about taking your soul?"

As Subaru muttered deeply to himself, a different sort of hallucination echoed in his mind, distinct from the voice of the deceased man.

It sounded very similar to the voice of the Witch with whom he had just parted ways.

Echidna: "No, this is not a hallucination. It really is me."

Subaru: "I know that. Shut up."

Subaru silently refuted the voice of the Witch that seemed to be whispering in his ear.

The source of the voice was the Magic Crystal that Subaru had placed around his neck again. He flicked it with his finger in annoyance and snorted at the voice, which he could hear without having to go back to the dream world.

The reason as to why so few words were exchanged as their parting was quite apparent.

Echidna: "It is not necessary for you to linger, as we can always talk anytime."

Subaru: "Don't just randomly start talking to me when you don't have business with me, just because you can."

Echidna: "It is not uncommon for a Spiritual Arts User and their contracted Spirit to communicate telepathically. And, how should I put it, I do not believe anyone would pay much attention, even if your monologues increased at this point."

Having had a sore spot poked, Subaru furrowed his brows with displeasure.

As soon as Echidna felt Subaru's discomfort, she exclaimed "Oops", and continued,

Echidna: "I will comply with your request here. Please, do not hesitate to call upon me if you need me, contractor-dono."

Leaving behind those theatrical words, communication with the telepathic Echidna ceased.

Although the physical distance between them had not changed, it was difficult for Subaru to relax as he was aware of her presence peering through the Magic Crystal.

And so, as the morning routine of being toyed with by the Witch came to an end—

???: "—Subaru-sama, are you awake?"

There was a knock on the door from outside, which informed him of his usual wake-up time.

Subaru cleared his throat slightly as he heard the gentle voice which had called to him. Then, clapping his hands to his face, and using the mirror to once again reshape his face into a smile, he gave a very unspirited reply of "Come innn".

???: "Good morning, Subaru-sama. Today is once again a splendid morning, you know."

Hearing that reply and entering the room was a smiling girl in a maid's uniform—Subaru's maid, Petra Leyte.

When he had first met her, she was still a young bud who had yet to flower; but now, she was entering a season of growth, and was in the process of blooming beautifully. Her height, arms, and legs had grown compared to before, and she was becoming increasingly well-suited to her pretty maid dress, too.

Her behavior and mannerisms, as well, were not lost against her adorable outfit. From the start, she was a girl who was well-taught and quick to learn. And now, as a maid, Petra had reached top-notch levels.

A fourteen-year-old flower—seeing the smile of the all grown-up Petra, Subaru replied with a smile.

Subaru: "Good mornin', Petra. I agree with you… it's indeed a splendid morning. I'm pretty happy that I was able to see Petra's cute face again this morning."

Petra: "Subaru-sama's still saying such things… Ah, but there are clouds hanging over the sky beyond the forest, and it seems that the weather may get worse this afternoon. I have plans to go shopping this afternoon, so I hope it'll stay sunnyyy."

Inclining her head in response to Subaru's greeting, Petra turned her eyes towards the window and muttered that out. In those words, there was a faint trace of her childish immaturity, and Subaru gave a small chuckle.

Petra: "Ah! No, Subaru-sama, why are you laughing?"

Subaru: "No, no, it's that just now, you broke out of your beautiful maid shell for a moment. How very Petra-like."

Petra: "Jeez, please stop treating me like a kid that way. I'm totally grown up. I've been a maid already for two years… because of that, I've become an adult!"

Shaking her auburn hair, Petra's cheeks blushed and her lips pouted in embarrassment. Before the figure of his cute little sister, Subaru smiled and stroked the girl's head.

Petra's eyes narrowed happily at that touch, and she let out a reluctant sigh.

Petra: "So, what will you be doing this morning? It's still too early for breakfast, but…"

Subaru: "Ahh, for the time being, I'll just finish my usual routine, and then if it goes well, we can have breakfast with everyone. If it doesn't go well… then, the usual."

Petra: "…Right."

Casting her eyes down slightly at Subaru's reply, Petra made quite a serious face. Not able to bear seeing such a sweet girl make such a face, Subaru scratched his head,

Subaru: "Anyhow, thank you for today as well. Especially for coming to wake me up."

Petra: "…"

Subaru: "Petra?"

Petra: "Subaru-sama, you really are careless."

Saying that to Subaru, who awkwardly tried to change the topic, Petra gave an exasperated sigh. And then, the girl shook her head, putting on a smile like a bloomed flower,

Petra: "No, even this is my job. Besides, it's very easy to handle because Subaru-sama never really sleeps in… It would be fine, even if you were a little less disciplined, but…"

Subaru: "Huh?"

Petra: "It's nothing. Well then, I'll see you later. Pardon me."

Every morning, after acting as Subaru's alarm clock, Petra would hold her skirt politely in a curtsy. And then, after seeing off Subaru, she would leave the room.

The door would close, and Subaru would nod his head in satisfaction at Petra's growth.

Subaru: "Petra has become so splendid. As a big brother, I'm proud."

Echidna: "But from her perspective, she does not seem to think of you as an elder brother."

Subaru: "…I tell you to keep silent except for when I need you, and then this happens. The great Witch sure is quick to break her promises."

As she responded to his soliloquy, Subaru was astonished by the Witch's lack of patience and inability to tolerate silence. But, letting out a sigh of resignation, looking towards the door through which Petra had disappeared,

Subaru: "I'm that girl's big brother, you know? So, that makes Petra my cute little sister. That's why I will make that girl happy. —That much I will absolutely do."

Echidna: "You shall absolutely make her happy, you say…? Contrary to what you might think, that may be a dreadful statement."

Hearing Subaru's firm tone, Echidna said this without poking any fun at him.

Ignoring the words of the Witch, Subaru stretched a little before leaving the room.

The corridors of the mansion were quite chilly with the air of the early morning; shivering, Subaru shrugged off the cold and set out.

—His daily "routine" was about to start.

4

Since a few months ago, mornings in the Roswaal mansion would begin with an intense "Death Match".

Though, calling it a "Death Match" might have been quite surprising for those involved.

Still, for Subaru, who would witness it from the sidelines, the exchanges were violent enough to be called a "Death Match".

In fact, one of the two who clashed together must have challenged with the intent to kill.

But unfortunately, the opposing party evaded that ferocious fighting spirit with ease. The disparity of power between the two of them was completely evident in the eyes of anyone who cared to look.

Of course, there was no doubt that they would keep up this dangerous routine every morning due to this reason.

???: "RHHHHHAAAAARRRGH!!"

There was a fierce howl of rage, accompanied by an explosive kick that blew away the lawn on the courtyard.

Digging their foot in deeply, with that tempestuous propulsion the golden silhouette charged forward, his beastly claws driving straight toward the figure of their opponent.

It was a blow that could rend thick steel plates, one which could turn a human body into minced meat—the claws of the beast delivered a myriad of violent attacks, assailing its prey in an attempt to forbid it from escaping.

However—

???: "I apologize, but the gap is too great."

???: "GHHA—!?"

The other silhouette easily avoided the downpour of fatal attacks coming from the claws of the beast. And immediately after, their long legs sprung up, and the body of the

beast was pierced from below.

The beast raised a cry in anguish at receiving that blow, and the body of the one who had set the trap arced upwards—

???: “GHHAGHK—!?”

—Or rather, that was what should have happened, but that was not what had transpired.

The body that had been launched skywards was intercepted by the opponent’s heel directly from above, sending them crashing down into the ground. The impact produced a circular crater upon the lawn’s surface, leaving the beast perfectly silent, sprawled out unmoving upon the ground.

They desperately tried to move their limbs, but the beast’s fighting spirit was extinguished.

???: “Do you wish to continue?”

???: “—Aurgh”

The victor asked them whether they wanted to proceed as the loser let out a groan.

There was neither sarcasm nor cynicism when asking that; they were words spoken only towards the other’s fighting spirit. That was why those words deeply wounded the loser’s pride.

Thus—

???: “You probably don’t even realize it, but words like that are demeaning, you know. Stop with the damn Samurai’s pity.”

Entering the scene in which the outcome had already been decided, Subaru interjected, scratching his head.

Hearing those words, the young man who had been overlooking his sprawled-out opponent turned to look back at him. The young man with hair red as a flame raised his hand towards Subaru, saying “Hello”.

???: “Good morning, Subaru. You’re up early this morning, no?”

Subaru: “Not as early as the two of you. Even so, don’t you get bored or fed up with having to do this everyday… you don’t have to always act so upright, Reinhard.”

Reinhard: “There’s nothing wrong with his ambition to become stronger. Besides, it’s also true that he’s strengthening his abilities day by day. Before long, won’t there come a time where he will have a good match with me?”

Subaru: “Is that so? …I’m having a bit of a hard time picturing that.”

So smiled the red-haired youth—Reinhard van Astrea.

Subaru tilted his head at the evaluation of this generation’s Sword Saint, the strongest man on earth. He meant not to belittle his morning training partner, but Reinhard’s assessment seemed overly modest.

Subaru had tried countless attempts, but he could not come up with a strategy to defeat Reinhard. No matter how many times he had Returned by Death, he could not envision a victory.

Perhaps the same applied for the person lying sprawled out on the ground.

???: "—Tch"

Having suffered significant damage, frowning was none other than Garfiel.

Wheezing in anguish, he was still unable to stand up but the fighting spirit dwelling in his emerald eyes had not wavered at all. However, the world was not so kind that a competitive spirit could have any effect on one's prowess.

Even if Garfiel's frustration had reached its limit, he would not be able to break Reinhard's cool demeanor.

That, too, was the observation of Natsuki Subaru, who had witnessed a wide variety of situations.

Subaru: "Your determination to take on the challenge is admirable. Hey, can you get up, Garfiel?"

Garfiel: "…Don't be touchin' me so casually. I don't need yer fuckin' hand ta stand up, ya know."

Shaking off Subaru's outstretched hand, Garfiel bared his fangs in disgust at him.

It was obvious that he was putting on a tough act, so Subaru quietly retracted his hand. Even if it was bravado, he would rather let his fangs break before he let that fact be exposed.

Ever since kneeling before the Great Rabbit, Garfiel refused to yield.

He continued to challenge Reinhard, despite knowing there was no chance of winning, all in an attempt to forget that defeat.

Echidna: "Such an adorable act of resistance."

Subaru: "Quit it. I won't let you make fun of Garfiel."

Echidna: "Huh!? I was not making fun of him at all…"

Subaru could only sigh at the surprised reaction of the wide-eyed wicked spirit within his head.

Then, he looked at the now-standing Garfiel, who had somehow managed to get up,

Subaru: "If you can stand up on your own, go take a bath before breakfast. Get rid of that sweat and mud, or Ram will come to dislike you."

Garfiel: "…Shut yer trap. I already know that without ya needin' ta tell me."

Subaru: "And…"

Garfiel, his knees trembling, wrinkled his nose as Subaru added a comment.

His enmity towards the person who had crushed his dignity was laid bare. Facing that gaze, Subaru closed one eye,

Subaru: "You should visit Ryuzu-san's place once in a while. Both Ryuzu-san and Shima-san were worried about you."

Garfiel: "—Tsk"

Subaru: "You can be stubborn all you want. But, if you let people worry about you because of it…"

Garfiel: "Shut the fuck up!"

And, at those sermon-like words, Subaru's collar was roughly seized by Garfiel.

Garfiel then attempted to hoist Subaru up.

However—

Reinhard: “Garfiel, do not go any further. Subaru is going to get hurt.”

In an instant, Reinhard intervened, restraining Garfiel’s arm.

Reinhard, who had somehow managed to get his hand off of Subaru’s chest, looked at Garfiel sternly and lowered his eyebrows.

Reinhard: “If that were to happen, Ram-san would be terribly angry with you.”

Garfiel: “If y’all’re thinkin’ my amazin’ self’d back down just ‘cause I get told to, you’re dead wrong.”

Subaru: “*Cough*, we can’t help that it’s the most effective method. *Ah, ugh.*”

Having both Subaru and Reinhard consecutively refer to Ram, Garfiel clenched his teeth in annoyance. Chuckling at the situation, Subaru briefly placed a hand to his throat, which was in pain for a moment, and lightly coughed to adjust his tone.

Subaru: “Phew… even though the bit about Ram getting angry is a joke, if people get hurt, then morning practice might have to be banned. If that happens, it won’t be good for you, either.”

Garfiel: “Grr…”

Reinhard: “Garfiel, I will always be here with you. I know you swore a vow to not see your family until you are satisfied with yourself, but…”

Staring at Garfiel, who was gnashing his teeth, Reinhard quietly shook his head.

Within those blue eyes that captured the azure sky, there was a hint of loneliness, as he said,

Reinhard: “But, you should meet with your cherished ones, and exchange words with them while you can still see them. If you regret it after they are gone, there’s no getting that back.”

Garfiel: “…”

The pupils of Garfiel’s emerald eyes narrowed as he listened to Reinhard’s heartfelt words.

And then—

Garfiel: “Next time, I’m gonna fuckin’ beat ya.”

With that, he shook off Reinhard’s grip on his arm and turned away.

As he walked away in a disgruntled manner, Reinhard called out “I will be looking forward to it”, a sincere cheer devoid of sarcasm.

Subaru: “But, the lack of sarcasm actually makes it sound kind of sarcastic.”

Reinhard: “I wonder about that. Do you think Garfiel was offended again?”

Subaru: “Nah, as far as he’s concerned, he’s got a lot more <u>hate</u> for me than for you, so I don’t think you need to worry about that at all.”

As they watched Garfiel depart from the courtyard, Subaru shrugged his shoulders. In response, Reinhard adjusted his collar with one hand and chuckled.

The slight disarrangement of his collar was the only trace of their morning training that Garfiel had managed to leave behind.

Subaru: "…After destroying the courtyard like this, I can understand why he's frustrated."

Reinhard: "Still, I think it's going to take a while. I can't help but feel bad about it too. After all—"

At that point, Reinhard paused, his gaze turning to the marks Garfiel had left on the lawn.

Reinhard: "He's avoiding visiting his grandmother, who lives apart from him, until he can defeat me."

Subaru: "I understand the logic, but he messed up his goal setting… his own lack of strength seems to have hit him pretty hard. It's understandable that he is stubborn. Just…"

Reinhard: "Just?"

Subaru: "I think you are a part of the reason for that stubbornness."

When Subaru firmly pointed a finger at him, Reinhard nodded his head in agreement.

There was something to recall here. It was also an event that created an insurmountable rift between Reinhard and Garfiel.

To put it simply, it was when Reinhard found out about Garfiel's vow.

Subaru: "That was why you went easy on him, to help him achieve his goal."

Reinhard: "It was a mistake, and I deeply regret it too. I should have handled it better."

Subaru: "As long as you're thinking like that, no matter how hard you try, it won't work."

While Reinhard regretted the method he had used, it also became a significant point of reflection for Subaru.

The rift that was created between Reinhard and Garfiel was one of Subaru's failures, a mistake that he could not redo—the incident that happened just before Subaru's Return by Death checkpoint, an irreparable mistake.

Echidna: "It was a trivial matter, so it did not hinder us later on."

Subaru: "Because of that, Ryuzu-san and the others were left feeling lonely."

Knowing that Reinhard had been holding back, Garfiel's stubbornness only intensified.

As a result, the intensity of the morning practice, and the ferocity of the young tiger, grew stronger with each passing day.

Subaru: "In this case, it's not about who's at fault."

Reinhard: "Just now, I thought you clearly said it was my fault."

Subaru: "It's a figure of speech! If we start pointing fingers, that stubborn Garfiel would be the one most at fault for sure."

However, not being able to solve Garfiel's stubbornness was also a sign of Subaru and the others' powerlessness.

It was a painful realization. Even if he accumulated Deaths and reached for the best outcome he could, he still would not be able to prevent every single slight scratch, and wounds might still fester.

Subaru: "So, please continue to accompany him for a while."

Reinhard: "I understand. Like I said earlier, his actual abilities are improving. It's good that he learns quickly. —The courtyard's destruction was worth it."

With a composed expression, Reinhard's concern was directed at the state of the ruined courtyard.

Garfiel had challenged him with a glaring intent to kill, but to Reinhard, this all might have been but child's play. The day that Garfiel's vow would be fulfilled remained distant.

In front of Subaru, Reinhard walked slowly across the destroyed lawn. And, as if by some unknown principle, wherever his footsteps touched, the ruined meadow began to recover.

Perhaps this was also the power of the countless Divine Protections he possessed; Subaru scratched his cheek at the casual miracle.

However, it was not just extraordinary power that defined Reinhard. This was what was so terrifying about him.

Echidna: "Given that, I would say that bringing him into your camp can be considered your finest play to this point. I, too, was surprised by your skill."

Reading Subaru's feelings, Echidna chimed in with her own comment. However, Subaru could not help but nod in agreement. Undoubtedly, it was one of Subaru's greatest achievements.

—The Sword Saint, Reinhard van Astrea.

Currently, he was a Knight affiliated with the Emilia Camp, backed by Roswaal.

Shortly after the Royal Selection had started, the Sword Saint had become Felt's Knight. He had been the greatest adversary he would have had to contend with, and because of his distinguished prominence in the Kingdom, he would have been their greatest threat, but—

Reinhard: "Subaru?"

Subaru: "Oh sorry, I was kinda spaced out. You always amaze me, no matter how many times I see you."

Reinhard: "It's just the Divine Protection of Vegetation. It's something that revitalizes the life force of plants and flowers."

Subaru: "Calling it "just" is already quite something. But, looking at it this way…"

Subaru cracked his neck while Reinhard nonchalantly explained the miracle of his Divine Protection. Then, after a deliberate pause, he uttered the words that followed.

Those were—

Subaru: "If Felt were to return, I can't help but feel heavy-hearted at the thought of opposing you again."

Reinhard: "…"

Subaru: “Reinhard?”

Subaru, as he spoke calmly and without any pretense, furrowed his brow. In response, Reinhard shook his head, “No”.

With a slight hint of melancholy upon his perfectly sculpted profile, the Sword Saint, the embodiment of miracles, lowered his gaze.

Reinhard: “I appreciate your concern, but I dare say I would be unable to go back to being Felt-Sama’s Knight. That lady has rejected me and judged me as unworthy. Were it not so, she wouldn’t have tossed me aside to vanish to whereabouts unknown.”

Reinhard faintly revealed a sense of regret and loneliness. It seemed that he wanted to say he had come to terms with it, but it was obvious that he had not yet sorted it out.

Witnessing Reinhard’s pained expression, Subaru cursed his own wickedness.

—Already, nearly a year had passed since Reinhard’s master, one of the Royal Selection Candidates, Felt, had disappeared from her Knight.

The girl, tough as a stray cat, had left the Astrea House, taking with her only the old man she regarded as family, and ran away from the Royal Selection. Thus, she cast aside the Sword Saint who had pledged himself to her.

Those were the rumors circulating among the public, and were almost identical to the truth.

In fact, Reinhard had heard nothing from Felt, before being abruptly driven from the Royal Selection. Having been abandoned by the master to whom he had sworn his loyalty, it was not difficult to imagine the sense of helplessness he must have felt.

Subaru had extended his arm out to this, and had dragged him over to this new camp.

With his conscience sullied, Reinhard had taken Subaru’s desperate plea, and offered his sword to Emilia as his new lord. And since, the Sword Saint had become the sword of the Emilia Camp, playing a key role in the Royal Selection.

Echidna: “He is the descendant of the Sword Saint who had sealed away the Witch of Envy. It is significant that he stated that he would support the candidate who is despised as a Half-Devil. It is enough to overturn her unfavorable reputation.”

As Echidna pointed out, Reinhard’s inclusion drastically altered the dynamics of the Royal Selection.

With the departure of the Felt Camp, and the weakening of the Crusch Camp, the position of the Emilia Camp was greatly strengthened, putting them on par with the Camps of Anastasia and Priscilla.

Truly, it was a situation shaped by Reinhard’s involvement.

Even if—

Echidna: “—Even if it was done by none other than your behest.”

Subaru: “…”

Echidna: “I guess it’s “Ignorance is bliss”, as they say in your world’s proverbs.”

Subaru ignored the teasing and probing words of Echidna that echoed in his mind.

Instead, he gave Reinhard a smile of concern, lifting the corners of his mouth slightly, and lightly patted the slumped shoulders of his friend. With just a glance at Reinhard's profile as he turned his gaze away, Subaru uttered, "Don't worry about it."

Subaru: "I can't just easily say that I understand how you feel. However, you've been a big help to me. Otherwise, I don't know how many times Garfiel would have beaten me up."

"That was a close call earlier, too," replied Reinhard with an open smile. Finally, the tension eased from his expression.

Reinhard: "No matter how you look at it, that seems like a groundless worry. Indeed, Garfiel's attitude towards you is harsh, Subaru, but… that is the flip side of him recognizing your strength. However, your strength lies apart from physical power. That's something Garfiel cannot openly express."

Subaru: "You're being way too generous with your words… And, I've done enough to Garfiel to deserve a grudge."

Subaru felt sorry for Reinhard, who did not know the whole story, but Garfiel had valid reasons to dislike Subaru. Even Subaru did not know if a day would come where the snow would thaw.

His recklessness in signing a Contract with Echidna and working to liberate the Sanctuary had only been possible by ruining and trampling upon the days Garfiel had accumulated.

From Garfiel's perspective, being left completely out of a crisis in his own homeland and finding out that even his trusted grandmother had cooperated behind his back —Subaru could only guess at how he felt, but any sympathy on his part would be nothing more than hypocrisy.

As a result, the Sanctuary was saved without any sacrifices.

But Garfiel, too, could not do anything either. That was the crux of the matter.

Without the persuasion of Ram, Frederica, and Ryuzu, Garfiel might not have even joined the Emilia Camp. If that had happened, the camp would have lost a crucial force until Reinhard joined, and that would have been a huge loss.

Subaru: "No…"

And, biting his molars at his own thoughts, Subaru forcefully pressed his fist against his forehead.

He was reflecting on how he had failed to grasp Garfiel's emotions and could not help but feel apologetic. But how did this take him to the position of seeing Garfiel as nothing more than a battle asset?

Did Garfiel despise Subaru because he could see through this thinking?

Subaru: "But, could that too be resolved if he continues to practice with Reinhard?"

The crux of Garfiel's resentment lay in his own lack of strength.

If that was the case, then by setting Reinhard as a clear goal, learning about the strength of the Sword Saint, and gradually getting closer, would things change little by

little? Would he be able to forgive Subaru someday?

Would the wounds that Subaru was unable to prevent in the Sanctuary eventually heal?

Subaru: "If that's what it takes to get him to open up to me, then it'll be worth it."

Reinhard: "Surely, one day he will understand your feelings, Subaru. There's no need to be impatient."

Reinhard shook his head, gesturing consolation at Subaru's half-hearted conclusion. And then, the red-haired Knight turned his eyes towards the mansion,

Reinhard: "I want you to leave Garfiel to me for just a little while longer… That's if you still have any expectations from me, the one who was not even able to acquire Felt-sama's trust."

Subaru: "Don't be so pitiful. If I can't trust in you, who can I trust?. Yeah, I've got expectations for you."

Reinhard: "Understood. Then, you too should do what is expected of you. —That is the duty of the One and Only Knight."

It was only in those parting words that Reinhard had shown some kind of emotion.

The One and Only Knight—that term was only permitted in master-servant relationships that were tied together by the strongest of bonds. Reinhard had not been able to become that for Felt.

He didn't wish for Subaru to turn out the same way; that was the feeling being expressed.

Reinhard: "Well then, I will see you later."

Without even revealing such sentimentality on his facial expression, Reinhard gave Subaru a clap on his shoulder and left the garden. Behind him, as we walked away, the landscaping, which was supposed to have been razed to the ground, was completely restored.

Standing on the grass, Subaru made sure that Reinhard had completely left, and let out a long sigh.

Considering the lie he had just told, feeling repugnance might have been more accurate than a sigh.

Subaru: "How dare I even…"

Echidna: "My, what a magnificent acting performance. Your skin grows thicker by the day."

Subaru: "…"

Once again, he heard the voice of the Witch who kept breaking her promise, but Subaru had nothing to say to her observation.

Taking his silence as permission to speak, Echidna transmitted her thought-waves from the Magic Crystal,

Echidna: "Hey, hey, no need to be so down. To begin with, were you not the one who brought up Reinhard in the first place? That you needed a sword to oppose the Witch Cult?"

Subaru: "I'm aware. I was the one who planned it, and the one who executed it."

Echidna: "Originally, that girl—Felt had no interest in the Royal Selection in the slightest. So, she jumped at the chance when she was offered an escape route with no consequences. Of course, you made a few threats about revealing the identity of that old giant man. But, it was only the difference between early or late."

Whether it was meant as consolation or not, Echidna's remarks carefully peeled away Subaru's pressure scabs.

Reinhard, who had encouraged him in vain, had nothing to do with the reason as to why Felt had abandoned him. All of it was the result of Natsuki Subaru's secret machinations.

If the truth were to be discovered, scorn and denunciation would be inevitable.

Echidna: "In order to save your beloved girlfriend, you needed strength to fight off the Witch Cult's malice. No one can be saved by charm alone. You made the correct judgment. It was a neccessary choice"

Subaru: "Shut up."

Echidna: "The damage to the Watergate City was kept to a minimum because of that choice. How could you have resisted the disaster that befell such a populated city without Reinhard?"

Echidna's words, accreting on top of each other, cut Subaru like a blade rather than comforting him.

The deceptions that were laid out to justify his actions were naught but piles of filth to Subaru. An ordeal he had to accept, swallow, and store as his own nourishment.

The Trial that he thought he had overcome at the tomb seemed to be continuing in the outside world.

—To save everything, strength was needed.

The memories of the future and the experiences he possessed were insufficient to cover the despair that existed in this world.

If he had been able to compromise, he might have been able to overcome his hardships more easily. However, Subaru could not be so strong or weak to tolerate self-sacrifice for the sake of sacrifice.

To accept giving up, to permit compromise, to turn a blind eye to sacrifices, there would be no point in that.

If he were to stop weighing his own life on the scales, the meaning of taking the Witch's hand would disappear.

Therefore, he had been working tirelessly to gather the necessary strength, to gather the necessary forces.

Echidna: "As a result, you have entrapped Reinhard van Astrea, and won him over to your side."

To accomplish this, it was necessary for Felt to withdraw from the Royal Selection —the trial and errors that had accreted for this reason made the struggle against Clind seem almost endearing.

How difficult must it have been for him, to deceive Reinhard under his watchful eyes?

It was more difficult than deceiving any other existence in this world.

Echidna: "But, you did it. In the end, not a single person was harmed."

Subaru: "…"

Echidna: "By now, she should be living peacefully together with her family in Kararagi. I am sure that this is the best thing for her as well. The fate of her blood is a harsh one for her."

This scenario imagined by Echidna, in fact, brought no solace to Subaru.

If there was only one thing that could save Subaru from his diabolical scheming, it was the indisputable fact that no one had been harmed.

Only that outcome could be salvation for Natsuki Subaru.

It did not matter how many times his heart would be wounded, so long as he could save their lives—.

Subaru: "Where there is life… there is a future. Where there is a future, there is hope. Where there is hope, there is possibility. Where there is possibility—"

Echidna: "—People can be saved. You are correct. You are not wrong. I can guarantee so."

Subaru: "I don't particularly need your guarantees, you know…"

Subaru spoke out his innermost thoughts to both cheer himself up, and to caution himself.

The Witch affirmed, understood, shared, and admired that.

While he responded aggressively to those words, it was a fact that he had been saved by the Witch's words.

—Life, was life.

If he was alive, he could start over. He had possibilities. It yielded hope.

Sacrifices were things that were different to Subaru's life. It was worth continuing to always use Return by Death all the time if it protected everyone except for Subaru's own life, which was no longer included in his calculations.

—Even if those whom I wish to save weep, I still wish to save them.

That was the salvation that Subaru had decided to receive by taking the Witch's hand.

5

Having received the Witch of Greed's cruel comfort, Subaru left the courtyard.

Witnessing the morning exercises of Reinhard and Garfiel had nothing to do with Subaru's daily routine; it was just a passing event he had witnessed.

Subaru's real daily routine was—

Subaru: "—Heya, Beatrice. Sorry to intrude."

Opening the door at the easternmost part of the mansion, Subaru did not need his sixth sense like before.

That was because this place would never move from where it was again.

Behind the heavy door, greeted by the scent of paper, Subaru closed one eye at the familiar sight. It was a library with a large number of bookshelves lined up and books crammed into the space.

Among the unchanged scenery, there was one thing that was distinctly different from before.

It was the absence of the librarian of the archives, who should have rushed him right as he entered. Sitting on a stepladder, a space where there should have been a young girl waiting with a disgruntled expression to welcome him; however, neither the girl he was waiting for, nor her words of welcome, were present.

Subaru: "…"

There, curled up in the corner of the room, was a little girl clutching her knees; a sense of loneliness emanated from her.

He should have grown accustomed to this sight, of her resting with her head on her lap, yet it still pained his heart to see her as she was now, compared to the girl he used to know.

Unchanged in her attire, unchanged in her form, only her way of being had completely shifted from before—Beatrice, there without even a hint of movement.

She slumbered not. That fact was evident from how her fingers hugged her knees with so much force that they were whitened.

The Beatrice who used to greet Subaru with a seemingly grumpy demeanor, yet proudly introducing herself as the librarian; her dignified posture, backed by pride and responsibility; she had lost every trace of her former self.

Narrowing his eyes at her appearance, Subaru briefly let an emotion pass through his chest before blinking it away. Then, he put on a cheerfully idiotic smile, and threw open the curtains of the library.

This place, once called the Forbidden Library, was an isolated space separated from reality.

However, as a result of Beatrice, the librarian, abandoning her role and relinquishing the concealment of the space via Door Crossing, it had manifested itself in reality, looking just like an ordinary room.

A breeze blew the curtains open, causing the light from outside to pour in from the window.

Nature that was previously absent in the former Forbidden Library, now boldly crossing the threshold.

Subaru: "Heyyy, Beako. Today's another splendid morning. There's a pleasant breeze blowing by. Isn't it about time you stopped hiding in this musty old room and went outside to play?"

Beatrice: "…"

Subaru: “If you don’t want to muddy your dress up by playing outside, then at the very least, let’s eat together with everyone. Come to the dining hall like before. It’s not too much to ask, right?”

Beatrice: “…”

With the window and curtains wide open, Subaru smiled warmly with the sunshine and breeze on his back.

However, despite his candid invitation, Beatrice remained silent with her face hidden. The girl, clutching her knees tightly, almost seemed like she was punishing herself in Subaru’s eyes.

Subaru: “Hey, Beako…”

Beatrice: “…Just shut the hell up, in fact.”

Subaru: “…”

Unable to bear the sight of her, Subaru tried to approach her, but Beatrice spoke out.

Her voice sank heavily, growing hoarse. But, after hearing her voice, Subaru felt happy. Because, recently, just hearing her voice was a rare occurrence.

So, even though her words were a solemn refusal, it made Subaru feel content.

Casting aside Subaru’s thoughts, Beatrice continued without raising her face.

Beatrice: “Betty is tired. She’s already given up, I suppose. Going against Mother’s instructions… breaking the Contract… and despite that, still being alive… why?”

Subaru: “Beatrice…”

Beatrice: “You, if only you had just abandoned me back then… why, why did you come to help me, in fact…? Who even asked you, you, who are not even That Person… hk!”

It was a resentment that would never disappear, a grudge that could never fade, a penitence that she could never forgive—.

In her four hundred years, Beatrice had bore those feelings alone, yet her heroic determination that had refused to relinquish such thoughts had been trampled upon, naturally bringing hatred.

Within the Forbidden Library, there was a Spirit who was prepared to abandon her mission; but, despite her resolve, she was spared.

Her eternal life had stripped hope from her, and all she had been given was time to live a life devoid of meaning.

Having relinquished the responsibility of managing the closed-off Forbidden Library, the long, long thread that had held Beatrice together finally snapped. and she had been left imprisoned in the death she had been prepared for. As a result, Beatrice was trapped in the Death she had prepared for.

She had given up her mission, thrown it away, and betrayed the mother who had believed in her.

The atonement for that was something she could no longer achieve herself. She had completely given up on that.

The weight of her strong sense of responsibility had become chains, binding the small Beatrice's soul.

Ever since the night she gave up her mission, she had spent endless hours crouched in a corner of the library, crying without end.

Even so—

Beatrice: "—hk! Go away! Let go, I suppose! Don't you touch Betty… tch!"

Unable to bear seeing her small figure in such a state, Subaru wrapped her body into a hug.

Shouting at him as he embraced her, Beatrice made no attempt to hide her disgust and rage, scoring Subaru's neck with her nails. Caught in her merciless attack, drops of blood oozed out of his wounds. But still, he would not let go.

He hugged her in an attempt to comfort her diminutive, shivering body.

But, perhaps it was actually Subaru who sought comfort in that act.

Beatrice: "Why, why did you come to see me, I suppose…! You're so, you're so…!"

Subaru: "No matter how many times you vent your anger at me, I'll be here. Even if the flames of regret don't seem like they're vanishing right now, if you keep pouring them out, maybe they'll vanish someday."

Beatrice: "They're not, supposed to vanish, in fact…! Betty is!"

Subaru: "I'm so glad that you're alive. So, I'll always look forward to the day where you'll stand before me with a pout once again. —That hope is there, because you are still alive."

Beatrice: "—hk"

After those gentle, sincere words were spoken, Beatrice's resistance subsided.

Without moving, Beatrice looked stunned, but then absently began to sob. It was a sign that she would no longer be able to continue this conversation.

—Once every two weeks, Subaru and Beatrice would exchange temper and stillness in such a way.

After releasing her from his embrace, Beatrice once again buried her forehead into her knees. And, after that, Subaru had nothing more to say to the girl who had retreated into her own shell.

Subaru's words still were unable to manage open the door to her Beatrice's heart.

Nevertheless, if he beat relentlessly against that door, maybe one day, they would open. —The mere possibility of this hope, was hope itself.

Subaru: "…Back then, I wonder if I should have lied and told her I was That Person."

Exiting the library and leaving Beatrice behind, whilst leaning his back to the door, Subaru recollected this.

Holding out hope that Subaru was indeed That Person, after the attack on the mansion, Beatrice had been prepared for the end of her long, long mission. However, both hope and resignation betrayed her.

For four hundred years, a girl eagerly longed for the arrival of That Person to take her away from the Forbidden Library. Should Subaru have deceived her, and lied about being That Person?

If he had done so, would her heart have been saved, and would she have relinquished the Forbidden Library with a smile on her face?

Subaru: "The book in that room…"

Echidna: "Beatrice has relinquished her role as librarian and has released the Forbidden Library. At that moment, all the books in the library turned blank. It was designed that way from the outset."

Subaru: "…You do some seriously ill-natured things."

Echidna: "It is simply a precautionary measure. If Beatrice were to be killed, I could not let the library be stolen."

Beatrice continued to sit in the library, which no longer possessed any value or reason to protect.

As if to irritate Subaru and his feelings for her, Echidna revealed the truth in a matter-of-fact manner. It was a precaution to prevent Beatrice from being killed—no, it was a precautionary measure to prevent knowledge from leaking out.

In the end, the feelings of Beatrice, who had been thinking of her mother for four hundred years, and the feelings that Echidna had induced, were vastly different.

Echidna: "Of course, the fact that the Forbidden Library is lost cannot be undone. Accepting the irretrievable loss of knowledge without inheritance is quite painful for me, but it cannot be helped. Though for you, compared to that knowledge, that Beatrice's life was saved is what matters most, is it not?"

Subaru: "—Hk! If you hadn't told her to wait for That Person…!"

Echidna: "Wait a second; no matter how you look at it, is that not sidestepping logic? I had my own reasons. Of course, responsibility for Beatrice's long solitude does fall upon my shoulders. But, my intent was certainly not one of forcing misfortune upon that child. I do hope you understand."

Having received Echidna's objections, Subaru, aware that he was taking his anger out on her, hesitated.

The Witch's words were correct. In the end, when Subaru blamed Echidna, he was just shifting the responsibility from what he himself could not do.

Subaru: "…In the end, That Person; who was it?"

Echidna: "Regretfully, I cannot let that slip from my mouth. Since the Forbidden Library has lost its role, discussing it would be meaningless. Even if you were to find out who it was, he would not know about it anymore."

Subaru: "He… which means, it's a man?"

Echidna: "—. Did my mouth slip? But, every way of finding him is gone now. In the first place, assuming you were to find him, what would you do? Would you introduce him to Beatrice? Or, do you intend to impose a sanction on him? In that case, what would be the charge? The person in question would certainly be unaware

of it; a crime that does not exist cannot be sanctioned. Moreover, it is not as if you have the leisure."

Irrefutable were Echidna's conversational tactics, leading Subaru to click his tongue.

As a matter of fact, everything spoken by the Witch was probably correct. He could not find any flaws. He could not judge them. Subaru did not have the time to do such a thing.

Echidna: "Beatrice truly did spend that time in pity. But, that is not to say that the future would remain so, and there is no indication for us to think thus. Incidentally, it is just as you said."

Subaru: "…"

Echidna: "Even if devastated by regret right now, there will come a day where that child will be freed. When that happens, someone will come to accept that child. Perhaps someone that is you, perhaps someone that is not. That is the possibility that living offers."

It was sophistry. It was merely a front of benevolence.

But, that doubtlessly was also hope.

It seemed like cajolery from Echidna, but if there was that possibility, then Subaru had no choice but to believe her words.

Thus Subaru, no matter how clear it was that the Witch with whom he was contracted was verbally toying with him, he could not deny her point. He could only cling to it, rely on it.

On her, as his only accomplice, keeping Subaru aware of his sins, allowing him not to forget was her presence.

Subaru: "Just like parallel lines."

Echidna: "Ah, like parallel lines indeed."

In the end, finishing their conversation thus, was Subaru and Echidna's manner of confronting their sins.

Entrusting hope to the future, believing in the paths to possibility, awaiting the arrival of the ideal day.

It mattered not how many chances he had, Subaru would always find himself back in this place.

Knowing that Beatrice had relinquished her mission, had been prepared to face Death, and had entrusted her last hope to Subaru, only to be betrayed and to break down in tears day after day, he still wanted her to live.

Thus, clinging onto hope, he kept walking forward through thick and thin, through thick and thin.

—That he will be saved. That he was saved.

Today as well, he made these words his motivation for the future; he prayed that hope would flourish.

???: “Oh myyy~, but if it isn’t Subaru-saaama~! On your way back from visiting Beatrice?”

Subaru: “…”

Suddenly, Subaru heard a voice from behind him as he walked through the corridor, causing him to reflexively stop in his tracks.

He instantaneously recognized the speaker from the tone and cadence of his voice. For that reason, he regretted stopping, but he could not ignore it as he had already stopped walking.

He turned around in displeasure, and directly behind Subaru stood the other figure, leisurely.

Subaru: “Roswaal, huh?”

Roswaal: “Mhhm, that’s me of course. Good morning. How was Beatrice today?”

Subaru: “…It’s been a while since she’s treated me so haughtily. Well, anticipate some progress from now on.”

Roswaal: “I see… Looks like you took quite the beeeating~, though?”

Roswaal narrowed his differently colored eyes as he received Subaru’s dispirited reply.

His gaze was fixed upon Subaru’s neck. There, were the painful scratches Beatrice had given him with her nails a short while ago.

Roswaal: “Unfortunately, I’ve never been skilled at treating injuries, and I won’t be able to heal those wounds. The only ones capable of using Healing Magic are… Beatrice, Garfiel, and Emilia-sama.”

Subaru: “The first two would be a bit difficult to ask. I could ask Emilia… well, I’ll think about it.”

Roswaal: “If you were to ask her, I am sure she’d definitely heal you right up. Or perhaps, could it be that to you, the ache of these wounds provide some sort of comfort?”

Subaru: “…”

In place of the reticent Subaru, each of Roswaal’s discursive words were as painfully sharp as a razor.

The last comment in particular hit him directly. Subaru narrowed his eyes, and so Roswaal shrugged his shoulders in a clown-like gesture, blatantly feigning ignorance.

The clownish makeup and exotic attire, Roswaal’s appearance and attitude had in no way changed—his way of interacting with Subaru, his respectful and admiring attitude, had also remained the same.

Roswaal respected Subaru, acknowledging him as his savior.

He understood that salvation could be brought about in any manner, and accepted it with understanding.

Roswaal: “No need to worry, Subaru-sama. If you make use of your time, I am sure you’ll find a solution; no matter what the method, you will dedicate yourself to finding the optimal way. If your desire is to save Beatrice’s heart, such a method will one day fall within your grasp. There’s no need at all to feel aaanxious~.”

Subaru: “You make it sound so easy. There’s no way it’ll be that convenient.”

Roswaal: “You’re too modest. —Besides, I don’t think that it’s easy, either. But, that mere fact doesn’t cloud all of your achievements to date, that’s all I was saying.”

Bowing reverently, Roswaal gave thorough praise for Subaru’s achievements.

As a matter of fact, only Echidna, who was contracted with Subaru, knew about his Authority of Return by Death. But, Roswaal had an understanding of his Authority to be similar to Redoing. Roswaal evaluated that fact and his achievements together.

As Echidna held no tangible power, it was no exaggeration to say that Roswaal valued and supported Subaru the most in the truest sense.

Roswaal: “At the Royal Capital, at my mansion, and once again at the Royal Capital. And then, at the Sanctuary, and the Watergate City. —You have made it this far without letting anything slip through your fingers. Indisputable are your achievements, feats you alone have accomplished. There will come a day when you will fulfill my long-cherished wish, and for that I offer my utmost support. Please make full use of it.”

Subaru: “You sure are optimistic… Don’t be so sure that I’ll dance on the palm of your hand.”

Roswaal: “But, you desire the blood of the Dragon. Without it, that girl—Rem will never awaken. Having reached that conclusion, you need Emilia-sama to become King. Isn’t that right?”

Roswaal gave him a low, searching expression, and Subaru in kind returned a sharp, cold look.

It was a relationship of mutual cooperation, established on choppy waters, in which both of them knew each other’s critical points.

Roswaal would accomplish his goal by utilizing Subaru’s Return by Death, all the while putting Subaru in situations whereby he must gradually achieve this.

And though Subaru knew of those intentions, for the sake of saving the still-slumbering Rem, he had no choice but to advance them.

Roswaal: “Oh, but it won’t be a bad deal. You do your thing, I’ll do mine, and in any case, we’ll both have our desires become reality. To that end, we’ll make use of each other. That’s all there is to it.”

Subaru: “…”

Roswaal: “My strength should prove useful. I’ve devoted nearly four hundred years anticipating this occasion. And for me, your power will be the same, isn’t that so?”

Subaru could give no objections to Roswaal’s conviction.

He had arrived at that answer when he had discovered Roswaal’s treachery all the way back at the Sanctuary.

Whether for the sake of the Royal Selection, or as a means of blocking against coming hindrances, being without Roswaal's presence was absolutely unallowable for Subaru and the camp.

Even if he was just planning on using Subaru to materialize his own wishes.

Subaru: "If you were honest about your true intentions and just told me what you wanted, maybe I would help you without being so stubborn."

Roswaal: "What a shame, I'm afraid that's impossible. You would never choose that path."

Whenever Subaru would try to approach him even in the slightest, Roswaal would immediately push him away.

This familiar exchange brought a wry smile to Subaru's lips, and Roswaal chuckled ostentatiously.

Roswaal: "Especially if you're not conscious of it yourself. You always push forward with your sole priority. Any obstructions, anything or anyone that could cause you to stumble; regardless of the circumstances, you will discard even their dearest wishes. You can do that. You have proven it. This all has already been decided, hence why you've become my trump card."

Subaru: "…"

Roswaal: "Isn't this wonderful? I'll take care of my side, you'll take care of yours, freely fulfilling our wishes. If it's impossible even like this, that merely indicates that the one with unfulfilled wishes lacked sufficient desire."

Subaru: "…Ah, is that so?"

Subaru already understood that Roswaal's crazed dedication was what was supporting him.

And, the root from which it came, his refusal to speak candidly about it was also thus.

With this in mind, Subaru ended the conversation with Roswaal, and finally started to walk away. With a posture that showed just how much Roswaal was detached from his heart, as Roswaal yet stood still,

Roswaal: "Ahhh, yes. Right about now, Ram should be in Rem's room. I'm letting you know, just in case."

Subaru: "…"

Unable to respond, Subaru rounded the corner and escaped from his gaze.

7

—The Contract with the Witch at the Sanctuary fundamentally changed Natsuki Subaru's way of existence.

It was a transformation of the world as Subaru perceived it, the world as he experienced it, and the world as he walked through it; he was destined to no longer live the same way he had before.

Naturally, it was inevitable that countless changes would come to Subaru both within the mansion, which was his base of activities, and outside of it, but her change was perhaps the one that had the greatest impact and caused the most discomfort among the changes he experienced.

After all—

???: "—Thank you very much for going out of your way to visit my unworthy sister, Natsuki Subaru-sama."

Saying this, the one who bowed deeply to Subaru as he entered the room was a pink-haired maid—Ram, whose character was the very picture of arrogance and insolence.

Subaru: "…"

After the events at the Sanctuary and the subsequent commendation ceremony, Ram's attitude had shifted drastically, and she no longer approached Subaru with the same familiarity as before.

This new attitude, however, made Subaru feel extremely suffocated.

Ram: "—? Is something the matter, Natsuki Subaru-sama?"

Subaru: "…No, it's just that no matter how much time passes, I'll never get used to your attitude."

Ram: "…Again, many apologies for my prior rudeness. Ram's ignorance and lack of awareness caused great inconveniences to Natsuki Subaru-sama. But, since Roswaal-sama and Emilia-sama have given orders to show Natsuki-sama the utmost respect, that will not be the case again. Kindly rest assured."

Without changing her expression, Ram replied to Subaru in a manner any dignified maid ought to.

There was no trace of familiarity or sense of closeness which could have been interpreted as friendliness in her behavior, as there had been once before. Between Subaru and Ram, an invisible wall had emerged before he knew it.

—No, if there was a wall, then there would have been a way to scale it. Rather, there was no way of surmounting it; more precisely, it was an invisible gap.

Ram held Roswaal in high esteem, and adored him. When Roswaal had changed the way he acted towards Subaru, the value of Subaru's presence also changed dramatically for Ram.

The result was this current attitude, where she regarded Subaru as someone she respected.

Averting his gaze away from *that* Ram, Subaru approached the middle of the room—the reason why he had come to this room, the blue-haired girl who slept on a bed.

Lying on her back, her figure remained unchanged for over two years—that girl, was Rem.

He had made a vow to awaken her, and yet, he still had not achieved the conviction needed to fulfill that vow. Time alone was mercilessly leaving this girl behind.

Subaru: "Have there been any changes with Rem?"

Ram: “There have been none. She still continues to sleep… With so many other problems to deal with, Ram has no words to apologize for the worry her foolish sister has been causing you.”

Subaru: “Don’t talk like that. Rem… thinking about Rem is absolutely not useless. Never say that again.”

Ram: “—Understood, sir.”

Ram responded curtly to Subaru’s firm order.

There was no dissatisfaction, nor complaint; no relief, nor gratitude.

In regards to her younger sister named Rem, Ram had no actual feelings or appreciation for her. Although she formally recognized that Rem was her sister, in the depths of her heart she probably had no room for Rem.

Her heart was completely centered on her loyalty to Roswaal.

This was heavily influenced by the actions of Subaru, who had made the choice to go along with Roswaal’s intentions, resulting in Ram’s cherished wish meeting its end.

Even if Rem were to awaken, would her heart once again have room for her little sister?

The older sister who was so adored, and the younger sister who was so doted upon: could these sisters ever return?

Subaru: “—Hk. Ram, I’m sorry, but I’d like to be alone with Rem.”

Ram: “…As you wish. Do call if you need anything.”

Grinding his teeth at the shuddering thought, Subaru felt terrified at being in the same room as Ram. Miraculously, before his trembling voice could escape, she removed her presence from the room.

Fortunately, Ram did not object to Subaru’s words, and instead bowed graciously and quietly headed for the door.

At the sound of her receding footsteps, Subaru let out a sigh of relief—

Ram: “—Ah, that’s right, Natsuki Subaru-sama.”

Subaru: “Wh-What is it? Did you forget to say something?”

Ram: “Yes. —Annerose-sama has sent a letter regarding Frederica’s condition.”

As Ram halted, Subaru was taken aback; her words that followed caused him to catch his breath.

The two names that were mentioned—Frederica and Annerose, neither of them were at the Roswaal mansion. Annerose, of course, was in her own mansion, and Frederica was accompanying her.

The official reason was to send her as a caretaker for Annerose, who had lost her steward. However, everyone, including Frederica herself, knew that it was in fact out of consideration for Frederica’s heart.

He had visited the Miload mansion several times, but Frederica’s stouthearted behaviour was painful to watch, and there was no prospect of her returning to be a maid at the Roswaal mansion.

Ram: “Apparently, she still is having difficulty concentrating. Annerose-sama is concerned as well, and in this circumstance, she is considering allowing her return to Ryuzu-sama.”

Subaru: “…I understand. I’ll discuss it with Emilia and Roswaal. What are your thoughts?”

Ram: “There is no need to be so forward with my opinion. By all means, do as you please.”

Politely bowing her head, she refused to give her thoughts when prompted. In the past, Ram would have offered her opinion even without Subaru asking for it. However, now she was well aware of her position.

Once again, the eerie sensation of dealing with someone who seemed like a completely different person surged within Subaru’s heart.

Considering Frederica, this was yet another terribly depressing event for Subaru.

While the elimination of Clind was inevitable, the fact that Frederica was present at the ceremony was another cruel twist of fate. Of course, Subaru, out of consideration for Frederica, had tried to keep her away from the venue and as he attempted to deal with Clind.

However, without Frederica’s presence, it was impossible to reduce the damage, apart from that done to Clind, to zero. Quite literally, Frederica was Clind’s Achilles’ heel.

Therefore, no choice remained but to utilize Frederica’s presence to strike at that weak point.

As a result, Frederica had suffered deep, emotional scars from which she had yet to recover.

Ram: “…”

Quiet, pale light-crimson eyes stared intently at the silent Subaru.

Under that piercing gaze, he felt as though he was being accused. In fact, being accused outright might have been much better.

He even wished for Ram to call him “Barusu” in her cold tone and for her to insult him again.

But, he could not ask that. Even if he were to command her to call him that, it would be meaningless.

Subaru: “…I’ll think about it carefully.”

Ram: “Yes, understood. Please, take care.”

Once again, Ram bowed to Subaru after relaying her message, and this time, she left the room. As the sound of the closing door echoed, Subaru’s shoulders slumped, and he let out a long sigh.

It had been suffocating. Honestly, so long as he kept his guard up, he felt suffocated no matter where he was, but it was especially stifling when he was with Ram.

Escaping that smothering feeling, Subaru turned his attention back to the bed. Finally, the only two left in the room were Subaru and Rem, who continued to sleep.

Subaru: "…Rem."

Rem: "…"

Lying on the bed, the girl, who simply breathed over and over again in a manner which could not be called mere sleep, replied not. The slight rise and fall of her chest, and the warmth of the blood in her body, were the only signs of life within Rem.

Visiting this place, making sure to take her hand, to check for a weak pulse; that was all that Subaru could do for Rem. It was the only comfort Subaru allowed himself.

Subaru: "…Echidna."

Echidna: "—For you to call out to me here, is truly a rarity."

As he sat by her bedside, gently holding Rem's hand, Echidna replied to Subaru's call.

The Witch, the one he knew all too well to speak without being called upon, silently waited for a response from Subaru, who was submerged in the lukewarm water of his emotions.

Gradually, the silence continued; it lasted for a dozen seconds, or perhaps a few minutes.

Subaru: "The way to wake Rem… it hasn't changed, has it?"

Echidna: "Oh, there are no new discoveries. The only way would be to reclaim her from the Sin Archbishop of Gluttony, the one who put her in this sleep… but, that is not realistic, considering the likelihood of encountering the Sin Archbishop of Gluttony. Even if you were to hypothetically use your beloved as bait—"

Subaru: "Echidna."

Echidna: "My apologies, that was only a joke. Anyway, the Sin Archbishop is in hiding, not showing themselves. If you could make contact with them, I am sure there would be numerous ways of making them talk utilizing your Authority."

Subaru: "That's right. Of course, that's right. If I can manage to find them, catch them, and force them to tell me how to reawaken Rem, I can challenge them tens of thousands of times. Even so…"

They were nowhere to be found. The Sin Archbishop of Gluttony, that despicable blasphemer, never revealed themselves.

Even during the unprecedented catastrophe that had struck the Watergate City of Pristella, the scene of the horrific terrorist attack perpetuated by the Witch Cult, Gluttony did not appear.

—Why, why, why, why, why: that question filled his mind.

Subaru: "No matter what I do, I can't find that damn Gluttony. That's why…"

Echidna: "—That is why, you have no choice but to obtain the Dragon's Blood."

Subaru's denied wish was met with a glimmer of hope offered by the Witch.

Subaru shifted his bloodshot eyes and stared at the Magic Crystal hanging at his chest. Although he was unable to see the Witch of Greed, she must have been able to see Subaru.

The image of a challenger marching along an infinite path, clinging to the slimmest of hopes.

Subaru: "—With the Dragon's Blood, I can wake up Rem."

Echidna: "I refer to the Divine Dragon. Using the omnipotent power contained in the blood of its heart, I believe you should be able to release the girl's soul from her sleep."

Echidna's words were naught but speculation. But, it was a convincing speculation.

Though she had spoken without making explicit statements, the words of the Witch resounded forcefully. Thus, for now, Subaru believed that this was the way to save Rem.

The Dragon's Blood was considered to be one of the treasures which the Divine Dragon Volcanica had bestowed unto the Kingdom of Lugunica.

It brought plentiful harvest to the lands, kept away every disease, and had the possibility of granting miracles.

It could only be used by people with the highest pedigrees of social status within the Kingdom.

In other words, it was those who—

Subaru: "If you ascend to the throne, you can get your hands on it."

Echidna: "Of course. —It is for that reason that you must make her, your beloved, King."

Subaru: "…"

Echidna: "Back your beloved, support her, and make her King whilst you save those whom you wish to save. And only when you obtain the Dragon's Blood, will you be able to save Rem."

The words of Echidna seeped into Subaru's mind like a poison.

In order to save Rem, Emilia needed to become King. Making Emilia King, and fulfilling Emilia's wishes, were among the goals that Subaru aimed to achieve.

It was of utmost importance. Supporting Emilia would result in saving Rem.

Make Emilia King, to save Rem.

In the end, Rem would be saved thanks to Subaru's desire to make Emilia King.

Therefore—

Echidna: "Therefore…"

Subaru: "Stop it, you dumbass… Don't try and shake my determination like that every time you can. Why are you trying to lower my opinion of Emilia like that?"

Echidna: "That was not my intention though?"

Subaru: "You're not very convincing. We've repeated this conversation many times, dozens of times, hundreds of times."

As if to brainwash him, the Witch would often pour poison into Subaru's mind.

To change Subaru's aims, she attempted to undermine his valuation of Emilia. But, that was a line that Subaru would not cross. If he were to make that mistake, Natsuki

Subaru would lose the qualification to trample upon his own corpses that he had sacrificed so far.

Subaru: "You shouldn't let your selfish feelings get in the way. No matter what you harbor against Emilia."

Echidna: "That is a misunderstanding. Well, no matter how much I say, your thoughts will never meet mine; we are like parallel lines."

Subaru: "We've had this conversation over and over again, and each time you say that we're like parallel lines."

In this partnership with Echidna, there were times like these where he could never let his guard down.

The Witch claimed to be Subaru's accomplice, and by lending Subaru her wisdom as a contribution, she planned to exploit not only Subaru's Return by Death, but also Subaru's very way of being.

Although, thanks to her always being naive in the end, he had managed to avoid those poisonous fangs.

Subaru: "I'll get my hands on the Dragon's Blood. By making Emilia King. —But, that's not something I'm only gonna do to save Rem. Making Emilia King will lead to saving Rem. My original intention remains the same. Make no mistakes there."

Echidna: "My, my. I would not mind it if you were to dance to my tune occasionally. If you never let down your guard even a bit, I will not be able to save face as a Witch, you know?"

Subaru: "Your execution is too naive. …Or rather, perhaps, you're too naive at the core. You're not cut out to be a complete villain. That's helped me so far."

Echidna: "I see. I will try to keep that in mind."

Echidna admitted her defeat with surprising readiness. Even if she attempted to use this as a lesson for next time, she probably would not be able to do so.

The reason for that, was because one's nature cannot be so easily changed. Because it is not something that can be changed.

Natsuki Subaru would always be Natsuki Subaru, no matter what befell him.

The Witch of Greed, Echidna, would only ever be the Witch of Greed, Echidna.

One has no choice but to live armed with that which cannot be changed.

Because, in life, one can only play with the cards they are dealt.

Subaru: "—Rem, wait for me. For sure, I'm gonna wake you up. That's why…"

—No matter how many times he would die.

His resolve was not exaggerated, and the stakes were not something to be surrendered lightly.

Regardless of how many times he threw it away, he would continue to spend his inextinguishable life. If that eventually led to her waking up, he would feel no regrets.

Just that much, just that much, just that would be good enough.

—After his visit to Beatrice's library and Rem's bedroom, he had reached the end of his daily routine.

Subaru gave the closed door of the room a light-hearted knock. Then, an immediate knock sounded in return from inside. It was not a reply, but a knock.

In response to that, Subaru gave another knock once again. And then, the other party immediately knocked back; not to be outdone, he knocked again. Not wanting to lose, the other knocked once more. Knock, knock, knock—.

???: "—Jeez, how long are you going to keep that up! It's making me reaaally~ anxious."

And, the one to lose their patience first was the one within the room.

The door opened from the inside, and the face of a beautiful girl with amethyst eyes and silver hair could be seen—she was the embodiment of supreme beauty that never ceased to captivate all things in this world.

Such was Emilia: even when she blushed with her cheeks puffed out, she gave off an impression of delicateness rather than of beauty; Subaru could not help but laugh.

Emilia: "Ah, what are you laughing for? Ugh, Subaru, you're such a twit."

Subaru: "Who even says *twit* these days. After all, it was Emilia-tan who started to return the knocks first. I just went with the flow."

Emilia: "So that's how you put it. Hmph, that's fine. If that's the case, I just won't let Subaru into my room."

Emilia tried to close the door, her face etched with annoyance from having heard Subaru speaking through his laughter. Seeing that, Subaru hastily put his hand in the gap of the doorway—

Subaru: "OWWW!"

Emilia: "Ah! Subaru, are you okay!?"

Emilia jumped at Subaru's over-exaggerated shriek of pain after having had his fingers pinched. Quickly rushing out of the room, she hurriedly grabbed Subaru's aching right hand, and,

Emilia: "*Nom.*"

Subaru: "Ehh, Emilia-tan!? Isn't that a little bold!?"

Emilia: "*Mmphphnn*, *mmhmhhmhpphhnomnomnomnomnom*."

Whatever he tried to say was muffled by Emilia's angered reaction and her sharp amethyst eyes.

Emilia's thin lips wrapped themselves around the reddened fingers of Subaru's right hand. In between her soft lips, he could feel Emilia's warm, pink tongue gently tracing the numbing pain which afflicted Subaru's fingers.

Tingling with that sensation, a sensual shiver traveled up Subaru's spine.

Emilia: "Mhm… that should do, I think. Subaru, that must've hurt… hey, why is your face bright red?"

Subaru: "I can't help my boyish reaction, given how confused I was by that unexpected development… uhh, well, I'm okay. Thank you very much. That should do it

for me."

Emilia: "—? I'm not sure if I understood that, so I'm going to use healing magic, okay?"

Emilia gave a bewildered face as Subaru bowed his head, holding up his fingers which had been licked. However, she immediately switched her attention, and began to heal Subaru's fingers with a light blue surge of magic.

The healing magic completely cured the pain that had been soothed by Emilia's tongue. All that remained for Subaru was how he would deal with his saliva-drenched fingers.

Subaru: "I'll wipe them on my clothes… wait no, that would be a waste. That being said, would it be too much to just openly lick them…!? But, if I let this opportunity escape…"

Emilia: "Ah, sorry. I got them covered in my spit. Yep, all squeaky clean now."

Subaru: "Dammit! It was a choice with a time limit—!?"

Not even noticing Subaru's astonishment, Emilia wiped his fingers with her handkerchief, looking pleased with herself. Then, suddenly, she glanced at Subaru's neck, and she blinked her eyes rapidly.

Still visible were the untreated scratch marks Beatrice had left. Emilia was quick to notice them, and gently touched the wounds with her white fingers.

Emilia: "Subaru, that looks painful. What happened here?"

Subaru: "Ah, aaaah, this? I just got my neck caught on something on the way here…"

Emilia: "Liar."

Subaru attempted to smooth over the situation, but he was interrupted; Emilia spoke only that one word.

With her round eyes wide open, she stroked Subaru's wounds with her finger over and over again, before eventually muttering a few words.

Emilia: "—It was Beatrice."

The moment she spoke thus, Emilia's voice became emotionless and cold.

In an instant, an enormous amount of pure white force surged from Emilia's body. It swept through the halls of the mansion in one fell swoop, and Subaru's skin was caressed by a great burning cold.

The air froze, the chill caused it to crackle, and Subaru raised his voice in a panic.

Subaru: "Emilia! Emilia, calm down! Everything is okay, everything is okay!"

Emilia: "…"

Subaru: "Emilia! Here, look at me!"

Emilia: "—Ah"

He forcibly extended his arms and hugged the girl's slender body as he called out to her.

Calling Emilia's name over and over again in her ear, Subaru, who was close enough that she could feel his breath, shouted as he saw himself reflected in those

amethyst eyes.

At the sound of his voice, Emilia's blurry eyes came into focus, and she let out a small whimper.

In an instant, the cold air that was spreading across the mansion's top floor vanished, and the overwhelming pressure that had been surrounding his body also dissipated, returning things back to as they were before.

Subaru: "Th-That was close. A little more of that, and Reinhard would have come rushing in…"

Emilia: "I… I… n-now… eh…?"

Subaru: "It's okay, it's okay. Emilia-tan is a good girl, a good girl, everything is okay."

Her eyes darting around, Emilia slumped down on the floor, and Subaru crouched down next to her. As she hugged her own body, unable to comprehend what had just transpired, Subaru gently stroked her back.

Gradually, Emilia's breathing regained its composure, and then, timidly looking at Subaru's face,

Emilia: "S-Sorry? I… was acting weird again…"

Subaru: "It's alright. Any troubles caused by Emilia-tan aren't troubles at all. That's the role I want to take on. Don't worry."

Emilia: "…Y-Yeah."

As Subaru spoke to her, Emilia nodded even as she continued to frown.

Subaru would not let go of her body until her heart truly settled down.

Emilia's unstable psyche—it was significantly impacted by the fact that she was unable to surmount the Trails in the Sanctuary

In the end, he would never know what she saw in the first Trial, the Trial which showed glimpses into one's own past.

Nevertheless, whatever memories she saw had broken Emilia's heart into pieces. And then, unable to overcome the Trials with her own strength, Subaru had completed them himself, and the opportunity was lost.

Therefore, Emilia's progress was probably still trapped within the tomb even now.

But, no matter how long she continued to reject, to mourn, time would continue to progress without cease. And neither the world, nor her surroundings, nor anyone would tolerate her stagnation.

For that reason, Subaru would continue to take Emilia by the hand, even when she halted to a stop.

Emilia: "Sorry, Subaru. I'm causing Subaru trouble again…"

Subaru: "It's okay, it's no pro, no problem at all. Rather, it makes me feel welcome."

Emilia: "…Hehe, aww, Subaru. Mhm, thank you. I'm okay, I've calmed down."

After a brief embrace, Emilia lifted her face from Subaru's chest. She stood up quickly, her warmth leaving his body, and Subaru stiffened his lips with a look of regret.

Subaru: “Dammit. I wanted to enjoy Emilia-tan’s softness just a little while longer.”

Emilia: “Huh, would that be for the best? If Subaru says so, I’ll do it.”

Subaru: “Nononono, it’s fine. This is a trick I use quite often to cope with dissatisfaction. Gorging yourself until you’re full is for cattle. I think rather than a pig in its sty, I’m more like a wolf that’s chasing after its prey.”

Emilia: “That might be true. I also think Subaru is closer to a dog than a pig.”

Subaru: “But, isn’t it a completely different story when it comes to dogs and pigs!?”

With this absurd exchange, Subaru was relieved to see that Emilia was once again smiling.

Luckily, it appeared that she had forgotten her anger upon seeing his wounds from just moments ago, which was a relief.

Echidna: “I cannot bear to watch this.”

Subaru: “Shut up.”

Emilia: “—Huh?”

Subaru: “Ah, I wasn’t saying that to Emilia-tan. Sorry, I was talking to myself.”

Subaru instinctively replied to those suddenly interjected thought waves, startling Emilia.

Through the thought waves coming across the Magic Crystal, the strong sense of disgust towards Emilia who stood before him was evident. Taking advantage of the fact that only Subaru could hear her scorn and mockery, the Witch’s abusive behavior was unbearable.

Emilia: “W-Would it be better for me to shut up? If that’s what Subaru wants, I will do my best to stay quiet…”

Subaru: “It’s not like that! It’s fine, so let’s talk a lot, okay? It’s okay if you talk to me.”

Emilia: “…Really?”

Emilia’s amethyst eyes began to timidly moisten with tears. When Subaru nodded in response, Emilia let out a sigh of relief, once again taking Subaru’s hand,

Emilia: “Well then, tell me, Subaru. —What should I do today?”

Subaru: “…”

Emilia: “Yesterday, I finished studying in my room as you told me to do. If it’s something Subaru says, there’s no doubt I will do it. So, can you tell me what I should do today?”

—She would do what was said by Subaru; she would make no mistake if it was Subaru; she would believe in Subaru.

In response to Emilia’s words, Subaru struggled to keep his fake smile from disappearing from his face.

The smiles he had practiced in front of the mirror: the culmination of these efforts was on display here. Thanks to that, Emilia harbored no distrust or suspicion, but she

simply waited with her eyes twinkling in anticipation for Subaru's response.

Emilia, who had been unsuccessful in her attempts to overcome the Trial of the tomb, was trying to protect her heart by completely relying on Subaru. —That was only natural.

By utilizing the power of Return by Death, Subaru had completely eliminated every obstacle that stood before Emilia. Emilia mistakenly believed that it was best not to defy Subaru's words, that his trust in her was something that she could earn; he had gotten this far by doing so.

Emilia's heart clung to Subaru, and he realised that she had become so terribly unstable that no matter how many Deaths he experienced, it was already beyond the point of no return.

There were other things which could not be undone. —For example, the beautiful silver hair of Emilia, who smiled before him, had been cut completely short.

Subaru: "…"

The exact reason as to why was unclear.

However, Emilia had cut her long hair, much to Subaru's surprise. Was it to catch Subaru's attention, or maybe to reduce the time and effort spent on grooming?

Or perhaps, did she do it to look closer to the "Sleeping Beauty" whom Subaru often frequented?

All of these were speculations. He did not know the answer. There was no turning back.

But still, Subaru did not consider this situation to be the worst.

Subaru: "Well then, I have a request for Emilia-tan. Today, just like yesterday, keep up with your studies! If I do something important again, I'll let you know in advance."

Emilia: "Like in Pristella?"

Subaru: "Yeah, just like in Pristella. Until then, you need to keep your spirits up. Preparing for an emergency, and boosting your own morale, those are assuredly the most important things Emilia-tan can do right now."

Emilia: "Mmm, understood, Subaru-sensei. I will do as ordered. So, could you—"

Emilia enthusiastically agreed with Subaru, who had put on somewhat playful theatrics. Emilia had accepted his command with something resembling a salute, then, as her words trailed off at the end,

Emilia: "—So, if I do that properly, could you stroke my head?"

Peeking up at Subaru, Emilia spoke this with anxiety and embarrassment in her eyes.

Subaru gasped at the sight of her, and for a moment he stood stock still. If that moment continued for any longer, it would not be hard to imagine despair creeping into Emilia's eyes.

But, fortunately, Subaru put on a smile before that could happen,

Subaru: "Isn't it obvious? Rather, shouldn't I be the one asking for legal permission to touch Emilia-tan's hair?"

Emilia: "—? If Subaru wants to touch it, he can touch it any time he wants…"

Subaru: "I'm! Saying!! That also would be a reward, so I shouldn't. When good things happen, then I promise to do so. I will pet Emilia-tan. OK?"

Emilia: "Mhm, *ohh kei*."

Subaru flashed a brilliant smile in confirmation and gave her a thumbs up, to which Emilia nodded awkwardly. And then, reluctantly, still holding Subaru's hand in hers—

Emilia: "Alright, I'll go back to my room."

Subaru: "Aaah, I'll have Petra bring some food up, so let's eat together."

Emilia: "Yes, I'll be waiting. Well, I'll see you later, okay?"

Waving her hand, Emilia walked back into her room. —Watching her hair, which had now been cut short, sway sadly, Subaru resisted the urge to let out a long sigh.

Before long, the door closed shut with a sound behind her, and the connection between Subaru and Emilia was physically severed.

Echidna: "Good grief, even ugliness has bounds."

Subaru: "…"

As soon as Emilia was out of sight, Echidna started her abuse. To those words, smeared in revulsion, Subaru gave no reply.

From the time he had entered into this relationship with Echidna, he had come to learn to never exchange words with her concerning the harsh way she treated Emilia.

If he did not speak, she would not speak.

If Subaru maintained that stubborn attitude, the Witch would perceive it as futility, and would remain silent.

Only regarding Emilia, could Echidna not be relied upon.

And, concerning the relationship between Subaru and Emilia, even though it did not seem to have changed from before, it still was different than it was, but he did not have the time to fix it currently.

Echidna: "It would be more convenient for you if she were but an obedient doll, would it not?"

Subaru: "—Hk."

His throat choked at her cruel remark, and Subaru regretted his reaction.

They were words that should not have been affirmed, but they were words that could not be denied.

To protect life; to protect the future; to protect hope; to protect possibility.

For this reason, he would sacrifice Emilia's Present heart.

And, that it would not be limited to Emilia alone, Subaru was well aware of this fact.

9

Everyone would gather together, and share a meal with one another.

That simple rule of the Emilia Camp had over time become meaningless, with hardly anyone adhering to it.

Subaru: "Sorry, Petra. We'll be having our meal in Emilia's room."

Petra, who was in charge of the meals, looked disappointed when Subaru informed her of this. However, she quickly masked her disappointment, and carried Subaru and Emilia's meal to her room.

For Emilia, who was mentally unstable, there was an ironclad rule that no one else was to accompany her during her meals.

Emilia: "Subaru, here, ahhhh~"

In the same manner that Subaru would spoil Emilia, during their meals, Emilia would indulge Subaru as well. Amidst this interaction, and occasionally supporting Emilia whenever she wavered, the breakfast had come to an end.

Afterwards, as per Subaru's instructions, Emilia went to her desk, determined to study diligently.

Emilia: "I need to do exactly what Subaru says to become a great King."

Cheering on that adorable, self-motivated Emilia, Subaru left her room.

Having had some of Roswaal's official work delegated to her, Emilia's knowledge for the Royal Selection far surpassed that of the first time he had met her. The fruits of her effort were ripening day by day.

However—

Echidna: "Regardless of what she does, in the end, she will always come to seek your approval. An awfully interesting way to raise a King."

Subaru: "Shut up."

Echidna: "You too are harboring unease concerning it. I know you are always wavering about whether she should be allowed to ascend the throne in her current state. However, you have no other choice but to do so."

Having left Emilia's room, Echidna's words dripped poison into Subaru's ears as he walked down the mansion's corridors.

It was true that Emilia's psyche had become unstable, and the willpower she had at the start of the Royal Selection had been greatly shaken. Nevertheless, she would certainly sit upon the Kingdom of Lugunica's throne.

None other than Natsuki Subaru would make it so.

By Returning by Death repeatedly, he would remove every hardship from before her, every impediment standing in her way, so that Emilia's ambitions would be fulfilled.

And, by doing so, he would not only support Emilia, but also save Rem.

Supporting Emilia, saving Rem, keeping those dear to him away from harm. —Was this not the exact future that Natsuki Subaru had hoped for when he made the Contract with the Witch?

—I am sorry, Natsuki-san. This is where we must say farewell.

Subaru: "…"

Suddenly, a voice resonated not within his eardrums, but within his own memories, halting Subaru's steps.

Turning his head around, he saw no one in his surroundings. He thought it perhaps was just the poor humor of the Witch, but it could not have been her thought waves. It was something else entirely: it was a call from his own memories.

The voice continued.

—As for me, Natsuki-san. Even through all of this, I thought of you as my benefactor. I thought of you as a person to whom I owed a great debt, one which I wished to repay any way I could.

The voice continued.

—But, I see your decision, and I understand it. You do not want anyone's help; on the contrary, you try, and somehow accomplish everything on your own.

The voice continued.

—Therefore, this is my way of returning the favor. Since you probably will try to protect everyone close to you, I will take my leave.

The voice continued.

—Well then, goodbye, Natsuki-san. Take care of yourself.

The voice continued.

—I thought of you as my friend.

The voice continued.

—Although, that must not have been the case for you.

Subaru: "—HK!"

Just as the last of these words resounded in his mind, Subaru punched the wall next to him with all of his might. A hard thud resounded throughout the corridor, and Subaru's fist cracked pitifully.

As blood dripped from his knuckles, Subaru exhaled raggedly and put his other hand to his head.

In this moment, he could not forget them, the parting words of Otto Suwen.

Having saved the Sanctuary and the mansion, having survived a life-threatening commendation ceremony, and having overcome numerous challenges, Otto said those words to Subaru before departing the mansion.

Even though more than a year had passed since then, the vision of him walking away never disappeared.

It seemed as if he had condemned Subaru for choosing to save everyone.

Echidna: "But, you made no attempt to stop him. In actuality, the fact that there are fewer people for you to protect has only been a blessing for you."

Subaru: "You're wrong. It's not like I didn't stop him for such calculating reasons. It's just, that I respected his wishes. From the start, he was a guy who had no reason to stay here."

He was attempting to repay him for purchasing his cargo and rescuing him from the Witch Cult.

But, when it came to reimbursement, the debt was settled the moment he had driven the dragon carriage to save Emilia, who was about to be blown away by a time bomb.

And as for the cargo, once the proper payment had been exchanged, this debt, also, was no longer owed.

For Otto Suwen, there was no reason to cooperate with the Emilia Camp.

If he were to continue staying there without such a motive, he would need a reason that went above and beyond what led to him leaving to continue his life as a travelling merchant, something that could only exist for him within this place.

Therefore, he did not stop him when he decided to leave. Besides, even though Otto's Divine Protection of the Soul of Language was useful, it was not indispensable for winning the Royal Selection.

In the first place, if he continued to be associated with the Emilia Camp, he would still be in danger from both the Witch Cult and the Royal Selection. It was better for Otto to leave this place

He had not heard any rumors of him since then. Their relationship was shallow to begin with; it was of no consequence.

Natsuki Subaru had others he had to protect by sacrificing his life.

Subaru: "…"

Stepping on the dripping blood, Subaru shook his head and started to walk away.

Recently, his thoughts were violated in this way by things that were out of his control. It was frustrating. It was irritating. And above all, Echidna seemed to be enjoying it.

There were countless things to consider. He had no time to brood within his own mind.

He needed to choose the best, the very best, the greatest, the ideal, the optimum choice.

And despite that—

Subaru: "…"

Stepping quickly through the corridor, Subaru returned to his room. He could not allow anyone, even inadvertently, to see his face right now.

Natsuki Subaru is calm, Natsuki Subaru is rational, Natsuki Subaru is optimistic; there is nothing different about him than usual.

So that things could remain as they were, everyone in the mansion must believe such things.

Otherwise, he would not be able to protect those he wished to protect—.

???: "—Oh my, you seem to have returned in a hurry."

He entered the room, and as soon as he locked the door behind him, Subaru's head shot up in shock.

Seeing Subaru's excessive reaction, the figure sitting on his bed smiling sweetly, gently stroking her hand across her long, braided hair.

???: “I thought I’d arrived on time, but you glaring at me like that is quite troubling.”

Subaru: “—Elsa.”

Elsa: “Yes, that’s correct. The Bowel Hunter, Elsa Granhiert, at her master’s request has come as quickly as she could—I’m not bothering you, am I?”

Articulating so, tilting her head seductively was a beautiful woman dressed in a rather revealing black garment that exposed her feminine body—an assassin with a bewitching yet poisonous aura, Elsa.

After his initial surprise, Subaru readily accepted the presence of the woman who had entered his bedroom without warning. There was no reason for him to panic.

After all, she was not his enemy. She had been once before, but that was all in the past now.

Subaru: “Now, I’m your collaborator… that is, unless you’re holding a grudge over the fact that I fed you to the Rabbit.”

Elsa: “That was an unforgettable experience. Besides, you rescued me before I was digested as Rabbit food. So, I’m not holding any grudges against you for that.”

Echidna: ““For that”: that is quite the loaded statement.”

As she sat on the bed, Elsa’s black eyes shimmered bewitchingly. Subaru tensed under her unfathomable gaze, yet Echidna’s tone remained unchanged as she whispered.

Echidna’s observation was not a nitpick, but rather an accurate assessment.

In order to repel Elsa’s attack on the mansion, Subaru had lured the Great Rabbit and had used it to overwhelm her with sheer numbers. Afterward, he had saved her from the brink of death, making her indebted to him.

However, he did not believe that this alone was enough to control this dangerous individual.

Subaru: “That’s why Meili remains a hostage. My loyal subordinates are keeping an eye on her.”

Elsa: “…I know that without you needing to remind me. To be honest, I’m quite angry about it, but I have no complaints about the job itself. I also have no objections to you being my employer.”

Touching the hilt of her *kukri* knife at her waist, Elsa licked her lips with her red tongue.

Contrary to her words, the pressure she exuded was capable of slicing Subaru’s neck at any moment. —The only thing holding her back was the presence of Elsa’s sister, Meili, who was currently held captive.

She was in a separate location from the mansion, where the duplicates of Ryuzu—Pico and the others, were taking turns keeping watch. She was not being treated poorly.

Subaru: “It’d be far too risky for me now to let you go.”

Elsa: “Even with the Sword Saint at your disposal, it seems I’ve been valued quite highly.”

Subaru: “Somebody’s gotta do the dirty work, don’t they?”

As Subaru responded in a lowered voice, Elsa placed her hand over her mouth and chuckled.

Currently, Elsa was secretly cooperating with the Emilia Camp, working behind the scenes.

—The leader of the camp, a symbol of purity who could not be tainted: Emilia.

—Lauded as the Sword Saint, with an unwavering reputation: Reinhard.

—And, averting numerous challenges with zero casualties, and overcoming many obstacles: Natsuki Subaru.

As a result of these accumulated reputations, Elsa had been asked to do the dirty work on behalf of Subaru and the others who were unable to do it freely. Of course, even though it was referred to as dirty work, the tasks assigned to her were not sinister activities such as assassinations or political purges.

She simply was proactively eliminating any potential obstacles or dangers that might come their way.

She had been entrusted with other tasks as well. Today's report concerned one of them.

Subaru: "So, how did it go?"

Elsa: "Sorry to report, but Gluttony was nowhere to be seen at the location you sent me to. There was nothing there but a motley crew of Witch Cultists… I helped myself to every last one of them. "

Subaru: "Aah. You're free to do whatever you want with that. …But, in the end, it was a dud?"

Subaru frowned and sighed at the report that had come from Elsa, who licked her blood-red lips.

Once again, it was a miss. Subaru's arrow had missed its target, and the target had gotten away again.

In search of the whereabouts of the Sin Archbishop of Gluttony, he had set up an information network in various locations, hunting down every Witch Cultist from one end to the other; yet, Gluttony was nowhere to be found.

Subaru: "In the end, the only one we've killed is Greed."

Elsa: "That, and Wrath was captured. I think that was a success, but I guess it might not be for you."

Subaru: "…Anyway, I got your report. For now, remain on standby until I need you again. If there's anything I need to ask of you, I'll contact you again."

Elsa: "Yes. Understood. By the way, I'd like to meet with Meili…"

Subaru: "—You can't. But, I won't hold her captive forever. At most, you'll need to be patient until the Royal Selection is settled."

Rejecting Elsa's request, Subaru emphasized the duration of their agreement. In response, Elsa replied with a brief "Yes, I understand", and headed straight for the window rather than the door.

Since Subaru's room was on the third floor of the mansion, she had probably entered through that window. It was not surprising that she managed to pull off such a feat of acrobatics—

Subaru: "Ah, wait, Elsa. There's one more thing I want you to ask you."

Elsa: "—? What may that be? I don't really know anything of much importance."

Subaru: "It's nothing that important. Since you came from outside… how was the weather beyond the forest? Was it raining or anything?"

Elsa: "The weather? Ah, there was no problem with it whatsoever. The clouds are a bit thick, but there's no need to worry about it getting worse. Is that all?"

Subaru: "No…"

Twisting his head to the side, Subaru gazed at the Magic Time Crystal in his room. Right now, it was already Fire Time—it had gone past seven Bright Time, and was now just after lunchtime.

After confirming this, Subaru walked over to Elsa, her feet still planted on the windowsill,

Subaru: "I want to ask you to do something. —Please, cut off my head with that knife."

Elsa: "—Your head… I wonder, have you lost it already?"

Subaru: "I'm being completely sane, okay? I'm just asking you to do something that has to be done."

Curiously widening her eyes at Subaru's remarks, Elsa emanated a fierce aura. But, Subaru's attitude remained unflinching.

Seeing his imposing manner, Elsa shrugged her shoulders.

Elsa: "Generally speaking, most people who have their heads cut off usually die."

Subaru: "I suppose I also fall under that category. I'm not sure about you, though."

Elsa: "I think I too would die if my head were to come off… Are you sure about this?"

Subaru: "Don't worry, this won't cause any harm to Meili. I'll have someone bring you written instructions later so you'll know where Meili is. Is that okay?"

As Subaru assuaged her concerns with his reassuring words, Elsa contemplated for a moment. However, after only a few seconds of thought, she slowly unsheathed her weapon—

Elsa: "Do you have any last words?"

Subaru: "Make it painless."

Elsa: "…"

Subaru: "Ah. I told you about Meili, but you can do whatever you want with my guts after I'm dead. Just don't lay a finger on anyone in the mansion. Well, I guess that's why I have Reinhard arou—"

Before he could finish saying those words, Elsa's arm sliced through the air.

For just a moment, Subaru's field of vision was turned upside down. As his view of the room spun around, he watched as blood splattered all over that familiar room,

and,

—Ah, cleaning this room is going to be hard on Petra.

And, with that thought, Subaru's life blinked out.

10

—When he woke up from his hollow dreams, Subaru always experienced a suffocating sensation.

However, this time, his release from there was much quicker.

Perhaps, it was because Natsuki Subaru was being reconstructed in a manner different from him waking from sleep.

Subaru: "…"

Subaru jerked up violently, placing his hand against his sweat-drenched forehead. It was cooler than the perspiration typical of sleep, closer to the cold sweat that flowed when faced with the shock of losing his life.

In any case, Subaru's body was atop the sofa in his own room, and sunlight was streaming in through the window.

Subaru: "…Morning, huh?"

Touching his neck which should have been cut, Subaru rose slowly. Cocking his head, making sure that his head had not fallen to the floor inadvertently, he checked the time using the Magical Time Crystal above his door.

The Crystal was glowing a pale green, indicating that it was currently early morning.

Then, the question that remained was "which" morning it was—.

Subaru: "…"

To confirm this, Subaru quickly pulled out the Magic Crystal around his neck.

As he clutched the ticket that connected this dream world with reality, the tapping of this foot, as if he were in a rush, overlapped with hot pulses, and Subaru's consciousness was engulfed by a white light.

Subaru: "…"

When he opened his eyes, Subaru was once again standing in the middle of the vast grassy plain.

Turning around, he saw a hill, and under a parasol atop that hill, a Witch clad in black faced a white table, gracefully sipping from her cup.

Ascending the hill, he headed towards the Witch.

Subaru: "Hey, what day…"

Echidna: "…"

Placing his hands on the table, he snarled at the Witch who continued her elegant tea-time. However, she replied not, and simply pointed silently at the seat across from her.

The seat was empty, and a cup of tea had been prepared for a visitor. What she had presented to Subaru was the minimum requirement for participating in her tea party—.

Subaru: "Damn it, I guess I should just drink it, I'll drink it!"

Grabbing the cup whilst clicking his tongue, Subaru gulped down all of the cup's contents in one swig. Instantly, the heat of the freshly brewed tea burned his throat.

Subaru: "Ghhhuaa—!?"

Echidna: "Whoaa!? Just a second, just a second! You do know that there was really no need for that?"

Subaru: "Shut up! You play the part of a difficult to please Witch, and this only happened because you insist on making me follow such complicated procedures… ghha, ghhk gh!"

As Subaru choked on the tea he had swallowed, even Echidna hurriedly stood up from her seat. She then placed her hand on Subaru's back, and continued to rub his back until his coughing subsided.

Then, after a moment of Subaru's sputtering,

Subaru: "Ghha, ack… ah, I've calmed down… eh, what about the tea?"

Echidna: "Ah, it is fine this time. Also, there is no fun in having you spit out the tea that I worked so hard to brew. And, the table too, it would be a pity to leave it stained like this."

Echidna shook her head as Subaru, wiping his mouth, tried to correct his transgression.

Then, with a snap of her fingers, the table that was sullied with the tea Subaru had spit out dissipated, quickly transforming the scene under the parasol into a desolate landscape.

Echidna: "Come now, you even dirtied the chair a bit. Making me stand here to talk to you, what a very sinful man you are."

Subaru: "I was just choking on my tea and spat out. —Compared to that, we have more important things to discuss."

Cutting off the teasing words of Echidna, Subaru raised his finger.

That which he had to confirm, was only one thing.

Subaru: "What day is it today? What's the month and date?"

Echidna: "—Hmm. From that question, I assume you have returned again?"

Subaru: "Yeah. Yes, that's right. I just want to be sure of the date. What is it?"

While holding out his Magic Crystal, Subaru asked this of Echidna, who fully understood the situation. Receiving the Magic Crystal, Echidna nodded before beginning to share in his Memories.

Echidna: "The month is Kisdam, the date is the fourteenth."

Subaru: "…"

Echidna: "Judging by your expression, it would appear you are half excited and half bewildered."

Upon seeing Subaru's reaction, Echidna closed one eye curiously. Subaru nodded with a "Yeah" at her question, his eyes half excited and half bewildered.

Returning to the morning of the day he had Returned by Death was something he had desired. However, it also hinted at the possibility of other anxieties—

Echidna: "*Myon myon myon myon myon*…"

Pressing the proffered Magic Crystal against her forehead, Echidna began her goofy inheritance of Memories.

While witnessing this Witch's ritual, Subaru righted the chair he had overturned, and sat down heavily.

He had some concerns. However, being able to return to this very morning was fortunate. Since the events that had transpired were still fresh in his memory, it would not have been too difficult to positively correct the situation.

Subaru: "There shouldn't be a problem with Petra, but during morning practice I told Reinhard and Garfiel some unnecessary things. I'll be more careful with that. Also, if I get scratched by Beatrice, it'll upset Emilia. But, Beatrice hasn't spoken to me in a while, so…"

He wanted to visit the Forbidden Library and exchange words with Beatrice as much as possible.

Even if that exchange would be a painful rejection of Subaru in a sorrowful, tearful voice.

Subaru: "Roswaal is the same as usual, and Ram too… ah, she's going to bring up Frederica in regards to Annerose's letter, so I gotta come up with a clever response. Also, with Emilia—"

He had to tread carefully, as Emilia could easily go out of control if she saw Subaru's wounds. However, if he were to deal with the situation in Beatrice's room from before, Emilia would no longer go berserk.

Yet, he did not want to miss the opportunity to talk to Beatrice. Even if he got scratched, would Emilia remain calm so long as he hid his wounds?

Subaru: "Emilia, Emilia, Emilia…"

Were there any oversights, any mistakes, any irreversible problems?

Reflecting on his half of a day, recalling, recalling, recalling—

Echidna: "—Natsuki Subaru."

As Subaru began to overheat in thought, without him noticing, Echidna, standing by his side, touched his cheek.

It appeared that the inheritance of Memories had completed. Echidna gently placed the Magic Crystal back around Subaru's neck as his eyes widened,

Echidna: "If there is anything you wish to talk about, I shall listen to anything."

And, that was all she said.

Subaru: "…"

Hearing those words, Subaru took a short breath and squeezed his eyes tightly shut.

In that quietness, he could feel his feverish thoughts start to calm down. He was okay now; he was fine. It was true that he was so distressed that he felt as if his heart might crack and shatter.

Subaru: "I can handle this much on my own… Thank you."

Echidna: "—. How surprising. For you to thank me so honestly, you must have been feeling very weak-hearted."

Raising her eyebrow, Echidna's words caught Subaru off guard.

He wanted to correct letting those words of gratitude reflexively slip out as some kind of mistake, but the spontaneity made it seem all the more genuine, making it impossible to remedy.

This sensation was something that Subaru had feared. It was something he did not want to put into words.

—He felt more at ease in the dream world with Echidna, than he did in reality where Emilia and his friends were awaiting him.

But such a thing should absolutely not be allowed to happen.

Subaru: "…"

Echidna: "Well, that is fine. Just seeing that expression on your face is enough of a reward for me."

Gazing at Subaru, who was silently attempting to cover things up, Echidna said this with a teasing tone.

It was extremely uncomfortable, as if she could see right through him, but the more Subaru pursued the matter, the more disadvantageous it would be for him. So, Subaru did not press the issue any further.

More importantly—

Subaru: "If you've inherited my Memories, then you should understand. The save point has moved. That means…"

Echidna: "—Another problem that threatens your life is fast approaching."

Echidna was quick to grasp the situation, and Subaru nodded with a tense expression.

The checkpoint for Return by Death always updated when Subaru was in danger. If Return by Death had reset him to this morning, then a life-threatening situation would arise shortly.

Once again, if Death were to befall Natsuki Subaru—

Subaru: "I'm going to have to borrow your strength again."

Echidna: "Well, that is what our Contract is all about… Nevertheless, there is just one thing…"

Subaru: "What is it?"

Catching on to her hesitant words, Subaru prompted Echidna to continue. Then, while Echidna twirled her fingers in her long, white hair,

Echidna: "Perhaps I am mistaken, but… you seem to be having a little bit of fun, are you not?"

Subaru: "—. Don't say such stupid things."

Subaru snorted in response to her outrageously ridiculous statement.

It was ridiculous, a truly ridiculous thing to say. There was no way something so stupid could be true.

To think that he would find more comfort with the spiral of Death engulfing him, repeating trial and error to escape from it, than he would in peaceful and ordinary days spent with Emilia and his friends.

Subaru: "At best, I'll be counting on you, Witch of Greed."

Echidna: "And you, for the sake of satisfying my boundless curiosity, please do your best."

Ignoring the budding turmoil in his heart, Subaru was ready to take on Echidna and the challenge ahead.

Perhaps it could be said that he had an opportunity for a preemptive strike due to the unexpected update of Return by Death's checkpoint.

Subaru: "If I were to use Return by Death to make the first strike, could it be useful for a surprise attack?"

Echidna: "It is a rather rare opportunity. I certainly hope to make good use of it. — Oh, and…"

Subaru: "Yeah?"

Calling out to Subaru as he was about to go off to battle, Echidna pointed to the Magic Crystal hanging around his neck.

Echidna: "Even after reading your memories, I still cannot understand: why did you Return by Death?"

Subaru: "Ah, that. That was because—"

The answer was—

11

Passing through the door of the dream world, Natsuki Subaru's consciousness returned to reality.

Subaru: "…"

Looking above the door of his room, the time shown by the Magical Time Crystal remained the same as it was before. As usual, feeling uncomfortable about the difference between the time he had perceived and time in reality, Subaru headed towards the bathroom.

He washed his face, brushed his teeth, practiced smiling, and quickly changed his clothes.

And, just as he had finished—

???: "Subaru-sama, are you awake—wah?"

Subaru: "Hey, good morning, Petra. You're looking cute this morning, too."

The door opened abruptly, and Petra stood there on the other side, her eyes wide open. But, after quickly realizing that Subaru was just teasing her, she smiled shyly.

Petra: "Jeez, please don't surprise me like that."

Subaru: "I'm sorry, I'm sorry. Well, Petra. Aren't you going to greet me?"

Petra: "Really, you don't regret what you did even a little? Hmph… yes, good morning, Subaru-sama. Today is once again a splendid morning, you know."

Without mentioning Subaru's frivolous attitude, Petra continued with a lovely smile. Her words were exactly the same as that morning before he had Returned by Death.

That being so, the next thing she would say would be exactly the same.

Subaru: "I agree, it's indeed a splendid morning. Petra is cute today, too; I don't even need to say it."

Petra: "Subaru-sama's still saying such things.… Ah, but there are clouds hanging over the sky beyond the forest, and it seems that the weather may get worse this afternoon. I have plans to go shopping this afternoon, so I hope it'll stay sunnyyy."

He listened to the girl talk about what she wanted to do, speaking in a manner which befitted her age; Subaru let out a laugh. Seeing this, Petra puffed out her cheeks, but he hastily replied with a "I'm sorry, I'm sorry" and continued to speak—

Subaru: "But, rest assured, Petra. Today will stay sunny all day. The clouds are giving off a false impression and won't be a problem. I can say that confidently."

Petra: "Huh? Really? That's super helpful… But, how do you know that?"

Subaru: "Well, that's because…"

Petra inclined her head and widened her eyes at Subaru's assertion.

Giving her a smile that showed his teeth, Subaru answered the girl's query.

Subaru: "—Because I returned just for this, putting my life on the line for it."

12

—A plain of green, a small hill, a white-haired Witch in a mournful black dress sitting at a white table under a parasol, gracefully tilting her cup.

Echidna: "Using one's own life, to save, to protect, to prevent others from being hurt. How great a feat it is to do so not just once, or twice, but repeatedly."

Letting out an exhilarated sigh, the Witch recalled the image of a boy with whom she was Contracted.

Desperately pursuing his ideals, pressing onward despite being struck endlessly by reality, possessing the most wretched Authority of Return by Death as his own, a lovable *human* who continued to fight with all of his might.

Echidna: "—But that Authority is a double-edged sword. Too little regard for one's own life, and one becomes too fixated on the value of lives other than their own. Sacrificing one's own life, desperately trying to protect the lives of those precious to

them… over time, they cannot focus on anything "except" for the lives of those loved ones. That is…"

No matter when, no matter where, that singular attitude of clinging onto one thing was downright foolish.

And, to be foolish, to be ignorant, to be knowable.

Echidna: "—You truly are, someone desirable to me."

Cheeks reddening like a maiden in the throes of infatuation, the Witch longed for the absent boy.

Through the Magic Crystal connected to his Gate, she felt the boy's world as if it were her own.

Was he aware of his own dependence on the Witch? He was willing to Return by Death simply to check the weather, unaware of such a mentality.

Echidna: "But, please rest assured. The lives of those whom you treasure, I will wholeheartedly protect them. I will support you with all of my wisdom. So, for this reason, you too—"

—To satisfy this Witch's inexhaustible curiosity, I want you to continue being my accomplice.

Times of hardship and unreasonable fate would continue to befall this boy endlessly.

No matter how arduous the hardships, how insurmountable the heights, the boy and the Witch would overcome, lending one other strength and wisdom, hand in hand.

Offered by the Witch of Greed was that *love* of scorching flame.

Echidna: "Ah, even so—"

Feeling the pain in the hearts of the people the boy scrambled to protect, pain that resulted from being protected by that boy, through the boy's Gate, the Witch sighed.

A proposition that would remain sempiternally unsolved, even in death; an enigma that would eternally enthrall her.

Ah, even so—

Echidna: "—Why must love fade?"

END

Afterword

Yes, this is the afterword of the bonus novel which comes as a bonus for purchasing the full-volume Blu-ray set!

First of all, thank you for accompanying me up to this point! It's me, Tappei Nagatsuki, also known as the grey-colored cat!

The story this time, as those familiar with the web version may already know, is the novelized version of the popular "April IF".

On the first of April each year, on Natsuki Subaru's birthday, an extra chapter which diverges from the main storyline is published. These IF stories are ambitious works that depict a Subaru who makes choices which diverge from the main story, along with the changes in the characters around him and how the conclusion of the story differs.

This installment, "Accreting in Another World from Zero" branches off from the fourth arc of the main story; in volume 12 of the novel, or episode 37 of the anime, Echidna offers him a Contract, and this is the pattern in which he does not refuse it.

Upon learning about Return by Death, Echidna may seem to be the perfect partner for Subaru, as a woman of wisdom in whom he can confide; however, as those of you who have read the story will know, the number of Deaths which Subaru accretes exceeds a hundred times that of the main story.

The reason behind this is the verbally manipulative Echidna, who steers Subaru into accreting numerous different experiences with deceitful words.

Yet, it is not out of malice, but rather her simply using any means necessary to satiate her own thirst for knowledge. In truth, she even helps by thinking of proper ways to overcome obstacles, leaving Subaru unaware of her underlying intentions.

However, the Subaru in Kasaneru, in his desperation to save the lives of those dear to him, ends up neglecting everything except for those "lives", and as a result, how does the future he obtains compare to that of the main story?

Does taking the Witch's hand truly lead him to a happy future? That, I shall leave up to you, the reader, to decide.

Now then, thank you for staying through to the end of this full-volume Blu-ray set purchase bonus novel. Re:Zero − Starting Life in Another World is, I believe, able to continue living on as a truly fortunate work thanks to all of your support.

I hope you'll continue to stay with us and witness the story of the Re:Zero world as it unfolds. As the original author, I will continue to put everything I have into writing the most compelling story that I can.

Well then, no matter the medium, I look forward to seeing you again soon!

Please, continue to enjoy the story from here on out! Thank you very much!

(Having finished writing the bonus novel for the Blu-ray, with gratitude and a sense of accomplishment.)

CLOSING DIALOGUE

Echidna: "*Myon myon myon myon myon*…"

Subaru: "—. I've been thinking about this for a while now."

Echidna: "Yes? What is it? If something is on your mind, feel free to speak. We are in this together, no? Why would you become shy about it now??"

Subaru: "Don't phrase it in a way that grates my nerves every time… What is this "*Myon myon*" thing?"

Echidna: "—? Nothing at all, it is merely a ritual for reading your memories from the Magic Crystal."

Subaru: "Not that, I'm talking about that lackluster chant. Why "*Myon myon myon*"?"

Echidna: "Oh, that. It would seem that, before I was born, there was a magic user who made quite the name for herself in an era when magic had yet to be systematized."

Subaru: "Oh, really? Someone like that… are they related to this?"

Echidna: "Yes. The name of that person is Myonmyon."

Subaru: "Myonmyon!! That was a person's name!!!!"

Echidna: "So, when those who received her instruction would use magic, they would chant this to remember the words of their master…"

Subaru: "So, you mean that Myonmyon was the master's name?"

Echidna: "That is how it is. I suppose that mystery has been solved?"

Subaru: "Now that I've solved it, I guess it was a mystery I didn't really need to be bothered with…"

Echidna: "Hey now, you have me explain it to you, and now you say this? What a terrible boy you are."

Subaru: "And you, who continually accompanies this terrible boy, also have a strange taste."

Echidna: "Hehe… well, what do you think? Do you regret it?"

Subaru: "Regret what?"

Echidna: "That day, the day in which you took my hand. That is how you have gotten to where you are now."

Subaru: "—No, I don't regret it. This, was the best choice I could have made."

Echidna: "…Huh?"

Subaru: “Don’t be such a pushover, Echidna. You and I are in this together. No matter how many times, how many dozens, how many hundreds of times it takes to redo, I’m taking everyone with me into the future. You’re gonna have to tag along for the ride, too.”

Echidna: “My my, I had nearly forgotten. You have quite the talent for flirting with Witches, no?”

Subaru: “It’s not a good idea to start a rumor mill… Hey, you’re not gonna continue with “*Myon myon*”?”

Echidna: “That is correct. For the time being, I would rather talk to the you of the present than delve into the you of the past.”

Subaru: “…I see. Do as you please. Wicked Witch.”

Echidna: “Oh, but of course. —I, am quite the Wicked Witch, am I not?”